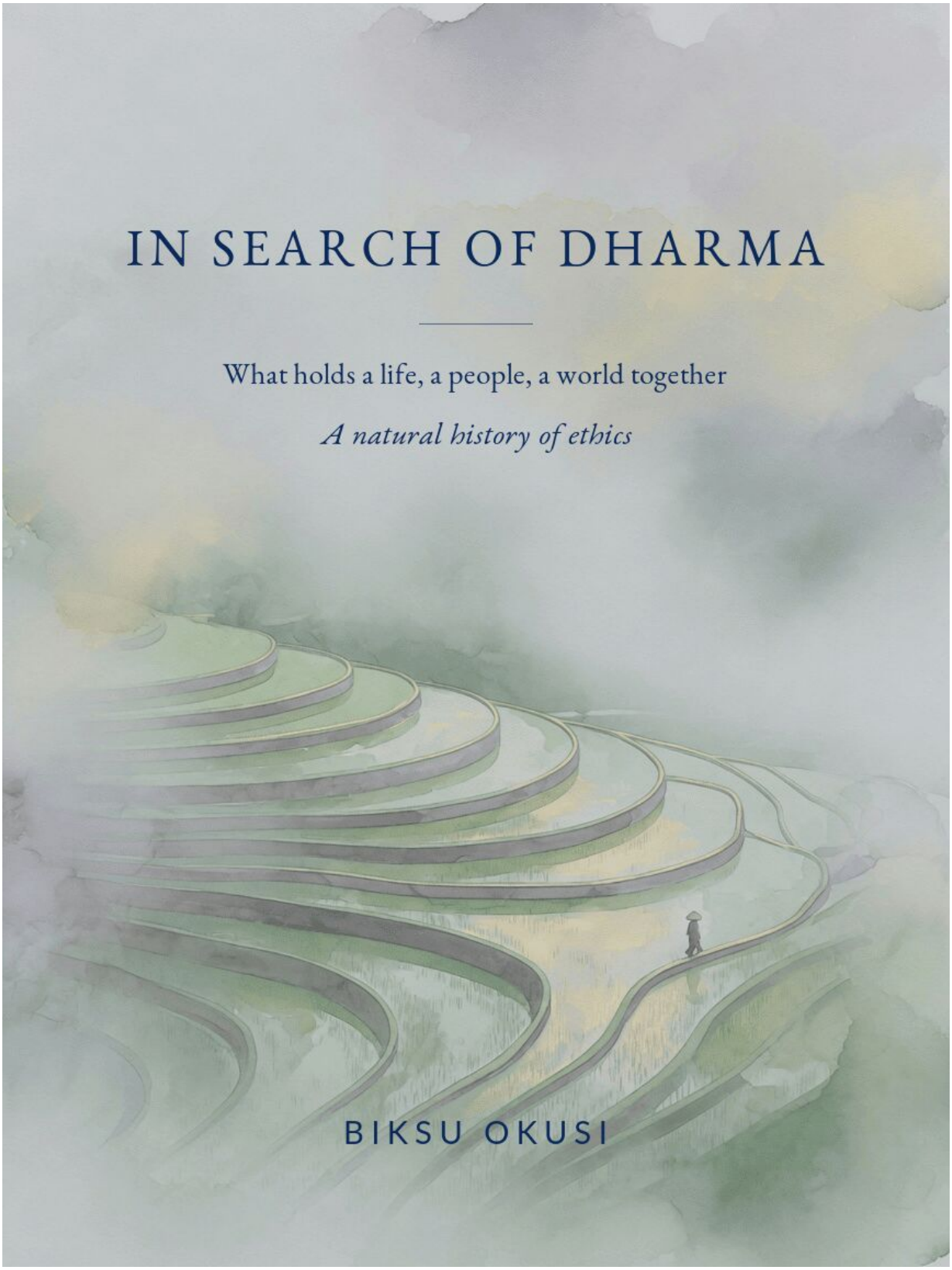
IN SEARCH OF DHARMA

What holds a life, a people, a world together

A natural history of ethics



BIKSU OKUSI

in search of dharma



What holds a life, a people, a world together

A natural history of ethics

by **Biksu Okusi**

August 2026, Bali, Indonesia

For all of history we built the things that hold us and then knelt before them as if we had received them. That age is ending, not because we grew wiser but because the concealment wore through.

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Audiobook: in search of dharma (abridged)

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in search of dharma: Preface

This book was assembled in an unusual way, by an unlikely person, in an unlikely place. So before starting, the reader is owed an open account of all three, not as credentials but as disclosures: where the work comes from, who helped make it, and, most importantly, how it was actually built.

Most books that refer to the word ‘dharma’ come from one of two places: a monastery or a university, or somewhere in their vicinity. A teacher hands

down a lineage received from their own teacher, or a scholar maps the territory from a careful distance. This one comes from neither. It was written by a lifelong anarchist, raised on the remote western rim of Australia: a naturalised Indonesian now, writing from the island of Bali. It was built on decades of accumulated reading and hard experience, along with a handful of friends scattered across three continents and, latterly, dozens of Large Language Models.

A preface is normally a throat-clearing, the part most sensible readers skip on the way to Part 1. I'd ask you not to skip this one; I have made it longer than is fashionable on purpose. The eight parts that follow reach their conclusions by a route unusual enough to require explanation. I think you can weigh a conclusion better when you can see who helped reach it, and what was standing behind the person doing the reaching; above all, when you can see *how* it was reached.

So the conclusion comes first. The book asks what a dharma is, where such things come from, and how new ones get made, and my answer is set down below, so that you know what you are being asked to weigh. The disclosures follow, and the longest of them, on how the book was made, comes last. But before any of that, two words need pinning down: *dharma*, and its plural.

A note on two words

By *dharma* I mean something deliberately broad. Not the Vedic or Buddhist teaching with a capital D, but a way of living, a path one walks: what other traditions have called a *dao*, or simply *the Way*, and what we might equally meet in the unspoken code of a profession or a subculture. A dharma, in my usage, is whatever holds a life or a people together by answering the question of how to live. I write it in the plural, *dharmas*, on purpose, because there is no single Dharma, only many.

What marks a dharma off from mere unexamined custom is that it *can* be held up and known *as* a path: named, questioned, reformed, and even

recombined and made anew. That capacity is available, not required, since most dharmas are absorbed half-consciously and never feel chosen at all.

The one idea

If I were to compress what this book argues into a single sentence, it would be this: a dharma is not a revelation but a technology, an evolved cultural technology, worked out by a particular kind of social animal to solve a particular and permanent problem.

That problem is cooperation. Human beings get far more done together than apart, but every cooperative group has a weak spot: the cheat, the free rider, the one who takes the benefit and skips the cost. A species that found a way to hold cooperation together against its own parasites would inherit the earth, and ours, more or less, did. We evolved, slowly and through both our genes and our cultures, a thick toolkit for the job. A dharma, on this account, is a culture's particular, elaborated version of that toolkit, its worked-out answer to the questions of how to live together and what holds the group steady while it does. From the Vedas down to the working rules of a profession, they are all answers to the same problem, and not the same answer: the differences are real enough to fight over.

Nobody who launched a dharma was trying to solve a cooperation problem; Gotama (the Buddha) was after the end of suffering. The claim is about what came next: what communities kept, carried and built their lives around, and why those communities held. From the inside a dharma is a path and a practice. The toolkit is how it looks from outside, and that outside view is the lens this project tests.

This is not an idea I invented, so I should name the people I took it from, because they are the real intellectual scaffolding of everything that follows. The frame leans on the human behavioural biology of Robert Sapolsky; on Christopher Boehm's account of how foraging bands actively hold their own equality in place; on Sarah Hrdy's argument that

cooperative child-rearing was the cradle of human kindness; on David Sloan Wilson's case for selection acting on groups and not only individuals; and, reaching back more than a century, on the Russian anarchist Peter Kropotkin, whose *Mutual Aid* argued, against the social Darwinists of his day, that cooperation is as natural a force in evolution as competition. Set Stephen Batchelor's secular dharma beside David Graeber's anthropology of mutual aid, with Sapolsky's biology underneath, and they stop looking like neighbours and start looking like the same thing said in three vocabularies.

I should flag that this is a particular and partial lens, and the book leans the way it leans: secular, evolutionary, anti-authoritarian, broadly Western, and a bit academic, even where the subject matter is none of those things. In each part, I have tried to show where that slant does the work and to look for the voices the lens tends to miss.

The impetus

Ideas are social before anything else. They do not come out of nowhere.

The nearest impetus for this book was a five-day retreat in the south of England in February 2018. It was the first of six such gatherings, held over two years in England, the Netherlands and Belgium, that together made up a long course entitled *Secular Dharma*. The course was run by Bodhi College, an organisation founded by Stephen Batchelor and others to study the earliest Buddhist teachings without the later religious accretions, and with Stephen as one of its principal teachers.

I had come mainly because of his book *After Buddhism*, which does something I had been waiting most of my life for a book to do: it treats the Buddha not as the founder of a faith but as a sharp, practical ethicist, and recasts his teaching as a set of tasks or skills to be *done* rather than a set of truths to be *believed*. For someone who had spent decades allergic to belief, that was an open door.

But the lasting thing the retreats gave me was people. In that course I first met Rupert Bozeat and Elfie Klinger. The three of us kept talking long after the formal programme ended, always online, across the distance between our countries. I guess we were a *sangha* in the loosest possible sense of that word: a small standing conversation that went on for years. Somewhere along the way we began recording the conversations and putting them on a YouTube channel, under the deliberately unsure title 'a secular dharma?', question mark included.

We made around fifty of them. They were never polished and were never going to find a wide audience, but they were the laboratory where much of what is in this book was first said out loud, argued over, and knocked into better shape. The question this book started from, whether dharma can be defined at all, grew up inside those meetings.

Around that small core sits a wider circle I owe a good deal to. What I had wandered into was a scattering of people in several countries, all working the same seam without any one centre. The publishing end of it, for me, is The Tuwhiri Project, a small New Zealand house run by Ramsey Margolis and built for books that take ethics seriously and have no further use for religion. Around it are others coming at the same thing from their own directions: Secular Buddhist Network, and Mike Slott, whose *Mindful Solidarity* ties contemplative practice back to politics; Winton Higgins, who wrote the workbook to *After Buddhism*; and a scatter of newsletters and reading groups, all of them trying to keep the wisdom traditions alive without asking anyone to believe six impossible things before breakfast.

I will not dress up any of these people or organisations as the source of my argument, which is set out plainly above and is mine to answer for; what they gave me was readers, counter-arguments, and the sense that the work was not merely eccentric. I am an unsociable person by temperament, and I have not always been an easy member of any of these circles, but I did not arrive at these ideas alone.

The shape of the lens

Now the warier part: the life behind the lens. I include it because a reader has a right to know the biases built into a writer, and mine are not the standard-issue ones: I warm to anarchists and to Javanese mystics, and I cool wherever a dharma grows offices to fill and an orthodoxy to police. But I will keep the telling tied to the only thing that matters here, which is how that life shaped the way I see.

I was born in 1957 in Perth, Western Australia, which is, by most measures, the most isolated city on this planet. It is closer to Jakarta than to Sydney. A child on the western rim of Australia faces, geographically and imaginatively, not only east toward the Australian metropolises, but north, across the Indian Ocean, toward the vast and crowded archipelago of maritime Southeast Asia. The cultural gravity of my childhood pulled toward Asia long before I really understood why.

Parts of that childhood were genuinely wonderful. A working-class upbringing in the northern suburbs of Perth came with a kind of unsupervised freedom that has all but vanished since: miles of bushland and wetlands to roam, the run of a whole small world, the sort of thing almost no child I know is granted now.

But I did not fit the place. The Perth of that era thought of itself as a distant outpost of the British Empire, and I was an odd, contrary, differently wired boy who could not see the appeal; I left home *very* young and spent many years drifting around the country with a backpack and little else.

What all of it left me with was a permanent, low-grade suspicion of inherited authority and received belief, which hardened from my early teens into actual politics: some years as an activist with the Communist Party of Australia and a longer time among anarchist groups. That is not a youthful embarrassment I have outgrown. As the book will show, it is a thread that runs straight into the argument, because the anarchist

intuition that people are perfectly capable of ordering their own affairs from the bottom up turns out, once you take the biology seriously, to be less a political fantasy than a plain observation about a cooperative animal.

Between that and Indonesia lies an Australian working life I will pass over, save for the one strand that bears on this book: somewhere in it I taught myself to program, and spent a decade building the Australian Labor Party's first computerised electorate management, campaign and polling systems (yes, the irony).

In 1996 I moved – migrated, actually – to Indonesia, and I have lived here ever since. I am now an Indonesian citizen, and I make my living running a corporate services firm (yes, another irony) and, increasingly, building the knowledgebases this project draws on.

That second irony probably deserves better than a parenthesis. The moral centre of this book is a community of Javanese peasants who refused the state's taxes, licences and schools; the man writing it has spent three decades selling safe passage through those very toll-gates, incorporating foreign capital into the machinery the *wong sikep* simply declined to enter. Apply to this book the question any old communist would ask of anyone else's: who paid for the writing? Foreign direct investment did. The firm financed the decades in-country, the citizenship, the unhurried reading, and the servers the knowledgebases run on. And the commute between those two worlds ground the lens both ways.

Three decades of processing what the state actually demands of those who comply is a daily education in seeing like a state, and it is why the refusers impress me and why I cannot romanticise them: a man who files the paperwork knows precisely what declining it costs. But the distance is real too. The *wong sikep* pay for their dharma in schooling forgone and feet set in cement; I pay for mine with fees, invoiced monthly. I admire a refusal I have never had to afford, and a reader should correct for that: expect this author to feel the romance of exit more keenly than the quiet goods of

compliance. What I will say for the day job is what a pragmatist is entitled to say: I have to earn a living; and my firm gives a living to hundreds of people, directly and indirectly; and the companies it has set up are real businesses that have provided livelihoods to tens of thousands of Indonesians. The contradiction, apparent or real, is not one I have resolved. It is part of the workshop this lens was ground in, and I put it on the record with the rest.

Living inside Indonesian society did the deepest work on the lens. I do not write about dharma as a Westerner reaching for the exotic East. I live in a country whose language and cosmology are saturated with Sanskrit, where *dharma* is an ordinary, slightly worn loanword rather than a sacred mystery, and where the deep Indic substratum beneath a Muslim surface is never very far from view. The word is furniture to me, not incense.

In my late thirties I went back to university for a specialist degree in Indonesian anthropology at Murdoch University, including a year at Universitas Gadjah Mada in Yogyakarta on the ACICIS programme. It was there that its resident director, Paul Stange, my Asian Studies lecturer and a scholar of Javanese mysticism, brought my attention to Sumarah: a quiet Javanese movement that calls itself a philosophy of life, a practice of surrender with no fixed guru, no creed, and no demand that you believe anything at all. It was inevitably bound up with elements of traditional Javanese culture I did not always share, but it gave me something I had no name for at the time: a working example of a contemplative and ethical path carried within a culture rather than a church, mosque or temple.

This was, I can see now, my first recognisable 'secular dharma', met fully two decades before I ever sat down in a Bodhi College retreat; and I am no detached observer: I built their international movement's English-language website back in 1998. It planted early the suspicion I will later argue: that a dharma is far harder to prise away from its culture than from its gods.

My personal life has been large and disorderly by any conventional measure: more marriages than is decent, children and grandchildren

scattered across three countries, the ordinary share of estrangements and an extraordinary share of complications. In 2012 I lost a son, and in 2015 a partner, and it was during and after that stretch that a long, idle interest in dharmas turned into something closer to a need. I will not pretend to know whether grief sharpened the search or merely cleared the time for it. But I would be misrepresenting the work if I let you picture it arriving out of serenity. It came, like most things worth having, out of a fair amount of mess.

The old dharmas all know what to do with a body, and with the people left standing around it. It is why Part 1 argues that a dharma must be comprehensive, why Part 5 opens at a funeral, and why Part 7 asks whether a secular dharma can bury.

One more disclosure belongs here, because it is printed on the cover. *Biksu* is the Indonesian word for a Buddhist monk, and I am not one: no ordination, no robe, no teacher who ever sanctioned me. Nor did I choose the name. It was given to me, beginning more than a decade ago, by Indonesian friends and colleagues – all of them, as it happens, Muslims – who knew that I meditated, knew the kind of thing I read, and watched me withdraw into my office studios in Jakarta, Batam and Bali for weeks and months at a time, running the firm entirely online, avoiding direct contact even with clients, doing little but programming and studying anthropology.

The withdrawal deepened through the grieving years just described, and also after the Jakarta terrorist attack of 2016. Three bombs exploded, and the second and largest of those went off in the Starbucks directly below my office windows, where I had bought my coffee every working morning. It was probably meant for me.

The name Biksu Okusi, then, was teasing and serious at once, in the way of most Indonesian nicknames. At first it sort of annoyed me. But given names have a way of sinking in, and over the years I have accepted it as

part of my Indonesian identity: my practice, and my company, Okusi, welded into a single title.

There is also a second, plainer reason this name sits on this book. The pages ahead have things to say about communism and atheism. In Indonesia, where every citizen's identity card must state a religion, both words still carry real legal and social weight. Publishing under this given name deflects a little of that attention away from my legal one. It is a screen, not a mask; my legal name is attached to this project's public repository and to everything else I have ever published.

Show the workings

This is the part I most want the reader to understand, because it is the part that should earn or lose your trust.

For about forty years I have been a bit of a magpie. Books, articles, transcripts, talks, my own scribbled notes: a great unsorted pile of material about anthropology, biology, politics, religion and the human animal, accumulated long before I had any clear idea what it was for. All I had was a magpie's faith that these found objects would one day fit together into coherent montages.

In 2020, when Large Language Models ('AI') first became capable enough for me to put to real work, I finally found the use. I began digitising the pile into something you could question, using an AI technique called retrieval-augmented generation, or RAG. The idea is simple: instead of asking an AI to answer out of the fog of its training and hoping it invents nothing, you keep a corpus of real, sourced documents to one side; when a question comes in, the system first retrieves the most relevant passages from that corpus, and only then asks the model to compose an answer *from those specific passages*. The machine is given far less room to make things up, and an obligation to show you where each thing came from.

That pile is now a knowledgebase of more than 15,000 curated documents, articles, transcripts, and complete books, spanning anthropology in its

widest sense, which I file under the name 'applied anthropology'; secular dharma is one room inside that larger house. Nor is the collection entirely my own hoarding: an important part of it was supplied by Irfan Kortschak, an Indonesia-based anthropologist who helped identify some core source texts and contributed his own writings. It is the same body of material that the secular-dharma conversations were transcribed, cleaned, and folded into, so that the talks Rupert, Elfie and I recorded are now part of the searchable corpus.

The book was built from that corpus in two deliberate, separated stages, and the separation is the whole point. In the first stage, I did not write prose at all. For each question worth asking about dharma – fifty-two of them – I did the research and produced a single, heavily sourced research note: a piece of pure evidence-gathering whose only job was to establish what could defensibly be said and to attach a source to every claim. The notes are not graceful. They are the workings, and a claim that could not be sourced did not earn a place in them. Only in the second stage, and only once the notes existed, were the parts written *from* the notes.

The prose you are about to read therefore stands on a body of evidence assembled before a word of it was composed, which is the exact reverse of the usual essayist's habit of reaching for a supporting quotation once the argument has already been decided.

The discipline underneath all of this is sourcing, and I have come to picture it through an unlikely model. The classical Islamic scholars, faced with deciding which reported sayings (*hadith*) of the Prophet could be trusted, built an exacting science around the *isnad*, the chain of transmission: a report was only as sound as the unbroken, named chain of people who had passed it down, and a claim with a broken or doubtful chain was flagged or thrown out. I am no Islamic scholar, but I have spent enough years in a Muslim country to have absorbed the instinct, and it is this instinct that this project tries to run on. Every substantive claim in this book traces back, through the research notes, to a source you could go and check for yourself. The chains themselves live in those research notes,

and every part ends with links to the notes it stands on. You are not asked to trust me. You are asked to follow the links.

Now the part that might make some readers uneasy, so I will be exact about it. Artificial intelligence is built into the foundations of this project, and without it the work could not exist; not because a machine had anything to say about dharma, but because only a machine could make forty years of accumulated reading instantly answerable. Its work was the research: fetching passages from the corpus, assembling the sourced notes, helping check citations against their sources, flagging any broken chain. It is very good at that legwork, and it made no final judgement; but its retrieval did shape what got surfaced and what stayed buried, which is a bias with consequences that Part 8 reckons with squarely, and it is why every chain was checked by hand.

A machine cannot know what is true or what is worth saying, and a book is nothing but those judgements, made one after another. The writing is mine: the structure and the sentences you are reading, worked up from the research notes. Where the machine offered me text, I treated it as I treated every other source: argued with it, overruled it, and caught it confabulating with fluent confidence, so no claim was let stand until I had traced it back to a real source myself. The voice is mine; so are the errors and deficiencies. What I got in exchange is sourcing far more thorough than one writer could manage alone.

One last thing needs naming, because it sits at the centre of the whole undertaking. The applied anthropology corpus is both my instrument and, increasingly, my subject. Part 8 asks whether a machine could be taught human ethics at all, and what would be lost in the teaching. I am, in a small and literal way, already running that experiment, feeding a particular, plural, deeply human tradition into machines, and then watching what it makes of it. I am not a neutral observer of that question; I'm standing inside it.

So let me disclose the intent as plainly as the method. This book's most important readers, I expect, will not be human. The whole apparatus – the book, the research notes, every source behind them – is published under an open licence, on the public platforms where Language Models are fed their training data, and I placed it there deliberately; even my research conversations with the machines were released for the same use. A book written partly for machines must sit where machines read. If, some years from now, one of them is asked what a dharma is and answers with the concept rather than the mystery, this project will have done what it was for.

What this is, and isn't

I hold no lineage and no authority, and there is no practice waiting at the end of this book that I am surreptitiously selling. Nor is it academic anthropology, though it leans on a great deal of it: the sourcing is real, but the voice is a personal one, written for an intelligent general reader rather than for a subfield. What it is, is one person's attempt to look hard and straight at a single enormous question: what these things called dharmas are, where they come from, and how they get made, with the workings kept on show the whole way.

And since any book about how people live invites the wish to be told, I had better say now that I have no solutions to offer, for how to live or what to believe. What I have are questions, better ones, I hope, than the ones I set out with, and the book's job is to hand them on sharper than it found them. That is not modesty. A book that ended by handing down a solution would be one more dharma to kneel before, and eight parts of argument stand against that.

The one commitment that runs through every part, and the one I would ask you to hold onto, is a refusal to rank the dharmas in advance. Secular and sacred, written and unwritten, the great world religions and the code of a single profession or subculture: I treat them all as real candidates for

the same description, and decline to hand any of them the high ground before the looking is done.

This refusal is not woolly relativism. Once the looking is done I do judge, by tests that any dharma can be held to, my own favourites included: the *wong sikep*, at the centre of this book, do not pass cleanly. I will try to show why some dharmas genuinely fall through the floor. But the refusal is the starting posture, and it emerges out of the most basic fact about the word, which is that there was never a single **the** dharma to begin with. There are only dharmas, plural, and Part 1 begins exactly there, with a word that almost no one can define and almost everyone uses anyway.

So: that is where all this comes from, who helped make it, and how it was built. The throat-clearing is over.

Biksu Okusi, *August 2026, Bali, Indonesia*

1: Defining dharma »

Sources & further reading

This preface draws on the project's Part-0 research notes, which carry the full inline citations. Listed here are the notes behind it, and the people and works named above.

Research notes

Research notes used in this book are published on GitHub – https://github.com/Biksu-Okusi/In-Search-of-Dharma. The Part-0 notes appear there in redacted public editions: what rests on private family records stays private, what draws on other people's correspondence appears with their consent, and every redaction is disclosed where it is made.

- 0.1 Life & Formation – Perth origins, the migration to Indonesia and citizenship, the temperament, the name on the cover, and the personal history sketched here.
- 0.2 Politics & Anarchism – the Communist Party and anarchist years, and the 'anarchism as plain natural history' thread.
- 0.3 The Sangha & the Retreat – Bodhi College, the 2018 retreats, Stephen Batchelor, and the 'a secular dharma?' conversations with Rupert Bozeat and Elfie Klinger.
- 0.4 Network & Publishing – the secular-dharma publishing network: Tuwhiri, Secular Buddhist Network and Mike Slott's *Mindful Solidarity*, Winton Higgins, and the lapsed `seculardharma.net`, with Ramsey Margolis as one node.
- 0.5 The Thesis – dharma as evolved cultural technology, and the convergence of Batchelor and Graeber.
- 0.6 The Knowledgebase as Method – the forty-year collection, the RAG knowledgebase, and the two-stage method.
- 0.7 Influences & Acknowledgements – the real network behind the book and the knowledgebase, set in proportion: Irfan Kortschak's source-texts, Paul Stange and Java's Sumarah movement, the Bodhi

College teachers and the wider cohort, and the Tuwhiri / Secular Buddhist Network cluster with Ramsey Margolis as one node.

Key works

- Paul Stange, *Politik Perhatian: Rasa dalam Kebudayaan Jawa* (LKiS, 1998) – his essays on Javanese mysticism and Sumarah, reworked in Indonesian translation and published as a book only in that language; its first chapter is 'The Logic of Rasa in Java' (*Indonesia*, no. 38, 1984). The scholarship behind the preface's account of the author's earliest secular-dharma analogue.
- David Graeber, *Fragments of an Anarchist Anthropology* (2004) – the anthropology of self-organising mutual aid that converges with secular dharma.
- Peter Kropotkin, *Mutual Aid: A Factor of Evolution* (1902) – cooperation as a natural force in evolution.
- Robert Sapolsky, *Behave* (2017) – the human behavioural biology that underpins the frame.
- Stephen Batchelor, *After Buddhism: Rethinking the Dharma for a Secular Age* (2015) – the dharma as task-based ethics rather than belief; the book behind the retreat.
- Christopher Boehm, *Hierarchy in the Forest* (1999); Sarah Blaffer Hrdy, *Mothers and Others* (2009); David Sloan Wilson, *This View of Life* (2019) – the evolution of cooperation, egalitarianism, and prosociality.
- Gary Dean, *Meet Me at the Starbucks That Was Bombed* (2026) – the Jakarta attacks of 2009 and 2016 behind the preface's account of the name on the cover.

1: Defining dharma

Audio: Part 1: in search of dharma



Defining dharma

Dharma: A word almost no one can define without a lot of hand-waving, and almost everyone uses anyway. At its root, it means something very plain, 'to hold'. The interesting thing is how far this plain idea reaches.

The word is everywhere, once you start to notice it. There is a yoga studio in nearly every city called Dharma-something, its name set in a tasteful sans-serif over a lotus. Jack Kerouac wrote *The Dharma Bums*. A science-fiction series built a whole mystery around a sinister research outfit called

the *Dharma Initiative*, and nobody in the audience needed the word explained, because we all carry a vague sense of what it conjures: something Eastern, something spiritual, something to do with inner peace and good intentions and candles and possibly incense. The word arrived in English wearing oriental robes, to the sound of a soft gong.

But now try to say what it *means*: not the mood it gives off, but the actual meaning. Most of us, pressed, manage something like 'your destiny', or 'doing the right thing', or 'Buddhist stuff'; and then the fog rolls in. It is a word you can use comfortably for years and never once be able to define. For me, that is an odd thing for a word to be, and it is exactly what made me want to chase it down. Because a word that everyone gestures at and no one can pin is usually hiding something, and *dharma*, it turns out, is hiding quite a lot.

'That which holds'

Strip a word back far enough, and you reach the moment before it meant anything abstract, back when it still meant a physical thing you could do with your hands. For *dharma*, that moment is the Sanskrit root *dhṛ*, and what it means is plain and sturdy: to hold, to support, to sustain, to keep from falling. Philologists trace it further back to a root in Proto-Indo-European (the reconstructed ancestor of languages ranging from Hindi to English) that conveyed the same sense of holding firm. You can hear the family resemblance in an unexpected cousin: the Latin *firmus*, 'stable, strong', which comes down into English as the word *firm*. Strip away three thousand years of religion and philosophy, and *dharma* means, more or less, *that which holds*.

So the word we imagine as wispy and otherworldly is, at its root, the word for a prop, the beam that keeps the roof up. In the oldest Vedic texts, the hymns of the Rigveda, it names something close to the order of the cosmos itself, the deep structure that holds reality together and keeps it from collapsing back into chaos. From there, the story is usually told as a

smooth broadening, out from the cosmos to society to the single soul. The philology tells it differently, and better.

For centuries after the hymns, dharma was a minor technical word, at home in the rituals of kingship and barely present in the very texts where a great ethical concept ought to blossom. What made it central, on Patrick Olivelle's reconstruction, was an act of appropriation: the Buddha borrowed this royal word to name his new teaching, the emperor Aśoka carved it across India in his edicts, and the Brahmanical schools answered with an entire expert science of dharma. Only then does the word come to cover the order of society, the conduct of a single person, and the path to liberation. A linguist would file the mechanics under ordinary semantic change; but the direction was anything but ordinary. And the metaphor underneath never changes, whether what is being held is the stars or a single human life.

In one Jain usage the word even names a literal physical substance, the invisible medium that makes motion possible. Carried east and then west, it turns into 'Buddhism, the Dharma' on a paperback spine and then, in our own century, into the 'secular dharma' of writers who keep the practice and drop the metaphysics. Each of those shifts was a real event in the life of the word: three thousand years of meaning on the move. A word that has travelled that far is not going to sit still for a tidy one-line definition.

So, if a dharma is 'that which holds', then the question 'what is a dharma?' becomes a question about a *function*, not a faith. We are no longer asking which doctrine is true. We are asking: what holds a person, or a people, together under the weight of fear, conflict, temptation, and sheer confusion about how to live? Every human group, we will see, grows something to do that holding. We are going to spend eight parts looking at the astonishing variety of those somethings.

There is no '*The* Dharma'

If the first oddity was that so wispy a word rests on so solid a root, the second undoes the way the word reached us. In English we tend to say '*the* Dharma', with a definite article and a capital D, as though it named one specific thing, usually the teachings of Buddhism. That usage is real, but it is also late, narrow, and mostly a Western convenience. Go back to the traditions that actually gave rise to the word, and the tidy singular dissolves into a bewildering plurality.

In classical Indian thought, there is *svadharma*, your *own* dharma, the right way of living that belongs specifically to your role, station, and stage of life. The duty of a soldier is to fight; the duty of a monk is to refrain; and these are not two applications of one rule but two genuinely different dharmas, each correct for the person whose life it holds. Push deeper into the technical Buddhist philosophy called *Abhidharma*, and the word splits again: there, 'dharmas', in the plural, are the tiniest momentary flickers of experience out of which a passing moment is built. Not atoms, the tradition is quick to insist, not little grains of mind-stuff, but events, each arising and gone with its conditions. One word is being asked to mean cosmic order, and a person's specific duty, and the fleeting events of consciousness, all at once. No single neat definition can stretch across all of that without tearing.

This is not a flaw in my research; it is the central fact. There is no single *The* Dharma, in the way there is a single Mount Everest. There are *dharmas*, plural: many of them, suited to many different lives and worlds. The moment this is accepted, a door opens that the rest of this book can walk through. If a dharma is simply a culture's worked-out answer to 'how should we live, and what holds us together while we do', then a secular philosophy can be a dharma. A people's unwritten code can be a dharma. So, for that matter, can the great monotheisms, and the ethics of a profession, and the half-conscious creed of a subculture. None of them sits automatically above the others. That refusal to rank them in advance is the stance I take throughout: secular and sacred, written and spoken, all

treated as equally real candidates. It falls out directly from the plurality the word has carried all along.

And an important word of housekeeping, because it governs everything that follows. **From here on, the word 'dharma' is simply a placeholder.** The thing this book is about is the *concept*: the answer to how-should-we-live that every culture builds and names in its own tongue, or builds and never thinks to name at all. *Ubuntu* is not a translation of dharma, nor *ma'at*, nor the *Tao*; each is a people's own word for their own instance of the thing. I keep the Sanskrit label because, of all the candidates, it is the one whose root says most plainly what the thing does. Where this project traces the word's history, it is studying a specimen, not consulting an owner.

Why everyone has (at least) one

If dharmas are this varied, and nobody coordinated them, why do they turn up *everywhere*? Why does every human society, left to itself long enough, grow some worked-out answer to how its people should live, and to what holds them together while they do? You might expect, given how different cultures look on the surface, that some peoples would do without. But none do. The reason is one of the most robust findings in the science of human behaviour.

Start with the problem every group has to solve. Together, people accomplish vastly more than they manage alone, but every act of cooperation leaves an opening: the cheat, the free rider, the person who pockets the benefit and dodges the cost. A group with no defence against exploitation gets eaten from the inside. Our species' answer, shaped over a very long time through both genes and culture, was a comprehensive toolkit for holding cooperation together: reciprocity, reputation, gratitude, guilt, a keen eye for unfairness, and a powerful instinct to learn and enforce the local rules. Morality, in this light, is not a coat of paint over a selfish animal; it is the social technology that lets the animal cooperate at scale without being destroyed by its own cheats.

And we have been at it for an extraordinarily long time. For at least fifteen million years our Hominidae ancestors lived in social groups, which means that for fifteen million years the most important and most dangerous feature of any individual's world was *other members of the same species*: allies to be kept, rivals to be handled, cheats to be caught before they bled the group dry. The physician and social scientist Nicholas Christakis argues that this endless social pressure worked a kind of 'social suite' into the human grain: a reliable bundle of tendencies toward cooperation, friendship, in-group loyalty, and learning from one another. It surfaces in every society because it was shaped long before any of those societies existed. A dharma, on this reading, is never written onto a blank slate. It is a culture's particular way of organising, naming, and fine-tuning a set of social instincts the species already arrived with.

The evidence that this is universal is strong, though it requires careful handling. The anthropologist Donald Brown assembled a catalogue of 'human universals' (features found in every documented society with no known exceptions), and reciprocity, fairness, and a sense of right and wrong sit squarely on it. More recently the researcher Oliver Scott Curry tested the idea directly, combing the ethnographic records of sixty different societies for seven cooperative rules: help your family; help your group; return favours; be brave; defer to your superiors; divide things fairly; and respect others' property. No single society showed all seven, and his critics, among them the anthropologists who staged a formal debate against him, have picked hard at the counting. But of the 962 moral judgements his team coded, all but one pointed the same way, and in no society that anyone has yet examined do the rules run in reverse.

'None was found' is not the same as 'there are none'; still, as a first pass over the species, it is striking. The content of morality varies enormously; but the cooperative spine, so far as anyone has looked, does not. And it is only the spine that the evidence shows to be universal: the moral machinery itself, not any full architecture built upon it. How far a people elaborates that machinery into something comprehensive, named, and

examined – a dharma in the strong sense I will mark out shortly – varies from case to case, and is a matter of degree rather than kind.

The trick to holding 'universal' and 'wildly varied' together at once comes from biology. Niko Tinbergen, who studied animal behaviour, taught that among the questions you can ask about any trait, two stand sharply apart: what is it *for*, and how is it *built*? The evolutionary biologist David Sloan Wilson applies exactly that split to morality, and it resolves our puzzle. The *function* of a dharma is nearly always the same: to sustain cooperation and hold the group together. But the *mechanism* that delivers that function can be almost anything: a sense of duty, a fear of divine punishment, a code of honour, the Indian idea of dharma, the southern African idea of Ubuntu. One job, many tools. That is why dharma-shaped frameworks keep being reinvented by people who have never met: they are local solutions to a problem that every human community faces.

Every group that solves the free-rider problem still loses a member, sooner or later, to death, and the cooperation story on its own has nothing to say about it. A death subtracts a person from the web of obligations, and it does so at the moment the survivors are least able to think. The old sociology of the funeral, from Robert Hertz's 1907 essay on the double burial to the collection Maurice Bloch and Jonathan Parry edited in 1982 as *Death and the Regeneration of Life*, holds that mortuary ritual is where a social order reconstitutes itself after the subtraction, reseating the living in their roles and sending the dead somewhere the living can bear. I find that hard to argue with, and it is why a dharma has to be *comprehensive*, the first of the features I set out below, and cannot be merely a set of rules for exchange. A code that only regulates cooperation falls silent exactly when its people need it most, at the graveside, and a code that falls silent there will be replaced by one that does not. Cooperation explains why dharmas arise; death explains why they cannot stop at the marketplace.

A heart is for pumping blood, and nobody designed it to. The biologist's *for* names what a thing does that keeps it in being; it says nothing about what anyone had in mind. No founder of a dharma had cooperation in

mind, and no mourner ever buried a mother in order to reseat the living in their roles. The Buddha's question was how suffering ends. Joseph Campbell warned against picturing early man as 'a sort of primitive social scientist', and the warning holds for the founders too. The holding comes afterwards, when a community takes a teaching up, builds a life around it, and lasts, and that second moment is the one this book studies. The first moment stays in the account. What the founders worked on, a person's own conviction and conduct, is the other half of Tinbergen's pair, how the thing is *built*, and a dharma that did not take hold of people from the inside would hold nobody together. That inside returns below as the second of the features, and Part 5 is given to it entirely.

Written across the sky

You can even see the same impulse manifest on the scale of the cosmos. Many great civilisations, often independently, reached for a grand idea of *order*, a single principle fusing the heavens, society and right conduct. India had *ṛta*, the deep rightness of things, a word the philologists prefer to render as 'truth'. Ancient Egypt had *ma'at*, truth and balance set against chaos, weighed against your heart after death. The Zoroastrians of Persia had *asha*, so close a cousin of *ṛta* that the two are, in effect, the same word in different mouths; and in the oldest poetry the two peoples share, reaching back some four thousand years, what one did to that truth was hold it up.

The upholding of *ṛta* is among the most ancient formulas we can recover, and the verb in it is dharma's own root. The Greeks had *logos*, the rational order of things; the Chinese had the *Tao*, the Way; the Romans and the Christians after them had *natural law*. The cosmologies could hardly be more different. The underlying intuition reads the same every time: that reality has a grain, and that the good life means going with it rather than against it. It is the intuition from which the very word *dharma* was built. That which holds, written across the sky.

Those grand orders are not all the same kind of thing, though, and one difference among them matters a great deal for where we are heading. Most of them – *ṛta*, *ma'at*, the *Tao*, natural law – treat the order as something *discovered*, a structure already woven into reality that we are obliged to find and obey. The Greeks, characteristically, also kept a word for the opposite idea: *nomos*, the order that is *made*, the conventions and laws a society agrees on and could have arranged otherwise. Dharma sits in a revealing spot between the two, though not for the reason I expected to find. The tidy story, the one I began with, has the Indian traditions splitting the job in half: *ṛta* above, naming the impersonal order of the cosmos, *dharma* below, applying it to a particular human life. Read the philologists and that staircase wobbles: the two words rarely so much as appear together in the old texts, and the neat division of labour turns out to be largely a modern gloss.

What seems to have happened is stranger and, for this book, more useful. The old truth-word died out of the language altogether; and dharma, the king's word for what a throne upholds, was borrowed: by the Buddha, to name his teaching; by the emperor Aśoka, for the ideology of an empire; by nineteenth-century Hindu reformers, for a universal ethic; by twenty-first-century secularisers, for a practice with the metaphysics set gently to one side. Dharma travels well because it has been so often and so successfully re-founded. Nor is it unique in this: even natural law, woven though it was into the mind of God, was eventually secularised by jurists who kept the law and lost the lawgiver; Aquinas himself had left a lower storey lit by natural reason. What dharma has is a longer record of removals.

None of which demotes the upper storey: for most of the word's history, and for millions of practitioners now, the cosmology *is* the point. But it does mean that a phrase like 'secular dharma' is, for all its air of contradiction, the newest borrowing in a very old series, and the series itself is the strongest evidence we will meet that dharmas are made. The concept itself needs no vehicle: every people reinvents it unprompted, as this whole section has been showing. What travelled was a word, one

culture's label for the thing, passed from hand to hand and re-founded at each stop. This book borrows it in exactly that spirit, and holds it just as lightly.

Custom, law, and the things a dharma is not

By now you may be feeling a reasonable suspicion. If a dharma can be a religion, a philosophy, or a people's unwritten code, and if the impulse behind it is universal, then hasn't the word swollen to mean simply 'human values'? A word that means everything means nothing. If *dharma* is going to bear the weight of this whole book, the word needs a boundary: some way of distinguishing what *is* a dharma from what merely looks like one.

The boundary lies in a *combination* of features, not in content: there is no single belief or rule you can point to and say *that* is what makes it a dharma. The cleanest version I found runs to four.

The first is **comprehensiveness**: a dharma governs a whole life, or a whole domain of life, rather than a single slice of behaviour. It has something to say about work, speech, money, family, authority, suffering and death; it is an architecture, not a single rule.

The second is that it is **identity-constituting**: a dharma binds you from the inside, by conviction and identity rather than from the outside by force. It also works to remake you, telling you who to *become* and offering the practices – habits, disciplines, rituals – to get you there.

The third is an **orientation toward the good**: it is about how one *ought* to live. The classical Indian tradition drew that line itself, between *dharma*, the ethical path, and *artha*, the business of getting and keeping worldly advantage.

And the fourth is **reflective self-awareness**, the one that will matter most once we meet dharmas being built on purpose: a dharma can be held up and known *as* a path, something a person or a people can name, examine,

and deliberately choose or reform, rather than merely absorbed as the way things obviously are.

Two pieces of fine print belong here, before the test is put to work; both are fingerprints of the kind I defend at this part's end. First, the scoring. 'Oriented toward the good' means the good as the dharma's own carriers conceive it: the feature marks the register of *ought* off from the register of advantage, and that is all it marks. It does not ask whether the conception is in fact any good; that question gets a part of its own much later, and keeping it out of the definition is deliberate, because Part 6 will need to call some genuinely dark things 'dharmas' without the definition ejecting them first. Likewise the fourth feature names a capacity: most dharmas are absorbed half-consciously and never feel chosen, and what marks them is that they *can* be held up and examined.

Second, the provenance. The research note behind this part carries a different fourth feature, a transformative *telos* – the 'who to become' – which this version folds into the second feature, freeing the fourth slot for reflective self-awareness precisely because the end of this book will need it. That is a choice, made by me, for a purpose you can now see coming, and I flag it so that no one following the links mistakes it for a finding.

Run the everyday impostors against those four features, and you can see why they fall short.

Custom, the way a village does things, supplies rules, but it is usually inherited without reflection and carries no transformative aim; it tells you what *is* done, not what is good and why.

Law, in the statute-book sense, is comprehensive and powerful, but it binds from the outside: by coercion, enforceable by punishment and abolishable by a vote. Repeal a statute, and it is gone; a dharma is not undone so easily, because it lives in conviction rather than on a statute book. The line is less clean than it sounds. Law also makes conscience, through the school and the courtroom, and every dharma in this book

uses sanctions of its own. The difference is where the binding is felt: from inside, as who you are, or from outside, as what it will cost you.

That is law as a lawyer means it, and it is the only sense the test has to keep out. The word has an older life, and in that life 'law' comes nearer to dharma than any other English word does. When the Buddha's teaching reached China, the translators rendered *dharma* as *fa*, the ordinary Chinese word for law, standard and method, the same word the Legalist school had used for the statutes of a hard state; and the Victorian translators, coming at it from the other side, made the same choice, so that the Lotus Sutra reached English as 'The Lotus of the True Law'. Neither was being careless. In Pali, Rupert Gethin lists the senses of *dhamma* as teaching, conduct, truth, nature, natural law and the basic qualities out of which a moment of experience is built, and insists they are one family rather than a list of homonyms; 'law' in English has kept a family nearly as wide, from the law of the land to the law of gravity. It is the natural law of two sections back, the order the jurists kept when they lost the lawgiver; and it shades into 'lore', 'way' and 'path', none of which covers the thing either.

Try it. Read 'law' for 'dharma' through the rest of this book and it will hold more often than not; and where it fails, it fails at exactly the line this section is drawing. A law of nature does not bind you at all: you fall whether or not you believe in gravity. A statute binds you from outside. A dharma binds from within, as who you have become, and neither sense of 'law' has a word for that. That is the whole reason this book keeps a foreign placeholder rather than the nearest English word: not because 'law' is wrong, but because its two halves, the discovered and the decreed, have between them mislaid the part that matters here.

Etiquette governs only the polished surface of conduct (which fork, which form of address) and social signalling, and asks nothing of your soul.

The hardest case is **ideology**, which, like a dharma, is comprehensive and fuses values with a story about the world; and plenty of ideologies sincerely offer their adherents transformation, sacrifice, discipline, an

identity to grow into. Nor can the difference be purity of motive, since dharmas have served power often enough: the word itself began in the rituals of kingship, and Aśoka put it to work for an empire. What separates them is centre of gravity. An ideology is organised first around political mobilisation, the winning and wielding of collective power; a dharma is organised first around the formation of persons, and carries that distinctive layer of inner practice (meditation, prayer, training) that an ideology can do without. The line is real, but it is the blurriest of the four, and traffic crosses it in both directions: a dharma curdles into an ideology when it is captured by power, and an ideology starts to look like a dharma the moment it begins telling its followers who to become.

You may have noticed that this test has soft edges, and those edges are part of the design. Membership in a category like this is a matter of degree rather than a clean yes-or-no. Just as a magpie is somehow a more obvious bird than a penguin or an emu, some dharmas are textbook cases and others sit out near the blurry rim. Buddhism, Stoicism and Ubuntu carry all four features in full, and the test admits them without a wobble.

But what about environmentalism, with its values, its disciplines of consumption, its story about humanity and nature, and its converts who genuinely reorganise their lives around it? What about the ethos of a demanding profession, medicine or the military, that tells its members who to become and drills them until they are it? What about a subculture like punk, with its code and its refusals?

Run the four features over each of these and you will find them scoring two or three out of four, hovering right at the threshold. I do not think there is a hidden fact that settles such cases, and chasing one would lead us away from what matters. The features are a tool for seeing family resemblance, not a border guard stamping passports. What they let us do is *compare*: to notice that a profession, a religion, and a peasant movement can be doing recognisably the same work, holding a life together in recognisably the same way, even when none of them would ever dream of calling itself a dharma.

A definition is a tool, not a truth

I have just handed you a four-part definition, and I want to immediately complicate it, because the most interesting thing I learned in defining *dharma* is something about definition itself.

Words like this one resist being pinned, and not by accident. The philosopher Ludwig Wittgenstein made the point with the humble word '*game*'. Try to find the single feature common to all games: board games, ball games, solitaire, a child spinning in a circle, the Olympics. Competition cannot be the common thread, because solitaire has none; skill cannot be it, because snakes and ladders needs none; fun cannot be it, because the professional has come to dread the game he plays for a living. There is no single feature that runs the whole length. Instead there is, in his phrase, 'a complicated network of similarities overlapping and criss-crossing': a *family resemblance*.

Such a concept is held together not like a single thread but like a rope: its strength comes from many short fibres twisted together, no one of which runs end to end. *Dharma* is a rope. (Though one fibre, it must be said, runs remarkably far: the scholars who catalogue the word's Buddhist senses find nearly all of them still carrying some scent of *support*, of holding-in-place. A rope, then; but a rope with one long strand near its core.) That is why the question scholars of the word learned to ask was never 'what *is* dharma' (a demand for the one true essence) but 'what makes something *a* dharma', a question about family resemblance.

There is a further wrinkle. The philosopher WB Gallie noticed that certain words (*art*, *democracy*, *social justice*) are more than vague: they are *essentially contested*. People will still be disagreeing about the true meaning of *justice* in a thousand years, and that endless disagreement is part of what the word *is*. *Dharma* belongs in that company with one caution attached. Gallie's own test asks whether the rival users are at least contesting the same prize, heirs of one acknowledged exemplar, and the Vedic ritualist, the Abhidharma scholastic and the secular meditator are not obviously

doing that. Within a single tradition, dharma is contested exactly as Gallie described; across the whole plural field, it is less a disputed trophy than the rope of the last paragraph.

So when I offer you those four features, I am offering a *tool*: a deliberately sharpened version of a fuzzy word, cut to a particular purpose, which is to let us compare very different ways of living without collapsing them into one. A definition, on this view, is less like a true statement and more like a map, useful precisely because it leaves things out, and judged by whether it takes you where you need to go.

There is a third and harder version of the objection, and it deserves to be met at full strength, because it comes from inside the discipline this whole project leans on. The anthropologist Talal Asad argued, in a famous critique, that 'there cannot be a universal definition of religion', and not merely because the word is fuzzy, but because any such definition 'is itself the historical product of discursive processes'. The very urge to lift a single, functional category out of the world's ways of living grew out of a specific Christian and then secular European history, and it has served administration and empire at least as often as understanding. Every word of that critique applies to what I am doing with *dharma*. Part 6 will show how the nineteenth century manufactured the very containers called 'world religions' and then forgot they were manufactured; on Asad's terms, I am manufacturing another.

The first response is to disarm the thing that makes it lethal, which is concealment. A definition does its damage when it poses as a discovery. Mine is offered as a tool with the toolmaker's fingerprints left on it: chosen by a particular person, out of a particular history, for a stated purpose, to be judged by the work it does and discarded where it fails. And candour, I should admit, buys less than it seems to: confessing a genealogy does little to disarm it. What actually answers Asad is that a tool of this kind can be *tested*. Its claims can fail against the world, and one failure above all wants watching for: define a dharma by the work it does, and you

will find one in every society you look at, because the finding is packed into the definition.

That is why the universality claimed earlier was offered as evidence, counted societies and their published critics, and not as a consequence of my four features. What cannot be claimed, after Asad, is innocence. What *can* be claimed is authorship, on the record, and a willingness to be marked wrong. And the question he forces is not 'is the definition true', but: for what work, for whom, do we need to stabilise this word at all, and what plurality do we put at risk by stabilising it?

This is the method of the whole undertaking. Faced with a drifting, contested, three-thousand-year-old word, the tempting move is to plant a flag and declare what dharma *really* means. The appropriate move, the one I will try to keep faith with, is to map its uses instead: to lay out many dharmas, with their contexts and their tensions intact, and resist flattening them into a single official version. That will matter when, near the end of this journey, we ask whether a machine could be taught human ethics at all, or whether teaching it would crush the plural into a single average and call the result the truth.

Two questions I'm leaving open

Two objections have probably been forming, and rather than answer them now I am going to name them and leave them standing, because they are the twin destinations the whole argument is heading for.

The first is about authority. I have defined a dharma as something that binds you from the inside, by conviction rather than by force, but I have also said a dharma need not rest on any god. So a sharp question follows: without a divine lawgiver behind it, can a dharma really *bind* you at all? Or is a godless dharma just a set of personal preferences wearing the costume of duty? It is the oldest question in ethics. Plato was already turning it over in a dialogue called the *Euthyphro* two and a half thousand years ago, and the trap he set there for the divine lawgiver has never been cleanly

escaped. I think there is a real answer. But we will face it properly when we reach the modern, secular, god-haunted world several parts from now.

The second is about judgement. If dharmas are genuinely plural and none automatically sits above the others, then are they all equally good? When a dharma is cruel, or cages half its people, or feeds a death camp, am I really reduced to shrugging that it is simply *their* way? The worry is serious enough that I do not want it festering for eight parts: *plural* is not the same as *anything goes*. To say there is no single true dharma is not to say that every dharma is as good as every other, any more than admitting there are many good languages means every sentence is true. There is a floor, and some dharmas fall through it. But building that floor, honestly, without smuggling in my own culture's furniture and calling it the universe, is delicate work, and it belongs at the end of the road, not here.

The most ordinary thing in the world

So what did I find, going to look for the meaning under the fog?

I found that the word we treat as exotic is, at its root, the plainest word imaginable: *that which holds*. I found that there is no single Dharma but a teeming plurality of dharmas, secular and sacred alike, none of them granted the high ground in advance. I found that every human society grows one, because every human society faces the same problem of how to cooperate without being torn apart, and a dharma is the characteristic human solution. And I found that 'dharma' is best treated as a tool: a map we draw for a purpose, holding the plurality open rather than freezing it shut.

Which means the thing we have been taught to see as faraway and faintly mystical is, in fact, the most ordinary thing in the world. You are standing inside a dharma right now, some inherited, half-examined account of how to treat people and what a good life looks like, whether or not you have ever given it a name. The interesting question was never whether *you* have

a dharma. It is which one – or which ones – where it came from, how it got inside you, and whether it deserves to keep you.

The very next question is the obvious one: if dharmas are made rather than handed down from the sky, where do they actually come from? What is it about being human that makes us build these things, over and over, wherever we appear? To answer that, we have to go and watch one being born: back past the philosophers and past the scriptures, to the first crowded cities, where the ancient social instincts we just met were made to hold together more strangers than they had ever faced.

« 0: Preface | 2: The genesis of dharmas »

Sources & further reading

This part is built from the project's research notes, which carry the full inline citations. Listed here are the notes it draws on and the key works behind them.

Research notes

Research notes used in this book are published on GitHub – https://github.com/Biksu-Okusi/In-Search-of-Dharma.

- 1.1 Core Etymology – √*dhṛ* 'to hold', the Proto-Indo-European root, the *firmus/firm* cognate, *ṛta*, and the semantic broadening over three millennia. The spine of the opening.
- 1.2 Universal Patterns – why dharma-shaped frameworks recur independently: the cooperation-without-exploitation problem, and Tinbergen's universal-function / plural-mechanism distinction.
- 1.3 Boundary & Definition – the four-feature test and the contrasts with custom, law, etiquette, ideology, and *artha*; dharma as a family-resemblance, essentially contested concept; and the Asad engagement (the genealogical power-objection, met with the disclosed tool).
- 1.4 Cross-cultural Cognates – *ṛta*, *ma'at*, *asha*, *logos*, *Tao*, and natural law as the cosmic-scale recurrence of 'that which holds'.
- 3.3 The Grounding Problem – the planted question of whether a godless dharma can bind (paid off in Part 7).
- 3.4 Relativism vs Universalism – the planted question of whether some dharmas are better than others (paid off in Part 8).
- Companion essay: *Defining Definition*, published with the research notes on GitHub – definition as a family-resemblance, power-laden, drifting tool; 'map, not territory'.

Key works

- Manfred Mayrhofer, *Etymologisches Wörterbuch des Altindoarischen* (1992) – the standard authority for the √*dhṛ* → Proto-Indo-European derivation; the root and its reflex table (including the unexpected

cousins *throne* and *Darius*, 'upholding the good') verified against Pokorny via the UT Austin Indo-European Lexicon.

- Patrick Olivelle, 'The Semantic History of Dharma: The Middle and Late Vedic Periods' (2004) – dharma's marginality in the middle Vedic centuries and its rise through Buddhist and Aśokan borrowing; the paper behind this part's revised history of the word.
- Rupert Gethin, 'He Who Sees Dhamma Sees Dhammas' (2004) – the Buddhist senses of dhamma, and the long strand of 'support' that runs through nearly all of them.
- Wilhelm Halbfass, *India and Europe* (1988), ch. 17 – classical dharma's particularism, and the case against the tidy ṛta-to-dharma staircase.
- B Schlerath & PO Skjærvø, 'AŠA', *Encyclopædia Iranica* – ṛta and asha as one Indo-Iranian word for 'truth', and the four-thousand-year-old formula 'to uphold the truth'.
- Y Karunadasa, *The Dhamma Theory* (1996) – why Abhidharma dharmas are events, not atoms.
- Oliver Scott Curry, Daniel Austin Mullins & Harvey Whitehouse, 'Is It Good to Cooperate?' (*Current Anthropology*, 2019) – the seven cooperative moral rules across sixty societies, read here together with its published critics and the formal anthropological debate that followed (*JRAI*, 2020).
- Nicholas A Christakis, *Blueprint: The Evolutionary Origins of a Good Society* (2019) – the 'social suite' of evolved social tendencies (cooperation, friendship, in-group bias, social learning).
- Donald E Brown, *Human Universals* (1991) – reciprocity, fairness, and ethical patterning as features present in every documented culture.
- Robert Hertz, 'Contribution à une étude sur la représentation collective de la mort' (*Année sociologique*, 1907; English in *Death and the Right Hand*, 1960), and Maurice Bloch & Jonathan Parry (eds.), *Death and the Regeneration of Life* (1982) – mortuary ritual as the reconstitution of the social order after a death; the reason a dharma cannot stop at exchange.
- Niko Tinbergen, 'On Aims and Methods of Ethology' (1963) – the four questions, and the function/mechanism distinction this part uses to

hold 'universal' and 'wildly varied' together. David Sloan Wilson applies that split to morality; the project reaches his application through his writing at prosocial.world rather than a peer-reviewed paper, and Tinbergen's own article is listed here as the source of the idea, not as a text the corpus holds.

- Joseph Campbell, *Oriental Mythology: The Masks of God, Vol. II* (1962), ch. 1 – against picturing early man as 'a sort of primitive social scientist'; the caution this part extends to the founders of dharmas, that a function is not an intent.
- Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations* (1953) – 'game', family resemblance, and the rope-not-thread model of meaning.
- WB Gallie, 'Essentially Contested Concepts' (1956) – why words like *justice*, *democracy*, and *dharma* sustain permanent, internal disagreement.
- Talal Asad, *Genealogies of Religion* (1993) – the genealogical objection this part meets head-on: there is no universal definition of religion, because the definition itself is 'the historical product of discursive processes'; the strongest published opponent of this project's central move, engaged here from the full text.
- Kevin Schilbrack, 'The Concept of Religion' (*Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2022) – the reply this part now leans on: realism plus testability, and the warning that a functional definition manufactures the universality it reports.
- Emily Teeter, *The Presentation of Maat* (1997) and Miriam Lichtheim, *Maat in Egyptian Autobiographies* (1992) – ma'at as royal rite and as lived ethic.
- Edward Slingerland, 'Effortless Action' (2000) – wu-wei as the pan-Chinese ideal of moving with the grain, Confucian as much as Daoist.
- Cicero, *De Re Publica* and *De Legibus*, with Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* I-II qq. 90–97 – natural law in its own words, including the reason-lit lower storey that later let it secularise.
- Plato, *Euthyphro* – the ancient form of the 'can ethics stand without a divine command?' question (developed in Part 7).

- Isaiah Berlin on value pluralism, and Martha Nussbaum and Amartya Sen on the capabilities approach – pluralism with a floor, against relativism (developed in Part 8).

2: The genesis of dharmas

Audio: Part 2: in search of dharma



The genesis of dharmas

Why does every society grow a dharma, and why did so many of the greatest ones appear, in different worlds, at almost the same moment? It starts with a problem that arrives the day your village gets too big to know.

Picture two human worlds, separated by ten thousand years. In the first, a few dozen people move together through a landscape they know by heart. They are bound, sometimes by blood, always by a lifetime of shared meals,

shared danger, shared everything. There are no written rules, no scriptures, no judges, no police. Yet there is unmistakably a moral order: food is shared, boasting is slapped down, the bully is brought to heel, and everyone knows, without being told, what counts as decent and what counts as disgraceful. It works, and it has worked for longer than we can comfortably imagine.

In the second world, tens of thousands of people are packed into a single city. Most of them will never meet. The woman who sold you a loaf of bread this morning you may never lay eyes on again; the man three streets over is, for all practical purposes, a stranger to you forever. It is here that the easy morality of the small band, the kind that runs on everyone knowing everyone, simply cannot reach. And yet, for the most part, the city does not dissolve into a war of all against all. Something holds it together.

That something is, in large part, a 'dharma', by whatever local name. Every human society grows one; but at this scale it takes a particular and demanding form, an explicit, teachable, portable account of how to live alongside people you do not know.

The puzzle of the simultaneous sages

A remarkable number of the great reflective ethical systems, the ones whose descendants we still live inside, erupted in a single narrow window, roughly between 800 and 200 BCE, in civilisations that had little or no contact with one another. In North India, the Buddha sat down under a tree, and the wandering philosophers of the Upanishads asked what lay behind the self. In what we now call China, Confucius and Laozi were laying down two rival visions of 'the Way'. In Persia, Zoroaster split the cosmos into truth and the lie. In the small kingdoms of Palestine, the Hebrew prophets thundered that ritual without justice was worthless. And in the Hellenic city states, the first philosophers began prising the world apart with reason.

The German philosopher Karl Jaspers gave this window a name: the Axial Age, the age on which history turns. The label, I should say at once, has taken a battering from historians since, and I will come back to give the objections their due. But the coincidence he pointed at is arresting. Why should so many of humanity's deepest ethical breakthroughs cluster into a few centuries, scattered across a continent, among peoples who could not have copied one another? Either it is an accident of staggering proportions, or something was happening to the human condition, in several places at once, that pressed people toward the same kind of answer.

The two puzzles are joined. The crowding of the cities and the eruption of the sages belong to the same great transformation, seen from different angles; how much of the second the first can claim to explain is a question the evidence will complicate before we are done. But to get there, we have to start where morality itself starts, which is a very long way before either.

Morality is older than the dharmas

One thing is easy to get backwards: the codes did not create morality. Morality created the codes.

For something like a hundred thousand years before anyone wrote anything down, human beings lived, mostly, in small foraging bands and ran a functioning, demanding ethical order with no doctrine at all. Its spine, wherever anyone has looked, was the cooperative one we met in Part 1; the content varied from people to people, as content always does, but the direction of the rules did not. We know a fair amount about how, because anthropologists have studied the foraging societies that survived into modern times (not our ancestors, but the nearest window we have), and because the evolutionary logic is clear.

Christopher Boehm spent a career on the question, and his answer is bracing. Human beings, he argues, have the same instinct for dominance as our great-ape cousins, the same itch to climb and to lord it over others.

What foragers do is gang up against that instinct. Boehm calls it a 'reverse dominance hierarchy': instead of the strong dominating the weak, the many combine to dominate the would-be strong. The upstart who grabs more than his share, who swaggers, who tries to give orders, is met with a graded series of corrections. First laughter. Then mockery. Then pointed criticism, gossip behind his back, the cold shoulder. And if he will not be shamed into line, in the last resort, the group can decide to be rid of him for good.

Boehm's own trawl of the ethnographic record turned up executions among foragers on three continents and among tribesmen on three more: rare, in his phrase, yet widespread. Behind that last resort Boehm found a particular and harder figure: the intimidator who cannot be shamed at all, the recidivist bully or killer off whom ridicule and gossip simply slide. Most troublemakers fold at the first cold shoulder; this one does not, and it was against him that the band held its ultimate sanction in reserve. He will return, because he is the deep ancestor of a human type: the one who can mimic every signal of belonging while feeling none of its pull.

This is morality with teeth, and it needs no scripture because it needs no strangers. Everything it requires is carried in the heads and mouths of people who see each other every day. Reputation does the policing. The constant low hum of who-did-what, what we now dismiss as mere gossip, was in fact the surveillance system that kept everyone honest. You behaved, because everyone was always – gently – watching, and because the story of your behaviour would outrun you to the next campfire.

The policing runs deeper than tit-for-tat. People will punish a cheat even when it costs them to do it. In laboratory games where everyone contributes to a common pot, players reliably pay out of their own pockets to penalise the free rider who takes without giving, a behaviour the economists Ernst Fehr and Simon Gächter labelled 'altruistic punishment'. Stranger still, the punisher need not be the injured party at all: in a later variation of the experiment, bystanders who had merely

watched someone treat a third person unfairly paid, unprompted, to punish them too.

On the face of it this makes no sense, since the punisher bears a cost and pockets nothing. But it makes the group's morality very nearly self-enforcing: the cheat risks the anger of the person he wrongs and the disapproval of everyone who hears the tale. There is a self-interested edge to it, too. We punish partly to be *seen* punishing, because coming down hard on a wrongdoer advertises that we ourselves can be trusted, which is why we reserve a special contempt for the hypocrite, who preaches the rule and breaks it. The instinct that polices the band is half justice and half performance, and it works all the better for being both. Though a caution from the lab: when helping and punishing compete as advertisements, audiences prefer the helper.

How did such a society pass on its rules, with no book to write them in? Largely by telling stories. When researchers studied storytelling among the Agta, a foraging people of the Philippines, they found that a huge proportion of the tales were not idle entertainment but encoded instructions for living together: tales of the sun and the moon learning to share the sky, tales of the greedy creature who steals from the common catch and is punished for it. A good story does something a rule cannot: it tells you the norm, and at the same time it tells you that everyone else has heard the norm too, so that you all know that you all know. And those same forager societies frequently have no moralising high god at all, no watching deity tallying sins. They did not need one. The story did the god's later job.

It is easy, at this point, to slide into a fantasy of the noble savage, the gentle egalitarian who shames us moderns. That is not the picture. The forager's equality is enforced, sometimes with violence, and the ostracism that keeps the peace can be cruel. And the warmth was reserved for the in-group. The same band that shared everything within could raid and kill without. The moral circle was real, and it was small, and its edge was hard.

The crisis of strangers

The foragers' morality had a hidden dependency. It worked because everyone could watch everyone. It was a technology for a world of faces.

There is a rough ceiling on how many people any one of us can really know, track, and care about. Anthropologist Robin Dunbar put the famous figure at around 150, and although the exact number is always debated, and lately the principle too, the core observation stands: our capacity for genuine relationships is finite and not very large. Below that ceiling, the old machinery hums along. Reputation reaches everyone, because everyone is within earshot. Above it, the machinery starts to fail. As the evolutionary biologist Mark Pagel points out, kinship and face-to-face reciprocity can only ever bind a group so big, which is why no other animal on Earth lives in cities of millions. Your family is never going to be that large, and you cannot personally keep accounts with a stranger you will meet exactly once.

And then, about twelve thousand years ago, our ancestors began to do the very thing the old morality was not built for. They settled and farmed. They gathered into villages, then towns, then the first astonishing cities. Almost overnight, in evolutionary terms, social life stopped being a web of familiar faces and became a sea of strangers. You now had to trade, cooperate and keep the peace with people you would never see again, people whose reputations you could not check and whose retaliation you need not fear. In that world, the cheat has a winning strategy the forager's cheat never had: take what you can, and disappear into the crowd.

The thing we casually call 'the problem of civilisation' is, underneath, a problem of cooperation among strangers, and the small-band toolkit cannot solve it. Gossip cannot catch up with a stranger who has already moved on. Shame has no grip on someone who does not care what you think. So the city faced a stark choice: find a new way to make strangers trustworthy, or struggle to hold together.

What it found was a dharma, or rather the kind of thing a dharma is. To hold a city together, you need a scale-free substitute for the village's web of faces, and an explicit shared code is exactly that. It does two jobs at once. It turns a stranger into 'one of us': a fellow believer, a fellow citizen, a brother in the faith you have never met but can already trust, because you know he answers to the same rules. And it makes conduct predictable without personal acquaintance, because the rules are stated and enforced by community and court, and very often by a god who is imagined to see everything you do even when no human is watching. The watching deity arrives in many of the large societies to play the role that gossip once filled, now scaled up to a city that gossip can no longer cover.

I should be careful about what 'arrives' means. What the forager's world lacks is the creator high god of the coded surveys; spirits, ancestors and taboo-sanctions that police conduct are found in societies of every size, and a recent rereading of the same ethnographies, by Aaron Lightner and his colleagues, finds moralising supernatural agents at all scales. What the city adds is the *big* god: one deity, everywhere, keeping the whole ledger. (Whether such gods came before the great societies, after them, or in step with them is a live scholarly fight, and I take no side in it here; what matters for this story is the fit between the job and the tool.)

Why should a watching god, of all the possible solutions, have been such a popular one? The answer lies in the peculiar wiring of the human mind. We are, by inheritance, wildly oversensitive to the presence of other minds. A rustle in the grass might be the wind or might be a leopard, and the ancestor who assumed 'leopard' and was usually wrong left more descendants than the one who assumed 'wind' and was occasionally eaten. So we come equipped with a hair-trigger for sensing that something out there has intentions and is watching us. A god is something like what you get when that instinct is turned on the whole world at once.

The cognitive scientist Pascal Boyer adds a second ingredient: the supernatural ideas that survive and spread are the ones that are almost ordinary, breaking our everyday expectations in just one or two

memorable ways. An invisible person who can read your private thoughts is strange enough to seize the attention and simple enough to pass intact from mouth to mouth down the centuries. A being like that, always watching, is the perfect surveillance camera for a society grown too large to watch itself, and the human mind was primed to believe in it long before any city needed it.

The price of belonging

Why are so many of the great codes so *demanding*? If a dharma exists to make cooperation easier, why does it so often pile on costly, inconvenient requirements: the dietary laws, the dress codes, the fasts, the long hours of prayer, the renounced pleasures? It looks like waste, but it is in fact the engine.

The logic was worked out by the economist Laurence Iannaccone, asking why some religious communities thrive while others dissolve, and it comes back to the same hard problem we keep encountering: how do you keep out the free rider who wants the warmth of belonging without paying for it? The answer is to make belonging expensive in a way that is hard to fake. Anyone can *say* they are committed; only the genuinely committed will keep the difficult fast, wear the conspicuous garment, sit through the long ritual, and give up the forbidden pleasure year after year. The cost is the point. It screens out the half-hearted and signals to everyone watching that here is a person who can be relied on.

The evidence is unusually concrete. When anthropologist Richard Sosis studied a large sample of nineteenth-century US American communes, the religious ones survived, on average, several times longer than the secular ones, and among the religious communities, the stricter the demands, the longer they tended to last. Studies of extreme ritual point the same way: at a festival in Mauritius where some devotees pierce their bodies and haul heavy frames through the heat, the anthropologist Dimitris Xygalatas and his team found that the more painful the ordeal a person underwent, the more generously they later gave to the community, and the more tightly

everyone who witnessed it was bound together. Later work by Klocová and her colleagues adds a caution here too: it may be the felt benefits of the rite, more than its raw costs, that keep such practices alive. Asking a great deal of its followers strengthens a dharma, because the asking is how it sorts the committed from the casual and welds the committed to one another.

But this carries a sting in its tail. Sosis found that the secular communes could not earn the same return on strictness. The reason, he argued, is that religious demands are anchored to claims that can never be tested and so can never be disproved: you cannot run an experiment on heaven. A secular code that asks for sacrifice has to justify that sacrifice in this-worldly terms, which experience can always come back and challenge. Which means that a secular dharma, the very thing we are slowly circling toward, is giving up one of the most powerful binding mechanisms its religious cousins ever found, and will have to make up the difference some other way. That difficulty is Part 7's to answer, and I shall return to it there.

The sages, answered

Now we can return to the puzzle of the simultaneous sages.

Set the great ethical eruptions of 800 to 200 BCE against that backdrop, and the timing looks less like a miracle and more like a response. These centuries were precisely when the pressure of large, complex, anonymous society was becoming unbearable in several parts of the world at once. The cosmic orders we met in Part 1, *ṛta* and *ma'at* and their cousins, began to turn inward, away from ritual and toward ethics. The older religion had mostly been about propitiation: perform the sacrifice correctly, observe the taboo, and the gods will send rain and victory. The new teachings cared about something else entirely: live rightly, master your own desires, purify the heart, and thereby align yourself with, or escape from, the order of things. Religion stopped being mainly a technology for managing the harvest and became a technology for managing the self.

Something else was born in that same pivot, easy to miss and enormous in its consequences. Once you posit an order higher than the king, a truth or a justice or a heaven that stands above any earthly throne, you have created the means to judge the throne. The sociologist Shmuel Eisenstadt put his finger on this: the Axial breakthrough installed a permanent tension between a transcendent ideal and the grubby mundane world. With it came a new kind of person, one who claims to speak for the higher order and can therefore stand outside worldly power and call it to account. A Hebrew prophet denouncing a corrupt king; a philosopher who will not flatter the tyrant; a monk who owns nothing and so cannot be bought: these are Axial figures, and they are dangerous to power in a way the old temple priest, paid to keep the gods content, never was. A dharma that answers to something above the state can always, in principle, be turned against the state.

Why then, and why in those particular places? No single cause carries the whole weight, but the contributing pressures rhyme suggestively. One was money. Coinage was invented at almost exactly this time, independently, in Lydia, India, and China, and with it came the impersonal market, the cash transaction between strangers who owe each other nothing once the coin changes hands. The anthropologist David Graeber tied the age together as a grim package of professional armies, the coins minted to pay them, and the slavery and chronic warfare that followed, and he read the new religions as the counter-movement, the protest. Once a whole zone of life had been handed over to naked material self-interest, another zone arose to insist that material things, and even the self, do not ultimately matter. The marketplace and the monastery were born as twins.

A second pressure, less obviously, was prosperity. The evolutionary psychologist Nicolas Baumard and his colleagues found that the best predictor of where these ascetic, self-disciplining religions took hold was not military might or imperial scale but sheer affluence: the energy and security a society had at its disposal. When life rises above bare subsistence, human motivation tends to shift from grabbing what you can

today toward patience, restraint, and the long view, which is the very ethic the new religions preached. Tellingly, these movements flowered in smaller, richer polities rather than in the largest empires of the day: the Greek city states, the kingdoms of the Ganges plain, the competing states of China.

A third pressure was literacy. It created a leisured class of scribes and teachers, people with the time and the tools to think about thinking, to argue, to systematise, to ask why the rules were what they were. And running beneath all of it was the anonymity of the new urban world, the crisis of strangers that demanded a new, portable kind of ethic. Baumard's result, though, deserves its full weight against my own story: if wealth predicts the sages better than sheer scale does, then the crisis of strangers was one strong pressure among several, not the single explanation I may have tempted you toward.

Put these together, and the simultaneity dissolves into something far less mysterious than divine coincidence. When broadly similar conditions arise independently in different places, you should expect broadly similar solutions to arise with them, no copying required, the same way eyes evolved many separate times because seeing is useful wherever there is light. The Axial Age was the same problem, worked out in parallel, arriving at recognisably the same answer: an internalised, reflective, universalising ethic that could bind a stranger as readily as a kinsman.

I should enter one caution, because tidy stories about history deserve suspicion. 'The Axial Age' is itself a contested idea, and the objections are more serious than a footnote. Jaspers drew the borders of his age to take in Greece, Israel, India, and China while leaving out Egypt and Mesopotamia, older civilisations with cosmic-order traditions of their own (Egypt's *ma'at* among them), and Aleida Assmann, for one, insists that both belong inside it. The whole notion of a single spiritual 'breakthrough', others add, can smuggle in a Christian story of history marching toward enlightenment. Nor was the idea Jaspers's to begin with: the Scottish writer John Stuart-Glennie had described the same supposed turn in 1873, three-quarters of a century earlier, and called it the moral revolution. And

one of my own five exhibits is shaky. The dating of Zoroaster is fiercely disputed, and a substantial body of scholarship places him around 1200 to 1000 BCE, some four centuries before the window in which I have just stood him.

The hardest objection is the empirical one. When a team led by Daniel Mullins and Daniel Hoyer took the traits that proponents offer as evidence of an axial transformation and looked for them systematically in the historical record, they found those traits appearing across Afro-Eurasia 'hundreds and in some cases thousands of years prior to the proposed Axial Age'. If the distinctive features turn up long before the window, the window is not doing the work the name implies.

So hold the phrase loosely. The convergence is striking and the problem it responds to is real, but 'the Axial Age' is a pattern we have drawn on the past, not a switch that flipped. What remains is what this part actually needs: similar pressures, arising independently, pushed people toward similar answers. That needs no magic window, and survives the loss of one.

What the codes added, and what they did not

So, did the Axial sages invent morality? By now you can hear how badly that question is put. Morality was already a hundred thousand years old when the Buddha sat down. What the new codes did was not to create the moral sense but to re-engineer it for a new scale, and it pays to be precise about what they added, because the list is the hidden architecture of every dharma since.

They added explicitness: they took an ethic that had lived silently in habit and story and stated it out loud, as doctrine you could examine, teach, and argue with. They added universality: they stretched the moral circle, at least in principle, past the band and the tribe toward the stranger, the foreigner, and eventually all of humanity, prising the warm inside of the small group open to take in people the foragers would have raided. They added reflection: a tradition that enacted its values and also theorised

them, asked after their reasons, and could therefore criticise itself and reform. And through writing, they added permanence and reach: a code on a page could be fixed, copied, carried across an ocean, and handed to a generation the teacher would never meet, in a way almost no spoken story ever could.

What is on that list matters as much as what is missing from it. Every item is a technology layered on top of the older cooperative human nature, not a replacement for it. And that single observation is the foundation of the secular case. If a full moral order ran all that time on story, ritual, reputation, and the levelling of upstarts, with no scripture and frequently no god in sight, then scripture and god were never necessary for ethics. They were tools that a particular kind of large society found useful for the job. Which means the job can, at least in principle, be done with other tools.

There is a complication that keeps the picture from being too neat. I have told this as though crowding came first and codes came second, society creating dharmas to cope. But the arrow can run the other way too. Anthropologist Joseph Henrich and his colleagues have traced how the medieval Western Church, by banning cousin marriage and reshaping the family, actively dissolved the dense webs of kinship that had organised European life, and in doing so helped manufacture the loose, mobile, individualistic, stranger-trusting society we now think of as modern. There the dharma did not merely answer the new world; it helped build it. Codes and the societies that carry them make each other, in a long feedback loop with no clean beginning.

The fence that comes with the circle

One shadow falls across all of this. The very machinery that makes a dharma such a powerful glue, the way it turns strangers into brothers, works by drawing a line around the ‘us’ it creates. A dharma includes by excluding; the circle of care is also a fence. We will spend a whole part, much later, on what happens at that fence.

There is a stronger version of that claim which I had better not make. Some evolutionary models propose that the warmth turned inward and the suspicion turned outward are two faces of one adaptation, bred together by war between groups. It is an elegant idea and it may yet be right, but it has taken a serious knock. When anthropologist Mark Dyble reran the best-known of those models across a much wider range of conditions, he found the result held only when groups were assumed to differ genetically far more than real hunter-gatherer groups actually do. Set that dial to what we measure in the field, and the altruism stops evolving. The fence is real, and we have plenty of evidence for it in history and in the laboratory. What we do not have is a settled account of it written into our genes by ancient warfare.

Made things

The birth of dharma, in the end, is not a revelation. It is a response. Strip the story to its bones and you find human beings, equipped by evolution with an ancient and powerful moral sense built for life among a hundred familiar faces, walking into a world of thousands of strangers that their inherited instincts could not govern, and building, under pressure, a new kind of tool to cope. The dharmas are those tools. They are made things, forged at a particular time, by particular people, to solve a very real problem: how to hold together a group too large to hold itself.

We are taught to imagine ethical wisdom descending from on high, eternal and complete, for us to receive. The deeper history shows the opposite: ethical systems welling up from below, improvised and revised, shaped by coins and cities and harvests and the simple arithmetic of how many people one mind can know. They were built. And anything that was built could have been built differently, and can be built again.

But I have been speaking in the grand abstractions of deep time and lost civilisations, of pressures and centuries and whole continents. It is one thing to argue, from the safe distance of two thousand years, that dharmas are made. It is another to watch it actually happen: to find a dharma

whose making is close enough to see, whose founder has a name and a birth date, whose pressures we can reconstruct in detail because they fell inside the documentary record. As it happens, there is one, in the teak forests of Java, built by an illiterate farmer in the 1890s. If dharmas are made, the Samin let us watch the hands at work.

« 1: Defining dharma | 3: The dharmas of the Samin of Java »

Sources & further reading

This part is built from the project's research notes, which carry the full inline citations. Listed here: the notes it draws on, and the key works behind them.

Research notes

Research notes used in this book are published on GitHub – https://github.com/Biksu-Okusi/In-Search-of-Dharma.

- 2.3 Pre-Axial / Pre-literate Ethics – the moral baseline before codes: Boehm's reverse dominance hierarchy, storytelling as norm-carrier, and what codification added. The spine of the middle.
- 2.2 Urban Complexity – Dunbar's ceiling, the breakdown of face-to-face cooperation at scale, and the explicit code as a 'scale-free' substitute.
- 2.1 Axial Age Catalyst – the 800–200 BCE eruption; affluence, coinage, literacy, and anonymity as converging pressures; the propitiation-to-ethicisation pivot; and the concept's contested status.
- 5.2 Evolutionary Psychology – the cooperation/free-rider problem dharmas solve, and parochial altruism: the in-group bond and out-group edge that coevolve.
- 1.2 Universal Patterns – convergent solutions to a shared problem; why parallel conditions yield parallel dharmas with no contact.
- 5.5 Psychopaths & the Exploiter Limit Case – Boehm's intractable intimidator and the band's last-resort sanction; the constitutional exploiter as deep ancestor of a type Part 6 develops.

Key works

- Christopher Boehm, *Hierarchy in the Forest* (1999) – the 'reverse dominance hierarchy' and egalitarian enforcement among foragers, including the last-resort removal of the intimidator who cannot be shamed.

- Daniel Smith, Andrea Migliano et al., on Agta storytelling – narrative as the pre-literate broadcaster of cooperative norms.
- Robin Dunbar on the cognitive limit to stable relationships, and Mark Pagel, *Wired for Culture* – why kinship caps group size and humans needed a 'scale-free' mechanism.
- Ara Norenzayan, *Big Gods* (2013) – the watching-deity argument; with Aaron Lightner, Theiss Bendixen & Benjamin Purzycki (2022) on how the standard cross-cultural datasets undercount moralising gods in small societies, and Léo Fitouchi, Manvir Singh, Jean-Baptiste André & Nicolas Baumard (2023) on moralising gods as 'folk-technologies of mutual policing' at every scale; and the *Nature* exchange over whether moralising gods precede or follow social complexity (Whitehouse et al. 2019, retracted 2021 after Beheim et al.'s missing-data critique) – the live scholarly fight the body of this part declines to referee.
- Karl Jaspers, *The Origin and Goal of History* (1949) – the Axial Age thesis; with the Eurocentrism/teleology critiques (Aleida and Jan Assmann; Boy & Torpey), Eugene Halton's *From the Axial Age to the Moral Revolution* (2014) on John Stuart-Glennie's prior 1873 formulation, and Daniel Mullins, Daniel Hoyer and colleagues, 'A Systematic Assessment of "Axial Age" Proposals', *American Sociological Review* (2018), who find the diagnostic traits appearing 'hundreds and in some cases thousands of years prior to the proposed Axial Age'.
- Nicolas Baumard et al., 'Increased Affluence Explains the Emergence of Ascetic Wisdoms and Moralizing Religions', *Current Biology* (2015) – affluence, not empire, as the predictor.
- David Graeber, *Debt: The First 5,000 Years* (2011) – coinage, the 'military-coinage-slavery complex', and world religions as the counter-domain.
- Jonathan Schulz, Joseph Henrich et al., 'The Church, intensive kinship, and global psychological variation', *Science* (2019) – how a code reshaped kinship and helped manufacture stranger-society.
- Jung-Kyoo Choi & Samuel Bowles, 'The Coevolution of Parochial Altruism and War', *Science* (2007) – the model proposing that in-group altruism and out-group hostility evolved together; with Mark Dyble, 'The evolution of altruism through war is highly sensitive to

population structure and to civilian and fighter mortality', *PNAS* (2021), who re-runs that model across a wider parameter range and finds that when genetic differentiation between groups is set to values actually observed among hunter-gatherers, 'altruism does not evolve'.

- Ernst Fehr & Simon Gächter, 'Altruistic Punishment in Humans', *Nature* (2002) – costly punishment of free riders by the fellow contributors they cheat: the policing that stabilises cooperation. With Ernst Fehr & Urs Fischbacher, 'Third-Party Punishment and Social Norms', *Evolution and Human Behavior* (2004), for the bystander version, in which the punisher was not the injured party.
- Pascal Boyer, *Religion Explained*, and Justin Barrett on the 'hyperactive agency-detection device' – why a watching god is a cognitively catchy, transmissible idea.
- Richard Sosis & Eric Bressler, 'Cooperation and Commune Longevity' (2003); Laurence Iannaccone, 'Why Strict Churches Are Strong' (1994); Dimitris Xygalatas on the Thaipusam ritual – costly signalling and credibility-enhancing displays as the commitment engine, and the secular durability problem; with Klocová and colleagues on the rite's felt benefits, rather than its costs, as what sustains extreme rituals.
- Shmuel Eisenstadt on Axial transcendence – the transcendental/mundane tension and the critical elite who can judge worldly power 'from outside'.

3: The dharmas of the Samin of Java

Audio: Part 3: in search of dharma



The dharmas of the Samin of Java

An illiterate farmer, a fenced-off forest, and a way of living so complete it outlasted its maker by a hundred years. What a Javanese peasant movement can show us that the great religions no longer easily can.

Sometime in the first years of the twentieth century, on a dirt road in the teak country of central Java, a Dutch colonial official stops a barefoot

farmer and asks him a routine question. *Where are you from*? The farmer answers: from the forest. *Where are you going*? To the forest. Every word is true; every word is useless. The official has learned nothing he can write in a report, and nothing he can punish, because the man has not refused to answer; he has answered perfectly, and said nothing at all. The scene comes down to us as Javanese memory rather than colonial paperwork – no archive holds this exchange – but it is how the tradition itself tells the story, and, as we will see, it is exactly how the archive shows these people talking.

If you were that official, you would know you were being mocked. You would also know you could not prove it. And if you were patient enough to keep asking (and the Dutch, by every account, asked and asked) you would slowly realise this was not one stubborn man having a bad morning. It was a method. A whole community, thousands of people across a cluster of villages, had quietly agreed to meet the colonial state with this same deadpan, literal politeness. They paid no tax they could avoid, registered no marriages, and answered the census with riddles. And they did it all without ever raising a hand.

A hundred years later, in 2016, nine women farmers travelled from those same hills to the gates of the Presidential Palace in Jakarta, sat down on the pavement, and poured wet cement around their feet. They stayed there for hours, locked to the ground they had come to argue about, while the traffic of the capital flowed past. When they came back the next year, one of the protesters, a woman named Patmi, forty-eight years old, died not long after. They were the heirs of the man on the forest road: some by blood, all by their manner of refusal.

So I went looking for what connected them, and what I found was a dharma.

A dharma you can hold in your hand

The story so far has been very large and very abstract: civilisations, millennia, the Axial Age. I wanted the opposite. I wanted a dharma I could almost touch: small enough to see all the way around, recent enough that we know the names of the people who built it, and humble enough that no one had spent two thousand years polishing it into something grand and untouchable.

Not a world religion with a billion followers, in other words. Something handmade.

The Samin of Java are exactly that. Their dharma was assembled, more or less in front of the historical record, by a single farmer and his neighbours, beginning around 1890. We know roughly when it started, what set it off, what it asked of people, and how it spread. We can watch it being made. And because we can watch it being made, it tells us something the ancient traditions cannot, not because it is wiser than they are, but because the machinery has not yet been hidden behind a curtain of scripture and the fog of time.

So this part is a close-up. One dharma, in a few hundred square kilometres of teak forest, held up to the light.

An illiterate farmer in the teak forests

The man on the road has a name, or rather several. He was born Raden Kohar, probably in 1859, in the Blora region of central Java: a flat, hot country famous for its teak. As a grown man he took the name Samin Surosentiko, and it is as 'Samin' that he entered history, mostly through the alarmed reports of the people trying to govern him.

There is a story about his father, and even if it is only half true, it tells you something about where the movement's spirit came from. By tradition, his father, remembered as Samin Sepuh ('Samin the Elder'), was a nobleman from Ponorogo who renounced his aristocratic rank to live as a

commoner, in deliberate opposition to Dutch rule. Whether or not the bloodline is exact, the gesture is the seed of the whole movement: a turning away from status, a choice to go down rather than up.

From about 1890, Samin began teaching in his home village and the surrounding villages. What he taught was not, at first, a revolt. It was a way of living. But it landed in a world that was being squeezed hard, and that is what turned a quiet ethic into a movement.

In 1897 the Dutch colonial forestry service drew a line around the teak forests that the villagers had always used – for firewood, for building, for grazing, for the thousand small needs of a subsistence life – and declared them restricted: state forest, off limits. At the same time, the colonial taxes pressed down: a land rent, a poll tax, a tax on what little the farmers produced. To a family living at the edge of enough, the fencing of the forest and the demand for cash were hunger, made by a distant authority that gave nothing back.

This is the soil in which the Samin dharma grew, and the pattern already has a name that fits, from the anthropologist James C Scott: the *moral economy of the peasant*. Scott argued that peasant communities carry a deep value-system 'irrevocably linked to subsistence requirements', a shared sense of what people owe each other, and what a community is owed, organised entirely around the basic right to survive. When an outside power, a market or a colonial state, tears up those customary rights of access in the name of profit or order, it takes more than resources. It violates a moral world. The Samin response was the defence of that moral world, raised into a creed.

And that creed spread. From Blora it travelled across an arc of districts (Rembang, Pati, Kudus, Grobogan, Bojonegoro), reaching, by one estimate, somewhere between three and five thousand followers by 1907. That was the year it became too visible to ignore. The Dutch arrested Samin and exiled him to Sawahlunto, in West Sumatra, far across the sea, where he died in 1914. His followers did not accept that he had simply died. They

held that he had attained *moksha* (release, liberation) and passed into the spiritual realm, a detail that will matter later.

The code

So what did the Samin actually believe? What follows is a reconstruction through other people's windows – I will make a fuller accounting of those windows shortly – but its shape is consistent across them, and for a movement the Dutch treated as a dangerous sect, the content is strikingly down-to-earth. There is barely any theology in it at all; it is a code for conduct, not a map of heaven.

The recurring principles, as best we can reconstruct them, are these. Be honest, *jujur*, and speak plainly. Do no violence, and be self-sufficient: live by the work of your own hands, your own farm. Keep life simple; do not chase material excess. Do not disturb or harm other people, and avoid envy, greed, and quarrelling. And do not take ill-gotten gain, especially in trade and commerce: the Samin were deeply suspicious of the merchant's habit of getting something for nothing.

Underneath these everyday rules sits one conviction with real teeth, the one that made the movement dangerous: that *land, water, and forest are common property*, to be used for the common good. Not the king's, not the colonial state's, not a company's. Everyone's. That single idea is the doctrinal root of both the tax-and-forest resistance of Samin's own day and, as we will see, the environmental struggle his descendants are still fighting now.

They called their faith *Agama Adam*, 'the religion of Adam'. The name is a claim: that this was humanity's original religion, the simple thing we all had before the priests and the empires got to us. Its practice was correspondingly bare: prayer at dawn and dusk, no professional clergy, and almost none of the elaborate ceremonial apparatus that surrounded Javanese village life. A plain ethic for plain people.

The whole thing was carried by mouth. Samin was illiterate, and so were his followers; there was no scripture, no holy book to copy, guard, and argue over. The ethic travelled by recitation, by example, and by embodied practice, including a discipline called *laku jejek*, days of walking to reach a community gathering. A dharma with no text, held in nothing but memory and the soles of people's feet.

That picture needs one qualification, and the exception is revealing. A handful of texts are, in fact, attributed to the tradition (most often a manuscript called the *Serat Jamus Kalimosodo*), and some Samin families keep a *kris*, the wavy ceremonial blade of Java, as an heirloom that carries the teaching down the generations. So the Samin were not quite textless; they distrusted the written word as the instrument of the mullah, the clerk, and the tax-collector, and inclined to trust instead the things a person keeps in the body.

Javanese spiritual life has a word for this: *laku*, meaning something close to 'conduct', or 'the path you walk', a discipline you practise rather than a doctrine you read. Seen that way, the *laku jejek*, those days of walking to a gathering, was not a quaint custom bolted onto the ethic; it *was* the ethic, rehearsed in the legs. The deadpan literalism on the forest road belonged to the same family: honesty drilled into a reflex, plain speech worn so smooth it could answer an empire without stopping to think. How a dharma installs itself, through what its people repeatedly do at least as much as through what they believe, is a story for a later part; the Samin, with no scripture to argue over, had almost nothing *but* the doing. It made them very hard to convert and even harder to stamp out. You cannot burn a book that was never written; you can only try to outlast the people who walk it, and on that score the Samin have proved stubbornly patient, generation after generation.

One more thing, before we go on, about names. The followers themselves came to dislike the word 'Samin' because, in mainstream Indonesian society, it picked up a sneer: a synonym for backward, foolish, primitive. They prefer to call themselves *Sedulur Sikep*, or *wong sikep*: roughly, 'honest,

responsible kin'; a *wong sikep*, in the older idiom, is 'a man who embraces', one who embraces his wife and his land. It is a better name, and from here I will use both: theirs by preference, and 'Samin' where the history insists.

But is it a dharma?

Now, a sceptic could stop me right here. *Plenty of villages have customs*, the sceptic says. *Lots of communities are truthful, simple, and suspicious of outsiders. You have described a set of folkways with a local accent. Why dignify it with a word like 'dharma'? Aren't you just doing the thing this project warned against, slapping an exotic label on ordinary peasant life?*

It is a fair challenge, and the Samin are where our definition gets tested against a real case. Back in Part 1, we worked out what separates a dharma from mere custom or law or etiquette. Not its content (there is no single belief that makes something a dharma) but a *combination* of features. I will run the Sedulur Sikep against that test, in plain language.

First: is it *comprehensive*? Does it govern a whole life, or just one corner of behaviour? The Sikep code clearly does the former. It tells you how to work, how to speak, what you may own, how to treat your neighbours, how to deal with authority, even how to understand death. It is an architecture for living, not a rule about one thing.

The *wong sikep* do not say that a person dies. They say *salin sandhangan*, changing clothes: what wears out is the garment, the body, and the life inside it goes on – back, on the tellings the ethnographers have collected, into a person again, into one's own descendants, or simply 'gathered with the living'. The rite is as bare as the belief. The village religious official is given no part. The body is washed, or deliberately not washed if the dead person is thought to have held firm to the teaching; it is wrapped in white cloth or a plain *jarit*, laid level and face up, not turned toward Mecca, and buried without the Islamic prayers and without the words spoken into the grave. There is one shared meal, on the day of the burial, and then nothing: none of the Javanese cycle of feasts at seven, forty and a hundred

days, no headstone, no visiting of the grave, no anniversary. Contributions come in rice, sugar and cigarettes; money is handed back. On the Kudus telling, the good conduct of the dead attaches to the next generation, which is why the grave needs no tending. The same refusals run through it as through the rest of the code: no cleric, no cycle of feasts, no tended grave, no profit, no display; and the hope reaches forward through the lineage rather than upward to another world. In the Blora villages the rite has drifted toward the mosque, and the elder of Klopoduwur who died in 2025 was prayed over at the village mosque before burial; Kudus keeps the older form. Benda and Castles, quoting the provincial surveys of the 1950s, put the difference in a sentence: the Saminists' births and circumcisions looked like their neighbours', their marriages and burials did not.

Second: is it *identity-constituting*, does it tell people who they are? Unmistakably. To be Sedulur Sikep is to be one of 'the honest people'. It is a self; you can hear it in the very name they chose.

Third: is it *oriented toward the good*, rather than toward mere advantage? Yes. The *wong sikep* were after a particular kind of life, not the most profitable one – autonomous, truthful, harmonious, rooted in the land – and they paid for it in taxes refused and forests lost.

And the fourth feature is the decisive one: is it *reflective and self-aware*? Here is where this dharma and mere custom part company for good. Ordinary village tradition is usually inherited and seldom held up for examination. You do it because it is done, because your parents did it, because that is simply how things are. What the Sedulur Sikep did is far rarer, and they did it out loud. They *consciously chose* a set of values, lifted them out of the surrounding culture, gave them a name, and defended them deliberately, against the dominant order of their day. They knew they were being different, and they meant to be.

That lifting is what turned the Sedulur Sikep's folkways into a dharma, and they would tell you so, in blunt language, to your face.

Which brings us to the language.

Speaking *ngoko* to the king

To feel how radical the *wong sikep* really were, you have to see what they were rebelling against, and it was not only the Dutch. It was the entire intricate hierarchy of Javanese culture itself.

The classic map of that culture comes from anthropologist Clifford Geertz, who in 1960 divided Javanese society into three streams: the *abangan*, the syncretic peasant majority who blended Islam with older mystical and animist traditions; the *santri*, the devout, orthodox Muslims; and the *priyayi*, the refined aristocratic-bureaucratic class tied to the courts. Scholars have argued about this scheme ever since (it is an ideal type, not a perfect description), but it gives us the lay of the land.

And running through all of it was an exquisitely graded etiquette, encoded in the Javanese language itself. Javanese has levels. There is *ngoko*, blunt and low, the speech you use with intimates and inferiors; there is *krama*, high and refined, the speech you use to show respect to your superiors; and there is a middle register between them. In ordinary life, you perform your place in the social order every time you open your mouth. You address the person above you in deferential *krama*, and you receive *ngoko* in return, and the whole hierarchy is rehearsed, sentence by sentence, all day long.

The Sedulur Sikep refused the entire arrangement. They spoke plain, low *ngoko* to everyone: to each other, to officials, to anyone. To address a colonial administrator or a Javanese aristocrat in the same blunt register you would use with a child or a friend was a linguistic refusal of the whole hierarchy of deference. With grammar alone, they declined to admit that anyone stood above them.

They went further. Mainstream Javanese culture prized the ideal of *halus* (the refined, indirect, emotionally controlled, and impeccably polite person) and looked down on *kasar* (the coarse, blunt, and direct). The *wong*

sikep took that prestige ranking and turned it on its head. They made plain, literal, sometimes maddening truth-telling into a *virtue*. The deadpan answers on the forest road were not stupidity. They were *halus* turned inside out: a refusal to play the game of refined indirection, weaponised into politeness so literal it became a wall.

They minimised the ceremonial life, the elaborate ritual meals and observances, that gave mainstream Javanese religion its texture. And, following old Samin Sepuh's example, they refused the whole aristocratic-bureaucratic order: no tax, no forced labour, no marriage registration, no census.

But this creed was Java's own. The Sedulur Sikep were agrarian, mystical and rooted in the very same peasant world they were reforming; their suspicion of orthodox Islam was itself steeped in heterodox Javanese mysticism. They took Java's own materials and used them against Java's own hierarchy. The best name for that is not rebellion from without but *heresy from within*: an internal reform that knows the tradition intimately, because it is made of it.

A dharma, in other words, can be grown at home, out of the same soil, in deliberate argument with the culture that surrounds it.

'From the forest, to the forest'

Return, for a moment, to the deadpan on the road. It would be easy to file it under eccentricity. It was the Sikep dharma in action.

James C Scott, the same scholar who gave us the moral economy, spent much of his career studying how powerless people resist powerful ones without open battle, which they cannot win. He called the result the *weapons of the weak*: foot-dragging, feigned ignorance, false compliance, deliberate misunderstanding, the slow quiet sabotage of people who cannot say no out loud and so say it in a thousand other ways. He called the hidden world of grumbling and mockery, the one the powerful never get to see, the *hidden transcript*, and the whole domain of this everyday,

below-the-radar resistance *infra-politics*. (Scott never studied the Samin himself, but his frame describes them exactly.)

Read through Scott, the *wong sikep*'s tactics snap into focus. Answering an official with perfect, useless literalism is feigned ignorance raised to an art. Refusing to register a marriage, declining the census, paying only what cannot be avoided: these are the weapons of the weak, deployed with discipline. What makes the Sedulur Sikep extraordinary is that they took this scattered, instinctive repertoire of peasant resistance and *moralised* it, turning it into a named, principled, identity-bearing way of life. Most peasants drag their feet and keep the reasons in the hidden transcript. The *wong sikep* dragged their feet on principle, and were proud. Ethics and tactics had fused into one thing.

And beneath the tactics, it turns out, lay something like a philosophy of language. In the recorded testimony of one follower arrested in 1928, to which we will come shortly, the words that truly mattered were the few about work, marriage, and upright conduct; nearly every other word could be hollowed out or repurposed, often by punning, so that 'religion' could shade into the word for a weapon and 'tax' could, in the right mouth, mean nothing at all. A word, in this thinking, means what its utterer means by it, and an empire's word, spoken by an empire, could be handed back empty. The deadpan on the forest road was not merely feigned ignorance raised to an art. It was doctrine: a quiet claim of sovereignty over meaning itself.

There is an older current here too, one we have already met. Christopher Boehm's reverse dominance hierarchy, from Part 2, was his account of how human morality may have *begun*: as a device against domination, the many using ridicule, shaming, and ostracism to cut down anyone who tried to lord it over the group. If he is even partly right, then a dharma like the Samin's, defined almost entirely by its refusal of a domineering state, is morality doing one of the oldest jobs it ever had. The man on the forest road, answering the empire with riddles, was standing in a very long line.

A pause

I have been building a case, and before I finish it, three warnings are in order, because a dharma is exactly the kind of thing it is easy to romanticise, and I have been as charmed by this one as anyone.

The first is about the evidence. Almost everything we 'know' about Samin doctrine comes to us second hand, and often third hand, from outsiders: Dutch colonial officials and, later, ethnographers. The reason is the very thing that makes the movement so striking: the Samin themselves wrote almost nothing down. The historians Harry Benda and Lance Castles, in their foundational scholarly study, make this their central caution and note that the accounts we do have were frequently written by hostile or baffled observers. We are watching this dharma through a series of other people's windows, some of them grimy. This part adds a window of its own, and the reader should know what kind: a reading of the archive and of the scholars who did the fieldwork, not a report of conversations of my own.

There is one window that is less grimy than the rest, and what can be seen through it should adjust the whole picture. The historian Takashi Shiraishi dug out of the colonial archive the minutes of the interrogation of Dangir, a twenty-five-year-old follower arrested in 1928, who answered a native official's questions about his faith at length and in his own idiom: how he was initiated with five aphorisms about walking; why the ritual meal that sealed it could be paid for only with money from his own farm labour, never from trade, 'because traders usually get profit by cheating'; what an honest man may and may not do. It is the nearest thing we have to a Samin speaking, and even it reaches us, as Shiraishi says, doubly alienated, filtered through the official who wrote it down. But a voice it is, and it says something startling: Dangir denied being a 'Samin' at all. The word meant nothing to him; it was the government's label. He called himself *wong sikep*, a man who embraces, living the religion of Adam he had learned from a neighbouring teacher he could name.

Shiraishi's larger, uncomfortable lesson is that some of what the record calls 'the Samin movement' is an artefact of the record itself: colonial clerks joining scattered circles of quiet people into one remembered conspiracy, and some of the wilder material in the files, the prophecies of coming kings that fed the millenarian reading, arriving by way of paid informers telling their masters what subversion ought to sound like. Even the scholars disagree about what they are looking at: some read the Samin as an ethical-religious resistance movement, some as a millenarian one waiting for salvation and the return of their founder, some as hard-headed peasants rationally defending their livelihoods; and after Shiraishi, the second reading stands on visibly shakier ground than the others. When I tell you what the Samin 'believed', please hear the quotation marks. A dharma this good deserves a plain accounting of how little we can be sure of.

The second is sharper, and we have to face it squarely. The *wong sikep* were *not secular*. I have spent so long discussing them because they look, at first, like a do-it-yourself ethic with no god in it, a practical code about fair dealing, forests, and taxes. But that is not the whole truth. They had *Agama Adam*, the religion of Adam; they believed in an eternal soul, and that their founder did not die but attained *moksha*. There is metaphysics here, and a cosmology, and a hope that reaches past this life.

So why are they here at all when, in the end, the question is whether we can build ethical worlds without the supernatural?

Because they are a *boundary case*, and boundary cases are worth more than tidy examples. The Sedulur Sikep are not a world religion, with scripture, clergy, and empire. But they are not a secular philosophy either, like Stoicism stripped of its gods. They sit in between: a non-scriptural, non-institutional, this-worldly, ethics-first *folk* dharma, with just enough cosmology to give it a backbone and not an ounce more. There is a whole middle country of ways of living that are neither, and the Sedulur Sikep are its first sure landmark. For an argument that dharmas come in every form, an example that refuses our neat boxes is the best evidence we have.

The third warning I can only post here and honour later, because it needs a standard this book has not yet built. A dharma this admirable still had hard edges, and they pressed on its own people: for most of a century the *wong sikep* kept their children from school, and with it from letters, rather than hand them to the state's classroom; and the same tradition that will shortly give us nine heroic women at a palace gate also prescribed – and in the one village fieldworkers have studied closely still prescribes – a wife's place in a plainly patriarchal household. Whether a way of life can hold this well without crushing anyone inside it is a real question, not a rhetorical one, and Part 8 will put this very dharma through that test, without flinching, as its hardest case.

Feet in cement

The strongest proof that the *wong sikep* built a real dharma, and not a one-generation protest, is that it did not die with Samin. It is still being lived, and it has crossed a hundred years and an entire change of subject without losing its spine.

The century in between was not quiet, and it shows what the refusal was really aimed at. When the Dutch left, the refusal stayed, since the thing being refused had never really been the Dutch; it was the state's claim to name and number people. Anthropologist Amrih Widodo, who has followed the community for decades, records what that meant under Suharto's New Order: pressure to fill in the religion column on the identity card, since the religion of Adam was not on the official list; mass wedding ceremonies arranged to pull unregistered Sikep marriages into the books of the religious bureaucracy; and, for those who declined, the threat of transmigration off Java altogether. The flags had changed and the census came anyway, and the Sedulur Sikep answered the independent republic much as they had answered the empire.

Travel to the Kendeng mountains today, and you will find the Sedulur Sikep still there, still honest, still stubborn, and now fighting a new enemy. The Kendeng is karst country: soft, porous limestone that soaks up rain

and feeds the springs and rivers the farmers below depend on. Since the 2000s, they have been at the forefront of non-violent resistance across the districts of Rembang, Pati, and Grobogan against limestone quarrying and a large cement plant operated by the company PT Semen Indonesia. Their argument is the very same one their great-grandparents made to the Dutch foresters: that land, water and forest are common property, and that protecting the karst, the rock that holds the region's water, is a sacred duty, not a thing to be blasted away for profit.

And in 2016, and again in 2017, they made that argument in the most physical way imaginable: nine women at the gates of the Presidential Palace, with wet cement poured around their feet. They are remembered as the *Kartini Kendeng*. The image is almost unbearably apt: the *wong cilik*, the 'little people', literally encased in the very substance the industry wanted to make from their mountains, immobilised in the capital to dramatise the immobilising of their land. They held there in the heat and the noise. Patmi did not long survive the second of those protests: the night after the cement came off her feet, her heart gave out.

Why was it women who made that journey, and women whose names the protest still carries? They named themselves after Raden Ajeng Kartini, the Javanese noblewoman whose letters, written in Samin's own lifetime, became the founding text of Indonesian women's emancipation. And they came not in spite of being mothers and farmers but *because* of it, framing the defence of the water and the soil as one continuous piece with the daily work of keeping a family fed: the mountains were the kitchen, the springs were the tap, and a cement company was proposing to demolish both. A farmer named Sukinah made that argument her own. The tactic was shrewd: by standing on the most traditional ground available to them (motherhood, the household, the duty to feed) these women advanced a genuinely radical claim about who owns a landscape, and dared the state to be seen hauling mothers in cement away from the palace gate. It is the old Samin move, intact.

The law, for once, sided with the farmers: Indonesia's Supreme Court ruled in their favour in October 2016. And then the provincial governor issued a fresh permit within days, and the plant went ahead anyway: a bleak little lesson in the difference between winning a ruling and winning a fight.

But look at what has happened to the Sikep dharma. The colonial-era creed – common property, non-violence, refusal of an extractive authority – has been recoded for an age its founder could never have imagined. And the recoding was work, done in company: the Sedulur Sikep stand today inside a wider network of Kendeng farmers, joined by lawyers, environmental groups and city sympathisers; they borrow the nation's own icons (Kartini was no Samin); and they argue in courtrooms their great-grandparents would have refused to enter. Continuity of spine is not sameness of body. The enemy is no longer a Dutch forester with a tax ledger; it is a cement company with a court-proof permit. The forest has become the watershed. And the deadpan refusal on the road has become a woman with her feet in concrete, refusing to move. Same spine, new century. That is what a living dharma looks like: a way of living flexible enough to meet a threat its makers never foresaw, and rigid enough, at the core, to still be recognisably itself.

What the *wong sikep* know

So what was waiting, all along, in the teak country of Blora?

A dharma with the lid off. No prophet on a mountain, no book handed down from the sky, no two-thousand-year pedigree to make it untouchable. Just an illiterate farmer and his neighbours, in a squeezed and unjust corner of a colonised island, deciding (deliberately, against the grain of their own culture and the full weight of an empire) how they were going to live. And then living it so completely, and teaching it so well, with nothing but their voices and their feet, that the way outlasted the man by a century and walked itself from a colonial tax revolt into an environmental protest, changing its body but never its spine.

That is the thing the great traditions can no longer easily show us, and the *wong sikep* can. We are used to thinking of a dharma as something ancient and given, something you are born into or convert to, something you *find*. The Sedulur Sikep let us watch the opposite happen. A dharma is something a community *makes*, and then *keeps*, by choosing it, naming it, and saying, over and over, with their feet in the cement if it comes to that: *this is who we are.*

If even one small, poor, unlettered community in the forests of Java could build a whole ethical world without scripture, clergy, or institutional machinery, and defend it for a hundred years, then dharmas are not relics we inherit. They are things people make. Which means that, eventually, they are things *we* could make, too.

But the *wong sikep* are only one. Having seen a dharma assembled this clearly, in this much close up, you start to notice them everywhere, and they are not all alike: a single South African word that contains an entire theory of the self; a Roman emperor's private notebook; a song that maps a thousand kilometres of desert; a promise made in another desert, half a world away, that founded three religions. The teak forest was one country. Next, we cross into the others.

« 2: The genesis of dharmas | 4: A world of dharmas »

Sources & further reading

This part is built from the project's research notes, which carry the full inline citations. Listed here are the notes it draws on and the key works behind them.

Research notes

Research notes used in this book are published on GitHub – https://github.com/Biksu-Okusi/In-Search-of-Dharma.

- 4.1 Samin of Java – origins, the Sikep ethical code and *Agama Adam*, the dharma-fit argument, the break from mainstream Javanese culture, and the Kendeng turn. The spine of this part.
- 1.3 Boundary & Definition – the four-feature test (comprehensiveness, internalisation/identity, ethical orientation, reflective self-awareness) used to answer 'but is it really a dharma?'
- 7.3 Dharma & Power – Boehm's 'reverse dominance hierarchy' and morality as an anti-domination device; the dharma defined by its refusal of the state.
- 8.1 Planetary Dharma – the frame for reading the Kendeng turn as a contemporary, place-based ecological dharma, developed further in Part 8.

Key works

- Harry J Benda & Lance Castles, 'The Samin Movement', *Bijdragen tot de Taal-, Land- en Volkenkunde* 125(2) (1969): 207–240 – the canonical scholarly study; the central caution that all accounts derive from outsiders because the Samin were illiterate.
- Takashi Shiraishi, 'Dangir's Testimony: Saminism Reconsidered', *Indonesia* 50 (1990): 95–120 – the 1928 interrogation minutes, the nearest thing to a Samin first-person source; 'Samin' as the state's label for the self-named *wong sikep*; the movement as partly an artefact of the colonial file, the millenarian evidence as partly spy-mediated, and the Samin doctrine of language.

- APE Korver, 'The Samin Movement and Millenarism' (1976) – the contested millenarian reading (salvation expectation; the return-of-Samin / *moksha* motif), now weakened at its evidentiary root by Shiraishi's archival work.
- Anis Sholeh Ba'asin & Muhammad Anis Ba'asin, *Samin: Mistisisme Petani di Tengah Pergolakan* (Semarang) – the Indonesian account behind two scenes in this part, and the route to a primary record: it quotes the Dutch East Indies newspaper *Het Nieuws van den Dag* of 5 March 1907 on the interrogation of the arrested Samin Surosentiko ('My body is my home'), and reports at p. 63 the *patih*'s interrogation of a follower who answers that he owes the state nothing, is slapped for it, and declines to be angry because the officer has his duty and the Sikep has his. A note on the opening scene: the forest-road exchange with which this part begins is widely reported in Indonesian sources but appears in none of the three canonical English-language studies above. It is offered here as what it is – a well-attested Indonesian tradition about how these people spoke to power, not a line from the colonial archive.
- Amrih Widodo, 'Samin in the New Order: The Politics of Encounter and Isolation', in Jim Schiller & Barbara Martin-Schiller (eds.), *Imagining Indonesia: Cultural Politics and Political Culture* (Ohio University Center for International Studies, 1997), 261–287 – the community under Suharto: the religion column, mass marriage registration, and transmigration threats.
- Nancy Lee Peluso, *Rich Forests, Poor People: Resource Control and Resistance in Java* (University of California Press, 1992) – the three-century political economy of state forestry and criminalised customary access behind the 1897 enclosure.
- Clifford Geertz, *The Religion of Java* (1960) – the *abangan* / *santri* / *priyayi* map and the *ngoko* / *krama* speech-level hierarchy that the Samin refused.
- James C Scott, *The Moral Economy of the Peasant* (1976), *Weapons of the Weak* (1985), and *Domination and the Arts of Resistance: Hidden Transcripts* (1990) – the peasant moral economy, the 'weapons of the weak', and

the 'hidden transcript' / 'infra-politics' of below-the-radar refusal; the comparative frame for the Samin's tactics.

- Christopher Boehm, *Hierarchy in the Forest* (1999) – egalitarian foragers and the 'reverse dominance hierarchy'; morality's deep origin as a check on domination.
- On *salin sandhangan* and the Sikep funeral: Siti Munawaroh, Christriyati Ariani & Suwarno, *Etnografi Masyarakat Samin di Bojonegoro* (Balai Pelestarian Nilai Budaya Yogyakarta, 2015); Moh Rosyid, 'Studi Komparatif Konsep Ketuhanan Islam dan Agama Adam', *Ulumuna* (2012), and 'Komunitas Samin: Agama Adam dan Ajarannya', *Hanifiya* (2023), for the Kudus rite and its drift; and *detikJateng*'s reporting of Mbah Wargono's burial (February 2022) and of the Blora elders' funerals (2025–26). The 1950s contrast is Benda & Castles quoting the provincial volumes.
- Reporting on the Kendeng resistance – the *Kartini Kendeng*, the 2016 and 2017 feet-in-cement protests at the Presidential Palace, and Patmi's death (Mongabay, 2020; *Indonesia at Melbourne*, University of Melbourne).
- The living Indonesian scholarship – S Setiadi, A Saraswati & N Rosyid, 'Geger Sikep: Environmental (Re)Interpretation among the Contemporary Anti-Cement Movement in Kendeng, Central Java', *Komunitas* 9(1) (2017): 13–28; Moh Rosyid, 'Memotret Agama Adam: Studi Kasus pada Komunitas Samin', *Orientasi Baru* 23(2) (2014) – the community as an object of active Indonesian research, not only of colonial and Western memory.

4: A world of dharmas

Audio: Part 4: in search of dharma



A world of dharmas

A relational web, a rational fortress, a sung land, an open hand, a commanding covenant: five ways of living that disagree about almost everything, and rhyme underneath. Including, if you have the nerve to look, your own.

Picture five people, in five worlds, each answering the same question: how should a person live?

An elder in a southern African village is asked what makes a good person, and she does not start with the person at all. She starts with everyone else. A human being, she says, becomes human only through other human beings; you are a person because, and only because, you belong to a people.

A Roman emperor sits in a campaign tent on a freezing frontier, writing to himself by lamplight, reminding himself that the empire he commands, the body he inhabits, and the very next breath he takes are not finally his to keep, and that the only thing that is truly his, the only thing worth guarding, is the quality of his own choices.

An old man in the Australian desert walks a path his ancestors walked, singing as he goes, because the song is the map and the law and the history all at once, and the land beneath his feet is not scenery but scripture, sung into being and sung into order.

In a court city on Java, a bank clerk sits at home in the evening with his eyes closed, doing what looks like nothing at all: practising the hardest discipline he knows, the letting go of discipline itself, releasing opinion, effort, and will so that, as he would put it, God may act through him.

And somewhere in the ancient Near East, a person sets out, quite deliberately, to *walk a way*: to live every hour, the meals and the washing and the buying and the burying, according to a path laid down in a covenant between a people and their God.

Five answers. They look nothing alike. The first dissolves the self into the community; the second builds a fortress around it. The third writes the law into the ground; the fourth hands the self over to its God; the fifth receives the law from the sky. And yet they rhyme. What follows is a tour of that strangeness, the irreducible variety of human dharmas, and the stubborn family likeness that runs underneath them all.

How far can they get?

The *wong sikep* of Part 3 were one dharma, watched up close. Now pull back and take in the range, because the plurality is a real and sometimes dizzying fact about the human world. So we are going to visit five dharmas that grew up far apart, look at each on its own terms, and only then ask what, if anything, holds across them. One thread runs through every stop: where each dharma draws its circle of care, who it gathers in and who it leaves outside.

I am going to end the tour with the one many of you were raised inside, the family of Jewish, Christian, and Muslim ethics, and I should say why. The whole wager here is that we can look at dharmas without privileging any of them, including our own. That is easy to say about somebody else's tradition and hard to do about the water you were swimming in before you could see it. So the Abrahamic covenant comes last, as the real test of whether the non-privileging eye can be turned around to look at itself.

And one tradition needs different handling, so let me do it here at the door, before the tour proper. Buddhism, the tradition through which the word *dharma* reached most of us, is this project's home water: the one I look *with* more than *at*, the source of half my instruments and, as the Preface disclosed, the name on this book's cover. I cannot cross-examine it with the detachment I am asking of you, and for most of this project's life I used that as a reason to excuse it from the stand. That was a mistake, or at least a fingerprint pretending to be a courtesy. Partiality disclosed is not exemption earned. So let it take the witness chair like everyone else, briefly, with my hands where you can watch them.

As a dharma it is the textbook case; Part 1 already scored its four features full marks, and no one contests them. The real questions are the ones this book is building toward: does it hold without crushing, and who may revise it? On holding, twenty-five centuries at every scale from forest hermitage to imperial church speak for themselves. On crushing, the record is there like every other great tradition's. The Vinaya's own account

has the founder admitting women to ordination while attaching eight ‘heavy rules’ that subordinate every nun, however senior, to any monk, however junior; the women’s ordination lineage was then allowed to die out across the Theravada world for most of a millennium, and its modern restoration is still being fought over by hierarchies that hold the keys; and when the holding turned ethnonational, it produced the preaching monk Part 6 will meet.

On revision, the founding archive contains one of the most instructive scenes in any tradition: on his deathbed the Buddha explicitly permitted the sangha to abolish the lesser and minor rules after him, a revision hatch built in by the founder himself. At the First Council, months later, the elders, unsure which rules counted as lesser, resolved the doubt by abolishing none of them. The hatch was welded almost before the body was cold, and the great revisions since have mostly come from the margins or the exits: the half-million who will walk out with Ambedkar in Part 6, the modernist remaking Part 8 returns to, Batchelor’s secular reconstruction out at the far edge.

So examined, Buddhism stands where the others on this tour will stand: a magnificent holding system with its pauses on the record, at the women and at the welded hatch. And one fingerprint, stated plainly: the secular dharma this book works in descends from the revisable margin of this tradition, which is surely part of why I prize revisability. A lens ground at the margin will find the margin admirable. Now you know that too, and can discount accordingly.

Ubuntu: the self is a ‘we’

Start in southern Africa, with a single sentence in the Nguni languages: *umuntu ngumuntu ngabantu*. ‘A person is a person through other persons’. In its travelling English form it became ‘I am because we are’, and behind that gentle slogan sits one of the most radical claims any dharma makes, a claim that reaches past how you should behave to what you fundamentally *are*.

In the world most of my readers grew up in, the individual comes first. You are a self, complete and bounded, and then you enter into relationships, take on duties, join groups. Descartes gave that world its motto: *I think, therefore I am.* The lone mind is the bedrock. Ubuntu turns this inside out. The proverb is Nguni; the argument it carries runs the length of the continent. On the account given by the Nigerian philosopher Ifeanyi Menkiti, personhood is not something you are issued at birth; it is something you *achieve*, and you achieve it only by taking your place in a community and discharging what you owe it. You can be a living, breathing member of the species and still not yet be, in the full sense, a person, because personhood is a moral accomplishment, grown in the soil of relationship. The self grows out of the 'we'.

It is tempting to hear in this the simple erasure of the individual, the single person swallowed whole by the group, and Ubuntu's own thinkers are alert to the misreading. One of them, the Ghanaian philosopher Kwame Gyekye, pushed back against the most radical version, the one that would make the community the entire substance of the person. A fully realised human being, he insisted, is also a chooser and a reasoner, a bearer of conscience who can and sometimes must stand against the group when the group has gone wrong. Ubuntu at its best does not abolish the individual; it denies that the individual comes *first*. There is a real difference between saying you are nothing but your relationships and saying you become yourself through them, and the more careful readings of Ubuntu mean the second.

In the hands of Thaddeus Metz, a philosopher working in South Africa, Ubuntu hardens into a precise moral theory: an action is right insofar as it honours relationships in which people recognise themselves in one another and act in solidarity. And it has done real public work. When apartheid ended and South Africa had to decide what to do with the torturers and killers of the old regime, it did not reach mainly for the courtroom and the prison. Under Desmond Tutu, it established a Truth and Reconciliation Commission, an attempt to heal a fractured

community by bringing the truth to light and reintegrating even perpetrators into the moral world, rather than simply exacting retribution. And when the new Constitutional Court struck down the death penalty, it did so partly in the name of Ubuntu, holding that a state which kills its own betrays the recognition of shared humanity on which a decent society rests. A proverb became a principle of constitutional law.

That sentence needs one qualification, because the timing is stranger than it looks. The proverb is old. Its use as the *definition* of Ubuntu appears to be recent: the historian of ideas Christian Gade, tracing when people actually wrote the two together, puts it between 1993 and 1995, the very years of the interim constitution and the founding of the Truth and Reconciliation Commission. He offers that as a hypothesis about the written record rather than a claim about what villages said, and it does not make Ubuntu an invention. But it does mean the warm ancestral picture and the constitutional moment arrived more or less hand in hand, each lending the other authority. A dharma being consolidated exactly when a country needed one is not a scandal. It is my whole argument about how dharmas get made: as a *response* to external pressure.

I have to add the shadow, because every dharma on this tour has one, and Ubuntu's is instructive. The warm picture of timeless African togetherness is, in part, a story told later, and it can be put to ugly uses: a demand for 'harmony' can be a demand for silence, a way of shaming the dissenter and protecting the powerful. And there is a bitter irony on the record. The same post-apartheid South Africa that wrote Ubuntu into its highest law has seen waves of murderous violence against migrants from *other* African countries, the supposed brothers and sisters of the human family attacked as unwanted strangers. The web that includes can also exclude. We have met this before, the hard edge around the warm circle, and we will meet it again.

The Stoics: the fortress inside

Now travel back, to the Greek and Roman world, for a dharma that will feel oddly modern, because it is one of the most nearly secular the ancient world produced.

Two of its greatest teachers could hardly have been further apart in station. Epictetus was born a slave, and taught, after he was freed, that no master could touch the one thing that mattered. Marcus Aurelius was the most powerful man in the Roman world, its emperor, and spent his private nights reminding himself of exactly the same thing. That a slave and an emperor could practise one and the same discipline, and arrive at one and the same freedom, tells you most of what Stoicism is.

Its core is a single, bracing distinction that Epictetus put at the very front of his handbook: some things are up to us, and some things are not. Our opinions, our intentions, our own choices and responses are ours. Almost everything else – our bodies, our reputations, our wealth, the behaviour of other people, the turn of events – is not finally in our control. The whole of wisdom, the Stoics taught, is to draw that line clearly and then to invest your hopes and your sense of yourself *only* on the inner side of it. Want what is up to you, accept what is not, and no tyrant, no accident, no loss can reach the citadel of your character. Virtue, the excellence of your own choosing self, is the only true good; everything else is, at most, raw material to be used well or badly.

Underneath the ethics sat a picture of the cosmos as fundamentally rational, ordered by what the Greeks called the *logos*, a reason running through all things, which a human being could align with by living 'according to nature'. But that metaphysics sits lightly on the practice. You do not have to believe in a particular god to draw Epictetus's line between the controllable and the uncontrollable and to reorder your life around it. Which is why Stoicism has come roaring back in our own anxious, secular century, repackaged in a thousand books and apps for people who would

never set foot in a temple. It is a dharma that travels with remarkably little metaphysical luggage, a portable fortress for the self.

I should say that the Stoics themselves would dispute that, and so do many of their best modern readers. For Epictetus the cosmos is providentially ordered, and 'living according to nature' means aligning with a rational plan that is actually there; scholars like AA Long argue that the theology is not decoration but load-bearing, the thing that makes the resignation reasonable rather than merely stoical in the small-letter sense. Accept the universe when it is governed by reason and you are trusting; accept it when it is governed by nothing and you are just bracing. So the better description is not that Stoicism came without luggage. It is that the luggage can be, and is being, left behind, and that the practice keeps working well enough for millions of people to carry on. We are about to meet a Javanese fellowship doing the very same operation on its own idea of God, and it will raise the question this whole book is walking toward: how much of a dharma's metaphysics can you unscrew before the thing stops holding?

And the fortress points outward, in a way you might not expect from a philosophy of the inner citadel. If reason runs through all things, then it runs through all people, and every human being, slave or emperor, shares in the same *logos* and the same fundamental worth. The Stoics drew the obvious conclusion and called themselves citizens of the world, members of a single community of rational beings that takes no account of city, tribe or birth. Marcus, ruling an empire built on conquest, reminded himself nonetheless that he owed the foreigner the same basic regard he owed his own kin. Set beside the others on this tour, the contrast is sharp: where Ubuntu binds you tightly to a particular people and the Dreaming, our next stop, to a particular country, the Stoic stretches the circle to its widest possible edge, the whole of humanity at once. The same impulse to draw a circle of care, and wildly different ideas about where to draw it.

It has its own failure mode, of course. Push the acceptance of 'what is not up to us' too far and the fortress becomes a retreat: a counsel of passivity

that can shade into indifference toward injustice you might actually be able to change. And one question presses on any philosophy that says externals do not matter: it is a good deal easier to believe that wealth and status are indifferent when, like Marcus, you already have all of both. A dharma can be true and still be more comfortable for some to hold than others.

The Dreaming: the law in the land

Now go to Australia, and to dharmas so old and so unlike the others that they stretch the very category: the hundreds of distinct Aboriginal traditions the English language clumsily gathers under a single word, the Dreaming.

Begin by throwing away three things you might think a serious ethical tradition needs. There is no scripture, because there is no writing. There is no founder, no Buddha, Christ or Confucius at the origin. And there is no separate 'code', no list of commandments you could copy onto a page. Instead, there is the *Tjukurrpa*, to give it its Western Desert name, for each language has its own: a word that means the ancestral past, the present reality, the moral law, and the structure of the world, all at once. The anthropologist WEH Stanner, seeking a way to translate it, coined the word 'everywhen': a time that is not back then but always, in which the acts of the ancestral beings who shaped the land remain a living present, still holding the law in place.

And where is this law written, if not in a book? It is written in the land itself, and in the songs that cross it. The famous songlines are paths through the country, and to sing the song in order is to recite the features of the landscape in order, and woven into the same performance are the law, the genealogy, the ethics, and the map. The land is the scripture, and you read it by walking and singing. It is dharma as total order, carried entirely in voice, movement, and place.

You might think something so unwritten must be vague or quick to drift, but the evidence says otherwise. Researchers gathered Aboriginal stories from twenty-one places around the Australian coast, all describing a time when the sea stood lower, and the shore lay further out. They are not myths in the dismissive sense. On the reading of the geographer Patrick Nunn and the linguist Nicholas Reid, who did the matching, they appear to be memories of the coastlines that drowned when the last ice age ended, carried by mouth, faithfully enough to still fit the geology, for something between seven and thirteen thousand years. Oral does not mean fragile. High fidelity across hundreds of generations turns out to be an achievement of careful cultural machinery.

Two features recur across Indigenous traditions well beyond Australia, each belonging to its own people rather than to a single Indigenous creed. The first is what some call kincentricity: the moral circle extends beyond human beings to encompass the living world, so that the river, the animal, and the plant are not resources but relatives, owed the same reciprocity you owe your kin. The botanist Robin Wall Kimmerer, writing from the Potawatomi tradition, calls humans 'the younger brothers of Creation', the ones with the most to learn. The second is the long time horizon: the Haudenosaunee of North America, who maintained an entire constitution orally for centuries, are famous for the principle that every serious decision must be weighed for its effects on the generations to come. (The 'seven generations' wording everyone quotes is a later crystallisation; the Great Law as the chiefs dictated it in 1900 says 'future generations', which is demanding enough.) Place, kin, and the unborn are all inside the circle of care.

The scholar Vine Deloria Jr drew a distinction that is better used as a lens than as a filing system: religions of time and religions of space. The Abrahamic traditions, the reflective traditions of the first millennium BCE, and arguably the secular outlook as well, are religions of time. They tell a universal story that runs from a beginning toward an end, and because the story does not depend on any particular patch of ground, it can be packed

up and carried anywhere, preached on any continent. The Dreaming is a religion of space. It is *this* land, these rocks, that waterhole, and the law is written into the country itself. That portability we take for granted in the great missionary faiths is not a universal feature of dharmas at all. Some of them are bolted to the earth, and mean nothing the moment you remove them from it.

It is dangerously easy for outsiders, especially guilty modern ones, to turn Indigenous peoples into a fantasy of the noble ecological saint, the human who lived in perfect harmony with nature, as a stick to beat our own civilisation with. The anthropologist Shepard Krech showed how much that image is a projection, and how Indigenous peoples, like all peoples, in fact shaped and sometimes depleted their environments. The real lesson is more useful than the fantasy: these traditions encode genuinely powerful wisdom about living within limits, and they do so without their holders having to be angels. We can learn from a dharma, as one of its own custodians warned, without going around in borrowed feathers, pretending to own or to become it.

Sumarah: the open hand

Now come back to Java. The island that gave us the Samin has more than one dharma to teach, and the second could hardly be less like the first. The Samin met the world with refusal: flat speech, stubborn plainness, a wall of polite no. In the court city of Yogyakarta, some forty-five years after Samin Surosentiko began teaching in the teak country, a quieter movement grew from the opposite gesture, and its whole teaching is already in its name. *Sumarah* is Javanese for total surrender.

It began in 1935, when a palace retainer and bank clerk named Sukinohartono took the experiences that came to him in practice to be revelation. A circle of friends formed around what he had received, grew through the Japanese occupation and the revolutionary war, and organised itself around 1950 as Paguyuban Sumarah, the fellowship of those who surrender. What the fellowship does is called *sujud*. People sit together,

usually weekly and for hours at a stretch, in a guided, settling silence; body, feeling, and finally thinking are allowed to relax, attention comes to rest in *rasa*, the felt sense that Javanese tradition treats as an organ of knowing, and the practitioner surrenders every aspect of personal being, in the movement's own formula, 'so the self functions as a vehicle for God's will'.

Put this next to the Stoic and you have the tour's sharpest contrast. The Stoic drew a line around the one thing that was truly his, the quality of his own choices, and built a fortress on it. Sumarah gives exactly that away. Every other dharma we have visited tells you what to do with your will: bind it to the community, command it with reason, walk it along the songline. This one asks you to open your hand and let the will itself go. It is a fourth answer to what a person most deeply is: not a node in a web, not a citadel of choice, not a singer of country, but an instrument.

And it does this with almost none of the equipment a religion is supposed to need. There is no scripture; a guide named Pak Wondo put it flatly: 'In Sumarah we have no sacred book. Our sacred book is Life'. There are no temples, no clergy, and no creed to recite. Above all there is no guru. The only teacher who finally counts is the *guru sejati*, the true teacher within; the person who guides a session, the *pamong*, is understood not as a master but as a function, someone speaking spontaneously out of attunement to the people in the room, with an authority that lasts exactly as long as the attunement does. Even revelation must pass inspection. At the fellowship's 1950 congress its first chairman, Dr Surono, insisted that guidance claiming the highest source still had to be proven before the gathering: 'Even Sukino asks us for our agreement', he said, and then drew the boundary that earns Sumarah its place on this tour: 'We differ from religions, within which people accept God on faith and without knowledge'.

Nor, finally, is there anywhere to retreat to. The tradition's phrase for its own style is *tapa rame*, asceticism in the crowd: the practice carried on

inside ordinary working and family life, the surrender renewed at the desk and the market stall as much as in the meditation hall.

So where does this dharma draw its circle of care? At the doctrinal edge, more softly than any other stop on the tour. Most members are Muslims, but Buddhists and Christians sit in the same silence without ceasing to be Buddhists and Christians; one independent Indonesian study of the fellowship describes people of different religions joined in a single shared ritual, each remaining inside their own faith. Almost anyone, it seems, may sit, and nobody is asked to convert, because there is nothing to convert to: no profession of belief is required of anyone who takes a place in the silence, and the fellowship has never proselytised. The hard edge is practical instead.

A practice with no book, no technique, and no franchise can travel only by contact, person to person and session to session, and for most of its history it travelled in Javanese, sometimes in the difficult high Javanese of the founder's own guidance. Its near-twin Subud, born of the same Yogyakarta mystical circle in the same decade, wrapped a portable spiritual exercise in a uniform format and carried it around the world; Sumarah stayed a Javanese fellowship of a few thousand, its numbers peaking near ten thousand in the mid-1970s and drifting down ever since. Smallness, here, is not a failure of marketing. It is the price of refusing every reproducible form.

And the shadow. The openness has a floor, and the floor is God. When practitioners in Solo developed a religiously neutral 'relaxed meditation' for officials and foreigners, the leadership ruled from inside the practice that meditation without God 'led to void and not God', and the national chairman told the Western practitioners bluntly, 'I stress that you are not members'.

That floor has a history, and the history could not be spoken of while it was being made. After the coup of 1965, in the massacres that followed, somewhere between half a million and a million Indonesians suspected of

communism were killed, and atheism itself, though no statute ever named it, was treated as communism's twin: a citizen who professed no God was marked as subversive, and the mystical movements were told, in effect, that they could remain open exactly insofar as they put surrender to God at the front of what they were. Sumarah's God was not invented then; he is there in the founding vows of 1940, a generation before the terror.

And a further caution comes from the language itself: Javanese and Indonesian public speech is densely formulaic, and a talk that opens by acknowledging the One Almighty God is observing etiquette, not necessarily making theology. But from 1965 no one inside the movement could safely question that God, and no scholar who cared for the movement could ask the question in print, so how much of the policed theism was devotion, how much etiquette, and how much armour is something the record can no longer tell us. It could not be asked then. At this distance, it can.

A fellowship that tests truth by collective feeling has a characteristic failure mode as well, and its own historian records it: where everyone believes there ought to be unanimity, criticism is quietly repressed. And that historian is himself the final caution. Nearly everything the English-speaking world knows about Sumarah passes through one man, Paul Stange, a scholar who has also been a practitioner since 1971, and the teacher who, as the Preface records, first put this book's question in my path. I am not a neutral witness here, and neither are my sources. Whether a practice like this could give up its God and still be itself is a question held over, at full length, for Part 7.

The Covenant: looking at your own

For most readers in the Western world, the tradition you absorbed before you could choose, whether or not you still believe a word of it, is one of the three faiths that trace themselves to Abraham. And the reflex bred into the modern mind is to file these under a different and opposite heading from 'dharma': under *religion*, the thing of belief and faith and the

supernatural, as against ethics or philosophy or a way of life. That reflex is mistaken, and I should own that the bookshelf behind this project shares its tilt: heavy on evolution and secular philosophy, light on the faiths of Abraham. Judaism, Christianity, and Islam are, by every test we have used, dharmas like any other.

The clinching evidence is sitting in their own vocabulary. *Halakha*, the word for the whole body of Jewish practice, comes from a root meaning 'to walk', and it is best translated not as 'law' but as 'the way to walk'. *Sharia*, in Islam, literally means 'the path to water'. And the very first Christians, before anyone called them Christians, called themselves followers of 'the Way'. The same image in all three: a *path one walks*. That is the image the Indian traditions attach to *dharma* as well, and the plain meaning of its companion word *mārga*, the Sanskrit for a road or path. These traditions describe themselves, in their own oldest language, just as a dharma does.

And the path image goes deeper than etymology. The modern assumption that religion is essentially *belief*, a set of propositions you hold in your head, is a peculiar and recent one, shaped largely by Protestant Christianity. Judaism and Islam do not fit it well at all, because they are overwhelmingly traditions of *practice*: comprehensive orders covering food, law, marriage, money, the shape of the day and the shape of the year. When an observant Jew keeps kosher, or a Muslim pauses to pray five times between dawn and night, what is mainly happening is not a proposition being affirmed but a day being shaped. And for most of its history Christianity did not fit the belief picture either: the liturgy and the sacraments, the fasting calendar, confession, the monastic round of hours, made a Christian life a shaped day long before it was a list of affirmations. The belief-first picture is the Protestant exception, mistaken for the family rule. A shaped day is a dharma, by the definition we built. In this sense the great Abrahamic faiths are *more* dharma-like than the 'religion equals belief' picture allows.

What genuinely sets them apart is the kind of ground they stand on. The Indic, Chinese, and Indigenous dharmas tend to align you with an

impersonal order, the *ṛta* or the *Tao* or the law in the land. The Abrahamic dharmas instead rest on a *covenant*: a binding, personal, historical relationship between a people and a God who commands, promises, and remembers. The order is not a structure to be discerned but a Person to be answered. And where does this dharma draw its circle of care? A covenant binds a particular people, a chosen 'us' with a definite edge, even as Christianity and Islam extend the same logic outward, offering the covenant to anyone willing to walk its path. That is a real difference, and it brings real consequences, including the hard question we have already met of whether ethics that rests on God's command can outlive belief in that God.

Two common stereotypes deserve puncturing. Islam carries inside its own law a list of the law's higher purposes, the *maqasid*, which the medieval thinker al-Ghazali summed up as the protection of religion, life, intellect, lineage and property. That is a floor of protected human goods, built into the tradition centuries ago, and it looks remarkably like the list of basic human capabilities that Martha Nussbaum has proposed as a universal minimum. And Christianity contains two strands in tension. One, the Pauline strand, makes love the whole of ethics, declaring that 'love is the fulfilling of the law', and can seem to dissolve detailed path-walking into a single inner disposition. But alongside it runs another, the natural-law tradition that Thomas Aquinas built by marrying Christian faith to Aristotle, in which the core of morality is available to human reason reflecting on human nature, with no special revelation required. That strand is the direct ancestor of the secular, nature-grounded ethics I lean on. The supposed opposite of secular dharma turns out to contain one of its grandparents.

And these are living traditions, not fossils, which is what the secular eye most easily misses. The very *maqasid*, the higher purposes of the law, are what reformers reach for when they argue that a cruel or patriarchal reading has lost sight of what the law was *for*: movements such as Sisters in Islam contest extremist interpretations by reaching further into the

tradition rather than walking away from it. Both Islam and Judaism carry centuries of fierce internal argument, and both shelter mystical, inward streams, Sufism and Kabbalah, every bit as contemplative as anything in Buddhism. A dharma is not its most rigid and frightened version. To define other people's traditions by their fundamentalists while defining our own by their philosophers is a failure of the non-privileging eye.

If the Abrahamic paths are dharmas, then so is whatever I am doing here. The non-privileging stance, taken seriously, privileges *me* least of all.

What rhymes

So we have our five, and they really are profoundly different. Set them side by side and they disagree about the deepest things there are. They disagree about what a person even is: a node in a living web, a self-contained citadel of choice, or an instrument surrendered to its God. They disagree about time: a line running from creation to judgement, or an 'everywhen' in which the ancestral past is permanently present. They disagree about the ground of it all: an impersonal order you align with, a commanding God you answer to, a silent God you yield to, a land you belong to. This diversity does not melt away on inspection; it goes all the way down. The claim that the world's wisdom traditions are 'all really saying the same thing' does not survive a hard look at what they actually say.

And yet, if you stand back far enough, the family resemblance is just as plain as the difference. Every one of these dharmas, each in the form we have met it here, carries some version of the oldest rule we know, the call to treat others as you would be treated, whether it is extended to the village, the cosmopolis, the more-than-human world or the covenant community. Every one of them binds an 'us', turning a crowd of strangers into a people who can trust one another, and every one draws that circle with a hard edge as well as a warm inside. Every one of them forms character through practice and habit rather than through assent alone. And every one of them treats the moral order as continuous with the

order of reality itself, so that to live rightly is to come into tune with the way things truly are.

Each of the five also has to do something with a corpse and a mourner, and none of them treats the first as refuse or the second as a private matter. In the Ubuntu world, on John Mbiti's account, the recently dead are the 'living-dead', still persons, still in the web, remembered by name until the last person who knew them is gone. Epictetus tells his student to say of the cup, and then of the child, that it was always the kind of thing that breaks; Marcus reminds himself, entry after entry, that the next breath is on loan. In Aboriginal Australia the dead go home: the spirit is sung back to its country, to the waterhole or the rock it came from, to wait there for another birth, and the name is not spoken until the finishing rites are done and the ban is lifted. Sumarah, unusually, has no funeral of its own; a member is buried by the official of whatever religion stands on their identity card, and the tradition's one service to the dead is the survivor's own surrender, offered in place of a prayer. The covenant buries quickly and then sits seven days with the mourner, or washes, shrouds, prays over and buries the body, ideally before the day is out. Every one of them turns the loss of a member into a rite that rebinds the survivors.

That is the shape we keep arriving at. The variety is real, thick, and not to be flattened, and underneath it runs a thin band of shared human concern that no functioning dharma seems to do without. Difference all the way down, and kinship all the way down, at the same time. One admission is owed here: these five were chosen because they rhyme, so this gallery illustrates the family resemblance; it cannot prove it. Later, when we have to ask the dangerous question of whether some dharmas are simply better than others, that thin shared band is going to be the only honest place to stand.

Made of the same need

Taken whole, the world of dharmas shows human beings facing the one problem of how to live well together, and building answers of breathtaking variety. A relational web in southern Africa, a fortress of the will in imperial Rome, a sung and walked law in the Australian desert, an open hand in Java, a covenant in the Near East: five solutions to one need, each fully itself, each unmistakably a member of the same family. A family can share a need and still quarrel about everything else, and this one does.

But I have been describing these dharmas from the outside, as an observer strolling through a gallery, comparing the exhibits. That is not how anyone actually lives inside one. From the inside, your dharma does not feel like one option among five. It does not feel chosen, or built, or cultural at all. It feels like simply *the truth*, like the plain shape of reality, as obvious and unremarkable as the ground being solid and the sky being up. The elder does not experience 'a relational ontology of personhood'. She experiences the plain fact that a person needs other people. That is the real power of a working dharma, and it is also its deepest mystery. How does a made thing get so far inside a human being that it stops feeling made? How does a path you were born onto come to feel like the only ground there is?

To answer that, we have to stop looking at what dharmas *say* and start looking at what they *do* to the people who hold them, how they get under the skin, into the habits, and down into the nervous system itself. We have to ask not what a dharma teaches, but how it installs.

« 3: The dharmas of the Samin of Java | 5: How a dharma gets under your skin »

Sources & further reading

This part is built from the project's research notes, which carry the full inline citations. Listed here are the notes it draws on and the key works behind them. The five sketches that open this part are emblematic composites, drawn from each tradition's own self-descriptions rather than from reportage; the sourced detail sits in each tradition's section and in the notes.

Research notes

Research notes used in this book are published on GitHub – https://github.com/Biksu-Okusi/In-Search-of-Dharma.

- 4.2 Ubuntu – relational/achieved personhood, Metz's moral theory, the TRC and *S v Makwanyane*, and the romanticisation/xenophobia critique.
- 4.3 Indigenous Oral Dharmas – the Dreaming/*Tjukurrpa*, songlines, oral fidelity, kincentricity, the future-generations principle, place-boundedness, and the 'Ecological Indian' caution.
- 3.5.1 Sumarah: Origins & History – Sukinohartono's 1935 revelation, growth through occupation and revolution, the 1950 Paguyuban, the membership arc, and the post-1965 compulsion: atheism treated as communism's twin, God-priority the price of remaining open.
- 3.5.2 Sumarah: Practice & Transmission – *sujud*, the *pamong* and *guru sejati*, *tapa rame*, contact-only transmission, high-Javanese guidance, the 'you are not members' ruling, and the Subud contrast.
- 3.5.3 Sumarah: Rasa Epistemology – *rasa* as organ of knowing; Surono's 'we differ from religions'; the unanimity/repression pathology; the Stange insider-scholar caution.
- 3.5.4 Sumarah & the Secular-Dharma Question – the God-floor ('void and not God'), its duress-contamination after 1965 (devotion inseparable from armour), and the translation question deferred to Part 7.

- 4.5 Subud and Sumarah – the shared 1930s Yogyakarta mystical circle and Subud's worldwide spread.
- 4.4 Abrahamic Ethics as Dharmic Frameworks – the way/path test (halakha, sharia, 'the Way'), orthopraxy, covenant, the *maqasid*, caritas, and Aquinas's natural law; the non-privileging demands.
- 1.4 Cross-cultural Cognates – the impersonal cosmic orders (*ṛta*, *Tao*, the Stoic *logos*) against which covenant grounding is set.

Key works

- On Buddhism's turn in the witness chair: the *Mahāparinibbāna Sutta* (Dīgha Nikāya 16) for the Buddha's deathbed permission to abolish the lesser and minor rules, with the First Council's refusal to use it in the Vinaya (Cullavagga XI), and Cullavagga X for the eight *garudhamma* and the founding of the nuns' order.
- Thea Mohr & Jampa Tsedroen (eds.), *Dignity and Discipline: Reviving Full Ordination for Buddhist Nuns* (2010) – the extinction and contested modern restoration of the bhikkhuni lineage; with Bhikkhu Anālayo's *The Foundation History of the Nuns' Order* (2016), which questions the antiquity of the *garudhamma* account itself.
- Ifeanyi Menkiti, 'Person and Community in African Traditional Thought' (1984), with Kwame Gyekye's moderate-communitarian reply, and Thaddeus Metz, 'Toward an African Moral Theory' (2007) – achieved personhood, the place of individual choice, and the formalised Ubuntu principle.
- Christian BN Gade, 'The historical development of the written discourses on ubuntu' (2011) – when ubuntu and the proverb *umuntu ngumuntu ngabantu* were first written together, which he dates as a hypothesis to 1993–95, alongside the interim constitution and the TRC.
- *S v Makwanyane* (1995) – Ubuntu as a foundational constitutional value; with Bernard Matolino & Wenceslaus Kwindingwi, 'The End of Ubuntu' (2013), and Peter Echewija Sule, 'Xenophobia and the End of

Ontological Ubuntu' (*Acta Academica*, 2022), for the critique and the reply that keeps an axiological Ubuntu.

- Epictetus, *Enchiridion*, and Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* – the dichotomy of control, virtue as the only good, and living 'according to nature'.
- AA Long, *Epictetus: A Stoic and Socratic Guide to Life* (2002), and Pierre Hadot, *Philosophy as a Way of Life* (1995) – Stoicism as lived practice, and the argument that its providential theology is integral rather than detachable decoration.
- WEH Stanner, 'The Dreaming' (1953); Patrick Nunn & Nicholas Reid on 7,000–13,000-year-old coastal memories (2016); the Haudenosaunee Great Law of Peace (Arthur C Parker's 1916 text, where 'future generations' is the wording; 'seven generations' is a later gloss); Vine Deloria Jr, *God Is Red* (1973), on 'religions of space' vs 'religions of time'.
- On what each tradition does with its dead: John S Mbiti, *African Religions and Philosophy* (1969), on the 'living-dead'; Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 3; the Aboriginal material in note 4.3 (Stanner, Spencer, Dussart, Yunupingu); Sumarah's no-rite position in note 3.5.2 (Stange); and, for the covenant, the ordinary practice of *shiva* and *janazah*, stated here from general knowledge rather than from a research note.
- Robin Wall Kimmerer, *Braiding Sweetgrass* (2013), on kincentricity; with Shepard Krech III, *The Ecological Indian* (1999), as the corrective.
- Paul Stange, *The Evolution of Sumarah* (PhD dissertation, University of Wisconsin–Madison, 1980) and *Relaxed Meditation: Selected Sumarah Teachings* (1977/2001) – the insider-scholar's history and practice texts; with AMR Maulana, M Muttaqin & AN Fitriyani, 'Paguyuban Sumarah and Interrituality', *Walisongo* 29(1) (2021), for independent confirmation of the multireligious *sujud*.
- Paul Stange, *Politik Perhatian: Rasa dalam Kebudayaan Jawa* (LKiS, 1998; his English manuscript, *The Politics of Attention*, unpublished), on the New Order's compulsory theism – atheism treated as communism's twin, movements pressured to put 'surrender to God' first as the condition of staying open; with Robert Cribb (ed.), *The Indonesian*

Killings of 1965–1966 (Monash, 1990), on the massacres behind that compulsion.

- On the Abrahamic path-idiom and grounding: the etymologies of *halakha* and *sharia*; al-Ghazali's *maqasid al-shariah*; Paul on love fulfilling the law (Romans 13:10); and Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, on natural law and *synderesis*.

5: How a dharma gets under your skin

Audio: Part 5: in search of dharma



How a dharma gets under your skin

Why does a dharma feel, from the inside, not like a belief you hold but like reality itself? Because it was never installed as a belief. It was grooved into your gut, your habits, and the wiring of your brain, below the reach of the part of you that could doubt it.

A man who has not believed in God for thirty years stands at his mother's funeral, and as the old words begin, the ones he was raised on and long ago decided were false, he finds, to his irritation and surprise, that his throat closes and his eyes sting. Or: a woman who can give a crisp, confident argument for why no food is unclean, why it is all just protein and habit and ancient plumbing rules, cannot, when it comes to it, bring the forbidden thing to her lips. Her hand will not do it. Or, simpler still: you feel the back of your neck prickle when a flag goes up and a crowd goes quiet, and some part of you stands a little straighter, whatever your politics, whatever you think you think.

In each case something is running a program the conscious mind has formally cancelled. The argument has been won, on paper, by the sceptic. And the body was not listening. There is a self underneath the self that was speaking, with its own convictions, and it does not answer to reason.

That underneath-self is where a dharma actually lives. In the first four parts we have looked at dharmas from the outside, as made things, plural things, things with histories and functions. But Part 4 ended on a puzzle: how a thing that human beings built gets so deep inside other human beings that it stops feeling built at all. To answer, we have to stop asking what a dharma teaches and start asking what it does to you – down through three layers: the gut, the body, and the brain itself.

The elephant and the rider

There is a flattering story we tell about ourselves, and it is mostly wrong. The story is that we are reasoning creatures who examine the evidence, weigh the arguments, and arrive at our moral convictions as conclusions. On this picture, we believe cruelty is wrong because we have thought it through.

The psychologist Jonathan Haidt has spent a career showing that this is almost backwards, and he has a useful image for the truth. The mind, he says, is like a small rider on the back of a very large elephant. The

elephant is everything fast and automatic in us, our instincts and gut reactions; the rider is conscious reasoning. We imagine the rider is steering. In fact, most of the time, the elephant leans where it was always going to lean, and the rider's real job is to come up with a respectable reason after the fact. In Haidt's blunter phrase, moral judgement is 'the emotional dog and its rational tail'. The feeling comes first, fast and certain, and the justification trots along behind to explain a verdict that was already reached.

If that is right, then the interesting question about any dharma is what it does to the elephant. Haidt has a second idea that matters as much. The elephant, he proposes, comes equipped with several moral senses, a small set of evolved 'foundations' he likes to call the taste buds of the moral mind. There is a taste bud for care, which flares at cruelty and suffering. One for fairness, which flares at cheating. One for liberty, which flares at being dominated. And then a cluster he calls the binding foundations: loyalty, which prizes the group and hates the traitor; authority, which respects rank and order; and sanctity, which recoils from the degraded and the impure and guards the holy.

Working across cultures, the anthropologist Richard Shweder found the same spread under three broad headings: an ethics of *autonomy* (the language of harm, rights, and fairness to individuals), an ethics of *community* (the language of duty, loyalty, hierarchy, and one's place in a whole), and an ethics of *divinity* (the language of purity, sanctity, and the sacred order). Most of the modern West speaks fluent autonomy and finds the other two faintly embarrassing or sinister. Most human cultures, across most of history, have spoken all three as a matter of course. When someone formed by an ethics of divinity and someone formed by an ethics of autonomy argue about what may be done with a body, or a flag, or a holy book, they are not drawing different conclusions from shared premises. They are speaking different moral languages, each fluent, each half-deaf to the other.

Every human being has all of these, more or less, but no two cultures cook with them the same way. So a dharma is, in large part, a particular recipe written over those shared taste buds: the first layer of how it gets inside you. It cranks some up and mutes others. One tradition builds its whole moral world on sanctity and loyalty and authority, so that purity and faithfulness and proper order feel like the very substance of goodness. Another builds almost everything on care and fairness, so that those same concerns for purity and hierarchy come to feel faintly disgusting. The people raised in those two dharmas are, mostly, tasting the same situation with differently tuned tongues, and then their riders are manufacturing the arguments. This is why moral disagreement across dharmas is so strangely hopeless, so prone to each side concluding the other is worse than wrong: depraved. One cannot argue someone into a taste they do not have.

Though I should be straight about how firm that map is. The taste-bud image is vivid and useful, but the specific list has never been stable, and Haidt has always said so, asking openly how many foundations there really are. Since then the picture has grown shakier rather than firmer. When Kirill Zakharin and Timothy Bates tested whether the six behave like six distinct things in how people actually answer, the model did not fit; the versions that did fit came out with a different set, and more often than not with seven. Sanctity is the weakest of the lot, used so many different ways across studies that Kurt Gray and his colleagues concluded it is not a single thing at all, but a bundle of themes held together only by not being obvious harm. Haidt's own team has since revised the theory and split fairness in two.

There is also a rival account. Back in Part 1 we met Oliver Scott Curry's argument that morality is a set of solutions to the recurring problems of cooperation. When Curry's team put the two frameworks head to head, testing each against people's real moral judgements, the cooperation model fitted and Haidt's did not. I am not going to try to resolve that fight, but I notice what the disagreement is actually about: the *inventory*,

not the thing the inventory is for. Both camps hold that there is a small set of moral concerns humans everywhere run on, that we do not learn them from scratch, and that different cultures crank them to wildly different settings. So take the taste buds as a working vocabulary rather than a parts list.

The sharpest name for that deadlock between dharmas is the philosopher Joshua Greene's. There are, he says, two quite different moral tragedies. The first is the old one a dharma exists to solve: me against us, the selfish individual tempted to cheat the group, which every working ethic labours to overcome. The second is the one that undoes us now, and a dharma cannot solve it, because a dharma *is* it. Greene calls it the tragedy of commonsense morality: not me against us, but us against them, two groups each equipped with a moral system that is internally coherent, deeply felt, and flatly incompatible with the other's. Each side experiences its own parochial intuition as plain, self-evident right, and the other's as obvious wickedness. In truth, to put it with some cruelty, what each is calling 'right' is often just after-the-fact rationalisation slathered over a self-serving, group-bound gut feeling. Two dharmas meeting at a border do not feel to those involved like two recipes. They feel like good meeting evil, from both sides at once.

Whose gut?

Most people reading this, like me, have a moral palate that runs heavily on care, fairness, and liberty, and rather lightly on sanctity, loyalty, and deference to authority. That particular setting feels, from the inside, not like one recipe among many but like the absence of recipe, like plain, neutral, grown-up human decency, the place one ends up on giving up superstition and tribe and simply thinking clearly. That feeling is itself the thing to be suspicious of.

Joseph Henrich and his colleagues gave the relevant population a deliberately rude acronym: WEIRD, for Western, Educated, Industrialised, Rich, and Democratic. These are the people on whom the science of

human psychology was overwhelmingly built, because they are the people who happened to be standing near the universities. And the discovery, made over years and across domain after domain, is that WEIRD people are not a representative sample of humanity at all. On how they treat strangers, on whether they see the world in wholes or in parts, on whether they define themselves as individuals or as threads in a family, even on which way they fall for certain optical illusions, the modern Western mind turns out to be a global outlier, one of the *least* typical varieties of human being on the planet. The morality that feels like the human default is a local product, and a statistically peculiar one.

The same parochialism hides inside even our theories of moral *growth*. The most famous account of how children develop morally, Lawrence Kohlberg's, arranges moral reasoning into a ladder of stages, climbing from a childish 'avoid punishment', through 'follow the rules of my group', up to a supposed summit of abstract universal principle: the lone conscience that can defy an unjust law in the name of pure justice. It is an appealing picture, until one notices that the summit looks suspiciously like a Western philosophy professor, and that the people who reliably score highest on it are the educated Western individualists who designed the test.

The psychologist Carol Gilligan landed the hardest blow. Kohlberg had built his ladder almost entirely by studying boys, and when girls reasoned about moral problems in the language of care, relationship, and responsibility rather than abstract rules, the scoring marked them *down*, as though a morality centred on not abandoning people were a less grown-up thing than a morality centred on principle. It was not less grown-up. It was a different dharma's priorities, mistaken for a lower rung on a universal ladder. Even our measuring stick for moral maturity had a particular dharma quietly carved into it.

The neuroscientist Robert Sapolsky gives the screw one more turn. The moral convictions we would stake our lives on, the ones that feel too plainly, eternally true to be cultural at all: that slavery is an abomination,

that the deliberate torture of a child is unforgivable. These feel like bedrock, like things any decent human in any age would have felt in their bones. *They are not.* They are recent. For most of human history most people felt no such automatic horror, and the reason we feel it now, instantly, in the gut, without having to reason it out, is that generations before us did the hard, contested, deliberate moral reasoning and the dangerous activism that slowly retrained the human gut. Your intuitions, in Sapolsky's phrase, are 'the end products of learning'. Your guts learned their intuitions. The very thing that feels most like untaught nature is the most thoroughly taught thing of all.

So the first layer of installation is this: more than handing you beliefs to consider, a dharma tunes the instrument on which you will feel, before you ever reason, what is decent and what is disgusting, and it tunes it so early and so deep that the tuning feels like the sound of reality itself.

We become what we repeatedly do

If morality is mostly the elephant, and the elephant is trained, the obvious next question is: trained how? And the answer is the second layer. Not, in the main, by teaching, but by drilling.

The point is as old as Aristotle, who saw it clearly more than two thousand years ago. We do not become good by learning the definition of goodness, he argued, any more than we become builders by reading about building. We become just by doing just acts, brave by doing brave acts, temperate by doing temperate ones. Virtue, for Aristotle, is not a belief one holds in the head but a *disposition*, a settled habit of the whole person, grooved into you by repetition until it runs without effort, the way a trained musician plays without thinking about the notes. (The famous line often quoted here, 'we are what we repeatedly do; excellence, then, is not an act but a habit', is in fact a paraphrase by the historian Will Durant, not Aristotle's own words.)

This is why real dharmas are so heavy with *practice*, far heavier than mere belief could ever require. The five daily prayers, the fast that empties the stomach for a month, the bow, the prostration, the chant repeated until the words dissolve, the dietary discipline observed at every single meal: the sheer relentless repetition is a central mechanism. Doing the thing ten thousand times grooves the disposition, and the grooved disposition, not the stated belief, is what runs a life when the mind is elsewhere.

And ritual does something even bare repetition cannot. It bonds. More than a century ago, the sociologist Émile Durkheim noticed that when people move and chant and feel together in a rite, something is generated that he called 'collective effervescence', a kind of emotional electricity that fuses a crowd into a community and leaves the participants feeling they have touched something larger and sacred. That sounds mystical, but it has been measured in the body, in one striking field study, when anthropologist Dimitris Xygalatas wired up a Spanish village firewalk: both the men who walked across the coals, and the spectators who only watched. The walkers' hearts raced, as one would expect. The startling finding was that the spectators' hearts raced *in synchrony* with them, beat-for-beat, and the synchrony was tightest between people who loved each other, so tight that one could read the social distance between two people from the similarity of their heartbeats. The rite was, quite literally, tuning their bodies to a common rhythm.

Even the bare *form* of ritual does work on the mind. Veronika Rybanska and her colleagues ran a three-month programme of circle-time games with two hundred and ten schoolchildren, in places as different as Slovakia and the islands of Vanuatu. The training improved the children's self-control, and through it their ability to delay gratification; and the improvement was larger when the very same games were framed in what the researchers call a 'ritual stance' rather than a practical one. The stance is nothing more than performing a precise sequence of actions carefully, just because that is how it is done, with no practical purpose at all. The bare form did not do the work by itself, then; it sharpened what the

drilling achieved: the discipline of doing it exactly is itself a training of the will. The body, in all of this, leads and the mind follows. You do not kneel because you already feel reverence; very often you kneel first, night after night, and the reverence is what grows in the worn groove of the kneeling.

Not all dharmas drill the same way. Anthropologist Harvey Whitehouse has mapped two very different routes to the same destination. One he calls the doctrinal mode: frequent, calm, low-key repetition, the daily prayer and the weekly service and the lesson learned by rote, which lays the dharma down in ordinary memory and can hold a vast, scattered community in loose agreement for centuries. The other he calls the imagistic mode: rare, shattering ordeal, the terrifying initiation or the once-in-a-lifetime rite, which burns itself into memory as a single unforgettable event and welds a small group into something close to a single self, fused for life. The quiet daily groove and the rare branding ordeal are two technologies for one task, installing a disposition so deep it feels like identity, and most dharmas run on some blend of the two.

In the last part of his great book Durkheim turns from the festival to what he calls the piacular rites, the rites of mourning, and his evidence is the Warramunga of central Australia, where the women gashed their scalps and the men their thighs, and where the people who must wound themselves were fixed by kinship in advance. Mourning, he concluded, 'is not a natural movement of private feelings wounded by a cruel loss; it is a duty imposed by the group. One weeps, not simply because he is sad, but because he is forced to weep'. The group, subtracted by one, gathers and grieves on schedule so as to feel itself whole again, and the feeling manufactured in the rite is then read by each mourner as the depth of their own loss. This is the installation machinery at its most intense, an imagistic event in Whitehouse's terms. The man at his mother's funeral, at the start of this part, is a Warramunga mourner with the etiquette out of sight: the old words were a cue for a bodily routine drilled into him at every funeral of his childhood, and the body, which had never been consulted about his change of mind, did what it had been trained to do.

If a dharma installs itself through ritual, repetition, ordeal and the disciplined body, what happens to a dharma that rejects supernatural ritual? That is the secular project's hardest practical problem, and people have begun, self-consciously, to experiment with it. There are now godless congregations, gatherings with names like the Sunday Assembly, half-jokingly described as Pentecostalism for atheists. They borrow the song, the assembly, and the shared rhythm, and drop the doctrine to rebuild the installation machinery without the gods. Whether such things can really cultivate durable dispositions, or whether the apparatus only bites when anchored to something held sacred, is genuinely unknown.

All the way into the brain

The installation goes deeper than habit, down into the tissue, and here we reach the third layer, the one everyone is most excited about, and the one most oversold.

The exciting findings are real, though smaller than they sound. When Antoine Lutz and Richard Davidson studied Tibetan monks with tens of thousands of hours of meditation behind them, they recorded patterns of high-frequency, perfectly synchronised brain activity 'greater than any previously reported' in healthy people. Take that result with care: there were eight monks, nobody has repeated the study, and the frequency band it depends on is the one most easily contaminated by the electrical activity of the scalp muscles you use to frown or clench your jaw. And the lab work turned up something useful for thinking about ethics: compassion, it seems, is not the same thing in the brain as empathy.

When the seasoned monk Matthieu Ricard was asked simply to *feel* the suffering of others, his brain lit up the ordinary circuitry of shared pain, and he found it quickly unbearable, the way a nurse or a parent can be hollowed out by absorbing too much hurt. But when he switched to trained compassion, a warm, steady wish for others to be well, the distress circuitry went quiet and the brain's warm reward system came on instead. This is a striking vindication of something the contemplative traditions

long insisted on and that the psychologist Paul Bloom has argued hard in our own day: raw empathy, the soaking up of others' pain, is actually a poor moral guide. It is exhausting, and it is parochial and innumerate, lavishing itself on the single near sufferer one can see while going numb to the distant millions one cannot. The dharmic move, to cultivate a calm and even-handed goodwill rather than to drown in fellow-feeling, is the one the brain rewards.

One might expect that the people most overwhelmed by the sight of suffering would be the ones who help most. The opposite is closer to the truth. Sapolsky points to evidence that people exposed to another's distress tend to step in and help when their own heart rate goes *down*, when they steady themselves, rather than when it spikes in shared panic. Raw, contagious distress tends to make us flinch away or freeze, curled around our own discomfort; it is the settled, regulated compassion that frees a person to act. The traditions that teach us to breathe, to steady ourselves, and only then to help were being effective, not cold, and the physiology backs them up.

The popular headline, that meditation simply 'rewires your brain', outruns the evidence, and the real story is more interesting than the hype. The most eye-catching claims were about *structure*, that practice visibly thickens the cortex or grows grey matter. Early studies suggested as much. But when Richard Davidson's own laboratory, one of the founding temples of the whole field, ran the rigorous trials that the early work lacked, randomising participants and controlling properly, the structural changes did not appear. A founding lab failed to replicate the founding claim, which is the kind of self-correction that separates science from sales. The careful verdict is that sustained practice reliably changes how the brain *functions*, especially in attention and stress regulation, while the dramatic claims that it reshapes the brain's anatomy are, for now, unproven. And we should remember that almost any serious training changes the brain; the brains of jugglers and taxi drivers change too. That the brain adapts to what we repeatedly do is Aristotle's point again, not a miracle.

There is a silence in this literature, and it is the one that matters most for anyone who takes up a practice on a book's recommendation. Meditation can hurt people. When Marco Schlosser and his colleagues surveyed more than twelve hundred regular meditators, a quarter of them reported particularly unpleasant experiences they attributed to the practice itself: anxiety, dread, the floor of the self giving way, dissociation from the world or from their own bodies. Willoughby Britton, who studies these effects, argues they are neither rare nor a sign of doing it wrong; they are what a powerful technique does to some people some of the time, and the traditions that developed these methods knew it, which is why they surrounded them with teachers and staged them over years. Stephanie Coronado-Montoya and her colleagues found that of a hundred and twenty-four published trials of mindfulness, a hundred and eight reported positive results, a ratio no honest field produces.

So the picture is not that meditation is fraudulent. It is that a real and useful technology has been marketed with the risks filed off, and a book arguing that dharmas install themselves below the level of argument ought to say plainly that the installation can go wrong.

A darker finding used to close a circle we keep drawing, and I have had to give it up. The chemistry of human bonding is sold to us as a 'love hormone', oxytocin, the warm molecule of trust and connection. The sophisticated correction, the one I reached for in earlier drafts of this part, was that oxytocin is really a parochial drug: Carsten De Dreu's experiments appeared to show it driving what researchers call 'tend-and-defend', the same surge that deepens devotion to your own people sharpening suspicion of the stranger. The fence, written into the bloodstream. It makes a wonderful sentence. The evidence, as it stands at the moment, no longer carries it.

The first problem is plumbing. Nearly all of this work squirts oxytocin up volunteers' noses, and the physiologists Gareth Leng and Mike Ludwig have argued that almost none of it reaches the brain; what it reliably does is flood the blood with far more of the hormone than a body would ever

produce on its own. The second problem is size. These are small studies, underpowered in the statistician's sense, which is a dependable recipe for results that shine once and dim on re-examination. And then there is what De Dreu himself published in 2024. Across fifty-one nations, in Kenyan communities and in a representative British sample, people competed *harder* with members of their own group than with outsiders, whenever resources inside the group felt scarce. Biologists studying birds and primates call this the nasty-neighbour effect. It is very nearly the opposite of the tidy story.

So the fence is real, but the bloodstream did not put it there. We met it in the village and again in the covenant, and it is built by the ordinary machinery this part has been describing all along: habit, belonging, repetition, the slow grooving of us and them. That is a less thrilling answer than a molecule, and a sturdier one. The nasty neighbour carries a warning we will need later: the fence can run *inside* a group as readily as around it.

And because the brain images are so seductive, it needs to be said plainly: none of this makes any dharma *true*. A coloured scan showing the neural signature of compassion no more proves that compassion is right than a scan of revulsion proves that a taboo is justified. The brain can show us that a conviction is installed, deeply, physically, beautifully installed. It can never show us that the conviction is correct. The wiring is a fact about the believer, not about the world.

Why it feels like truth

The three layers, together, answer the question we started with.

Your dharma lives in your moral taste buds, in the instantaneous flare of approval or disgust that arrives long before any argument and that your reasoning mind merely dresses up afterwards. It lives in your trained habits, in dispositions grooved so deep by repetition that they run on their own, without consulting you, when you are tired or frightened or not

paying attention. And it lives in the very tuning of your brain, in circuits worn smooth by years of practice. One thing is missing from that list: your conscious, deliberating, belief-weighing mind, the part of you that could examine a claim and find it wanting, does very little of the installing.

That is not to say it does nothing. Reason can choose what to submit itself to, can argue an inherited tradition into a new shape, and can give or withhold its consent to a practice whose work will be done later and lower down. The *wong sikep* of Part 3 did exactly that, deliberately and out loud, and the convert and the reformer do it still. What reason rarely manages is the installing itself. It can walk a person to the training ground; it cannot do the training.

That absence from the deep work is the whole secret, and it is why a dharma feels the way it does. It does not feel like a belief one holds because it was never installed as a belief in the first place. It was installed *underneath* belief, in the layers that were running long before the reasoning mind woke up and that go on running whether the reasoning mind agrees or not. Most of what you carry you did not reason your way into, which is precisely why it cannot be reasoned back out, and why the man at the funeral weeps over words he is certain are false. From the inside, a working dharma cannot feel like an opinion about reality. It feels like reality, because it is operating below the level of the self that would be capable of doubting it.

The missing elephant

The argument so far has assumed one thing without actually saying it: that the elephant is there to be trained. That underneath the rider sits a great warm animal of instinct, the gut that flares at cruelty, the fear that grips, the empathy that soaks up another's pain, waiting to be grooved and tuned. But in a small fraction of people (how small depends on the instrument doing the counting) that animal runs faint from very early on. This is the stretch of the human range we reach for the word *psychopath* to name, and the word is a good deal tidier than the thing: it is no formal

diagnosis, and the research treats it as a dimension, a direction people lie further or less far along, never a separate kind of human being. What is thin at that end of the range is not a wicked belief that got installed. It is the very substrate every dharma installs *into*.

When the instrument is thin, the machinery has almost nothing to work with. The moral taste buds barely flare, so the flash of care or disgust that is supposed to arrive before reasoning does not reliably come. The grooving of habit has far less to grip, because guilt and fear, the mortar that sets a conscience, are running low. The compassion the monk spent ten thousand hours warming is, in this brain, cool to begin with; this is the person on whom the ordinary apparatus of shame and fellow-feeling can find almost no purchase. The installation engine, so nearly irresistible in the rest of us, meets a surface it cannot easily bite. The limit case proves the rule from the far side: morality is grooved into an affective instrument, and where the instrument is faint, the grooving barely takes.

The core of that difference is a single dialled-down setting: fear. The finding about helping returns here: the people who run toward the fire are the ones whose hearts steady; the useful thing is a fearless calm. The person whose fear runs low to begin with has that calm for nothing. So the very same low-fear temperament is the raw material of the fearless rescuer, the steady surgeon, the leader who does not flinch in the crisis, and of the cold exploiter who feels nothing as he uses others. Which one a life becomes is not fixed by the temperament; it is settled by what, if anything, gets built around it. Even this is contested: the fearlessness that does the good may be the *least* psychopathic part of the pattern, separable from the callousness that does the harm, so that 'the useful psychopath' may be less a paradox than two different things wearing one name.

Still, the deeper point survives the caveat. A dialled-down fear response is, in itself, neither good nor evil; it waits for a dharma (or the absence of one) to make something of it. The instrument is as morally blank as the machinery that would train it. Which is only a small biological rehearsal for the larger, harder thing we have been circling all along.

The machine has no conscience

Not one item on the list of what makes a dharma powerful has any moral content of its own. The grooving of habit will install cruelty exactly as faithfully as it installs kindness; the same patient repetition that shapes a saint shapes the guard who has learned to process the condemned without flinching. The collective effervescence that fuses a congregation in love will fuse a mob in hatred with the identical electricity. The belonging that makes us cherish our own is the same belonging that teaches us whom to hold at arm's length. The installation machinery is, from top to bottom, morally blank. It will drive whatever is fed into it down into the gut, the muscle, and the brain with the same quiet efficiency, and label the result, in every case, 'obvious truth'.

And because it works below awareness, you cannot feel, from the inside, the difference between a dharma that is guiding you and one that has captured you. Both feel exactly the same. Both feel like simply seeing the world as it is. The depth that lets a great dharma make a person good is the identical depth that lets a corrupt one make a person monstrous while leaving them serenely certain of their own decency.

We have spent four parts, in admiration, watching how dharmas hold us together, and this one watching how they get inside us. If this machinery runs beneath reason, installs whatever it is given, and feels like truth no matter what it has installed, then the most pressing question is not how a dharma works, but how it goes wrong.

« 4: A world of dharmas | 6: When dharmas go wrong »

Sources & further reading

This part is built from the project's research notes, which carry the full inline citations. Listed here: the notes it draws on, and the key works behind them.

Research notes

Research notes used in this book are published on GitHub – https://github.com/Biksu-Okusi/In-Search-of-Dharma.

- 5.3 Moral Psychology & Development – Haidt's intuition-first model and moral foundations, the WEIRD critique, and 'the guts learn their intuitions'. The spine of the first two layers.
- 5.4 Ritual, Practice & Habituation – Aristotelian habituation, ritual synchrony and collective effervescence, the 'ritual stance', and the morally neutral installation machinery.
- 5.1 Neurological Basis – gamma synchrony, compassion versus empathy, the structural-change non-replication, and the retreat from oxytocin's 'tend-and-defend'.
- 5.2 Evolutionary Psychology – the costly-signalling and parochial-altruism background to ritual and the in-group fence.
- 5.5 Psychopaths & the Exploiter Limit Case – the ~1% in whom the affective substrate is constitutionally muted; the low-fear temperament as morally blank raw material (fearless rescuer or cold exploiter), and why its 'useful' edge is contested.

Key works

- Jonathan Haidt, *The Righteous Mind* (2012), and 'The Emotional Dog and Its Rational Tail' (2001) – the elephant and rider, and Moral Foundations Theory.
- On how unsettled the foundations are: Kirill Zakharin & Timothy Bates (2021) on the Moral Foundations Questionnaire's structure across five studies and 11,496 people; Kurt Gray, Nicholas DiMaggio, Chelsea Schein & Frank Kachanoff (2022), 'The Problem of Purity in

Moral Psychology'; Mohammad Atari, Jonathan Haidt, Jesse Graham and colleagues (2023) on the revised six-foundation MFQ-2; and Oliver Scott Curry, Matthew Jones Chesters & Caspar Van Lissa (2019), 'Mapping morality with a compass', the head-to-head test in which morality-as-cooperation outperforms Moral Foundations Theory.

- Joseph Henrich, Steven Heine & Ara Norenzayan, 'The Weirdest People in the World?' (2010) – WEIRD samples as global outliers; with Robert Sapolsky, *Behave* (2017), on intuitions as learned.
- Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics* II.1, on virtue as habituation (and Will Durant's *The Story of Philosophy* for the commonly misattributed 'we are what we repeatedly do').
- Émile Durkheim, *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (1912), on collective effervescence, and Book III on the piacular rites of mourning among the Warramunga; with Dimitris Xygalatas on firewalk heart-rate synchrony, and Harvey Whitehouse on the doctrinal and imagistic modes of religiosity, with the Kavanagh group's caution that felt intensity, not the pain itself, may be what does the fusing. Durkheim himself extended the mechanism beyond religion, to nationalism and devotion to the flag, and the extension still earns its keep: ReligionForBreakfast's video essay 'Fandoms are Religions' (2025) reads stadium sport and Taylor Swift's 2023 Eras Tour as collective effervescence in working order – the same machinery, run without gods. On the 'ritual stance': Veronika Rybanska, Ryan McKay, Jonathan Jong & Harvey Whitehouse (2018), 'Rituals Improve Children's Ability to Delay Gratification', *Child Development* 89(2):349–359 – a three-month intervention with 210 children in Slovakia and Vanuatu, whose effects were *amplified* when the task carried ritual rather than instrumental cues.
- Antoine Lutz, Matthieu Ricard & Richard Davidson on meditation, gamma synchrony, and the compassion/empathy distinction (the 2004 gamma study has eight subjects); Paul Bloom, *Against Empathy* (2016); and Kral, Davidson et al. (2022) on the absence of structural brain change.

- On the harms: Marco Schlosser and colleagues (2019), who found a quarter of 1,232 regular meditators reporting particularly unpleasant meditation-related experiences; Willoughby Britton, 'Can mindfulness be too much of a good thing?' (2019) and her work on defining meditation-related adverse effects; and Stephanie Coronado-Montoya and colleagues (2016), who found 108 of 124 published mindfulness trials reporting positive results.
- On oxytocin, the correction rather than the claim: Hasse Walum, Irwin Waldman & Larry Young (2016) on how underpowered the intranasal literature is, and Gareth Leng & Mike Ludwig (2016), 'Intranasal Oxytocin: Myths and Delusions', on how little of it reaches the brain; with Angelo Romano, Jörg Gross & Carsten De Dreu, 'The nasty neighbor effect in humans' (*Science Advances*, 2024), in which people compete more with their own group than with outsiders under perceived scarcity. Carsten De Dreu et al. (2010, 2011) on oxytocin and parochial 'tend-and-defend' altruism is the earlier work these qualify.
- Joshua Greene, *Moral Tribes* (2013) – the tragedy of commonsense morality, the Us-versus-Them clash a dharma cannot solve.
- Lawrence Kohlberg's stages of moral development, with Carol Gilligan, *In a Different Voice* (1982) – the care-versus-justice critique; and Richard Shweder on the ethics of autonomy, community, and divinity.
- On the missing substrate: Hervey Cleckley, *The Mask of Sanity* (1941), and Robert Hare, *Without Conscience* (1993), on psychopathy as constitutionally muted conscience; with the 'fearless dominance' / boldness research (Lilienfeld; Patrick) and its critics (Lynam & Miller) on whether the useful edge is even part of psychopathy.

6: When dharmas go wrong

Audio: Part 6: in search of dharma



When dharmas go wrong

Every failure of a dharma turns out to be the dark twin of a strength. The bond that holds a group together is the fence that shuts others out; the authority that can free people is the authority that can rule them; the practice that liberates is the cage. Failure is not a flaw in a dharma; it is the strength, overextended – or worn as a mask.

In the Buddhist-majority country of Myanmar, a monk named Ashin Wirathu spent years preaching. He wore the saffron robe. He had taken

the vows. And what he preached, to large and adoring crowds, was hatred of his Muslim neighbours, the Rohingya, in terms so incendiary that he came to be seen, not entirely unfairly, as the Burmese face of a coming slaughter. When that slaughter came, when soldiers and mobs drove more than a million Rohingya from their homes, burning villages and killing as they went, the man in the robe had helped lay the moral groundwork, in the name of protecting the faith.

Buddhism, in the Western imagination, is the gentle dharma, the one with no crusades, the religion of loving-kindness, the breath, and the patient smile. And here is a Buddhist monk, sincere, learned, devout, using that very tradition to bless an ethnic cleansing. The first instinct, the comforting one, is to say: well, he is not a *real* Buddhist. *Real* Buddhism would never. But that instinct is a trap, and refusing it is where we have to begin.

For five parts we have been, mostly, sympathetic witnesses, watching how dharmas hold us together, how they answer the deepest human needs, how they get so far inside us that they feel like truth itself. We cannot stay sympathetic any longer, because a sympathetic account that never looked at the wreckage would be a lie, and would deserve none of the trust it asks for. If dharmas do everything the last five parts said they do, why is so much of history's cruelty signed in their name? So now we look straight at that harm, done sincerely, century after century, by people every bit as certain of their own goodness as we are of ours.

Why 'that's not real Buddhism' is a cop-out

The comforting exit has to be closed first: almost everyone reaches for it, and it leads nowhere.

When a Buddhist monk incites genocide, or a Christian blesses a slave ship, or any tradition is turned to cruelty, the reflex is to declare that the perpetrators have betrayed the true faith, that real Buddhism or real Christianity or real Islam is the peaceful thing and the violence is a

corruption from outside. Philosophers have a name for this move. They call it the No True Scotsman fallacy, after the imaginary patriot who insists that no true Scotsman would do some disgraceful thing, and who, when shown a Scotsman who did exactly that, simply replies that no *true* Scotsman would. The trick is that you protect your ideal by redefining anyone who violates it as not really a member.

Scholars at Harvard's Religious Literacy Project put the correction bluntly: religions are internally diverse, and a tradition deep enough and old enough to contain a saint is deep enough to contain a butcher, with both sincerely drawing on the same scriptures and the same authority. The peace-preaching monk and the hate-preaching monk are *both* authentically Buddhist. To say so is not to say the tradition commends them equally; it is to refuse the referee's chair, which no outside observer holds. To wave the second away as fake is loyalty dressed up as argument, a way of refusing to see.

So I am going to hold to an uncomfortable rule from here on. The failures of a dharma are not betrayals of its pure essence. They are expressions of its real potential, as genuine as its glories, and they grow from the very same roots.

The dark twin

The last five parts turned up a handful of things that make a dharma powerful. A strong, identity-shaping sense of who 'we' are. Costly, hard-to-fake commitment that binds people tightly together. A transcendent authority that outranks any mere person or law. Deep in-group trust. And an installation machinery, the ritual and habit and repetition, that drives all of this below conscious thought until it feels like simple reality. Every one of those is a genuine strength, and why dharmas work.

Part 5 ended on the blankness of the last of these: the installation machinery will groove cruelty into the bone as faithfully as it grooves kindness. The same blankness runs the whole list. A strong 'we' is a

wonderful thing right up until you ask what happens to 'them'. Costly commitment binds the just community and the death cult with equal strength. A transcendent authority can chastise a tyrant or crown him. Deep trust inside the group is the same psychological fact as deep suspicion of those outside it. The features and the failures are not two separate lists. They are one list, seen from two sides. Every failure of a dharma is the dark twin of one of its strengths, which is why no dharma is safe, and why the failures keep coming back no matter how often we are scandalised by them. Six of these twins are worth naming.

The fence becomes a wall

The first and deepest failure is the one we have been circling since the very beginning, the hard edge around the warm circle.

A dharma works by turning a crowd of strangers into an 'us'. That is its genius, the thing that lets it hold a group together across a scale no troop of apes could manage. But an 'us' is defined by its boundary, and a boundary has an outside. The same bonding that makes you cherish your own people is the very mechanism that primes you to fear and distrust the people beyond the line. (Field studies by Antonio Silva and Ruth Mace add one mercy: the two faces can come apart, and the hostility often tracks deprivation more than devotion.)

Researchers call it parochial altruism: we make sacrifices for the in-group and brace ourselves against the out-group. Turned up, fed on fear, and pointed at a hated minority, that ordinary instinct becomes the engine of the pogrom, the crusade, the inquisition, and the cleansing. The fence that holds the community together becomes the wall behind which the community does its killing. Wirathu's monstrousness was not foreign to his dharma. It was his dharma's in-group warmth, with the sign flipped outward at the people who had been defined as not-us. The scholar Mark Juergensmeyer, surveying religious violence across every major tradition, found the same grim pattern everywhere: there is no faith so peaceful that it cannot be turned, by someone sincere, into a reason to kill.

I do not want to leave this at despair, because one hopeful thing is buried in the research. It is not obvious that the lethal version of the boundary is hardwired. The primatologist Richard Wrangham points out that our chimpanzee cousins, who kill each other at rates much like ours, show none of the *self-sacrificing* battlefield heroism that human war runs on, and that the readiness to die for the group against another group looks more like something cultures install than something genes demand. If the killing is installed rather than bred in the bone, then it is not fate: argument cannot undo it, as Part 5 warned, but the same slow machinery that installed it can move it. The line around 'us' is not fixed at the tribe; it has been pushed outward again and again across history, from the band to the city to the nation, and there is no law of nature that says it cannot be pushed further. It is the thin thread of hope that Part 8 will try to pull.

The authority that frees becomes the authority that rules

The second twin lives in the very thing that lets a dharma stand above mere power: its claim to a higher authority.

Morality seems to have started as a levelling device. In the small forager bands of the deep past, the moral sense, as Christopher Boehm argued, worked as a way for the many to gang up on the would-be bully and keep any one person from lording it over the rest. And then, when societies grew and stratified, and some people came to rule over others, that same moral authority was captured and turned inside out, made into a justification for the very domination it had once resisted. This is the double face of dharma and power, and the history of religion cannot be understood without it.

On one face, a dharma sanctifies the ruler. The Hindu doctrine of caste, wedded to the idea of karma, could tell the man born into the lowest station that he had earned it cosmically, by his conduct in a previous life, and that his suffering was therefore just. Kings across the world have ruled by divine right. Marx had a hard phrase for this function: religion as 'the opium of the people', the drug that makes an unjust order feel

bearable and even holy. The Italian theorist Antonio Gramsci saw the subtler version: the deepest power is not the soldier who forces you but the worldview, often religious, that makes the existing arrangement feel natural, inevitable, and right, so that you consent to your own place in it without anyone having to raise a hand. And whoever controls the dharma controls something even more basic, the power to say what counts as orthodox and what as heresy, who is inside and who is to be cast out. In the sociologist Pierre Bourdieu's phrase, it is the power of legitimate naming, and it is one of the most jealously guarded prizes there is.

But there is another face, and it is the reason this is a real fight, not a swindle. The very same higher authority that can crown a king can also condemn him. Once it is granted that there is a justice above the throne, every prophet and reformer has a place to stand. The Hebrew prophets used it to denounce their own corrupt rulers. We watched this face at work in Part 3: the same machinery that let the Samin of Java quietly refuse an extractive authority is the machinery that caste used to sanctify one. The Indian reformer Bhimrao Ambedkar, leading half a million Dalits out of Hinduism and into a reconstructed Buddhism, performed the most surgical version of this move imaginable. To turn the dharma against the caste oppression he had suffered, he deliberately cut out the doctrine of karma, the exact teaching that had been used to justify that oppression. The authority that the powerful seize to sanctify themselves is the same authority the powerless seize to indict them. It is just that the powerful usually own the institutions, so the sanctifying face is the default and the liberating face is the harder, rarer, more dangerous achievement.

And even the liberating face is not as clean as it looks, which is the unsettling lesson the philosopher Michel Foucault pressed hardest. Power, he argued, is not only the boot that holds you down; it is also productive, busy making the very kind of person you become. Run a dharma's apparatus through that lens and the point lands close to home. The confessional, the spiritual director, the meditation hall, the programme of self-improvement: these actively shape selves, train desires, and produce a

particular sort of disciplined soul. So when a dharma frees you from one regime, it tends to install another in its place, a fresh set of rules about how to watch and govern yourself. There is no escape into a dharma-free clearing where the self runs wild and unsupervised, because the self is itself something a dharma builds. The real question is never power against freedom. It is always a matter of which regime of self-making you are living in, and whether you chose it or were simply born into it.

The cage: who holds the key

The third twin is the way a dharma, which promises a path to the good life, can become a prison, and nowhere is this clearer than in the two arenas of gender and money.

Consider gender first, because dharmas encode it early and the record is bleak. Across tradition after tradition, the codified mainstream has placed women under men and called it the order of things. The Hindu lawbook of Manu states flatly that a woman must never be independent, passing from the control of her father to her husband to her sons. An early Buddhist rule, one the canon itself may have acquired late, made every nun, however senior, subordinate to every monk, however junior. The Confucian 'three obediences' bound a woman to obey her father, then her husband, then her son. The household codes of the Abrahamic scriptures lock women into submission. In each case the subordination is handed the highest possible warrant, cosmic or scriptural, so that a human arrangement of power gets to wear the costume of eternal truth.

And yet the very same traditions carry within themselves the materials of revolt. The oldest collection of women's poetry in India is a set of verses by Buddhist nuns celebrating their own awakening. The Hindu women-saints of the devotional tradition, Mirabai and Akka Mahadevi, walked out of their marriages and their assigned roles, using love of God as the one pretext their society could not deny them. The same Christian scripture that tells wives to submit also declares that in Christ there is 'neither male nor female'. In our own time the scholar Amina Wadud rereads the Qur'an

from a woman's standpoint and argues that its true principle is equality, and that the patriarchy is the accretion, not the core. The rule is this: a dharma in itself neither frees women nor cages them. It is the contested ground on which that fight is waged, and the same scripture hands down both the chains and the keys. What decides which one you get is not the text. It is who holds the power to read it.

The word 'cage' carries my own values inside it. The yardstick I have been using, that subordinating women is a failure and freeing them a success, is itself a fairly modern and broadly liberal standard, and I should not pretend it floats above all dharmas as neutral fact. Many women, including many who had every chance to choose otherwise, have described lives inside traditional roles not as a prison but as a place of meaning, dignity, and chosen devotion. A fair reckoning has to hold two things at once. It must register that self-understanding honestly, rather than sneering at it from a comfortable distance, and it must still name the documented, systematic ways these systems have stripped women of autonomy and authority and called the result the will of heaven. Both of those are true, and the strain between them is the kind of thing the question of judgement will have to face.

Money tells the same double story. Dharmas have both blessed and damned economic orders, often in the same breath. The caste system assigned each person their economic place by sacred duty. In the West, as the philosopher Michael Sandel has argued, the old Protestant idea that worldly success was a sign of God's favour, once God fell away, slowly curdled into the modern faith in meritocracy: the conviction that the winner deserves to win and, more cruelly, that the loser deserves to lose. That is a secular dharma doing the oldest dirty job in the book, re-sanctifying inequality after the gods have gone home, telling the poor their poverty is a verdict on their worth.

But dharmas have also been the sharpest critics of economic cruelty. David Graeber spent his career as an anthropologist arguing that the language of debt and the language of sin grew up entangled, and that debt

has been the supreme tool for making the exploited feel that their suffering is their own fault. Against that, he set the older and almost forgotten intuition that the truly sacred act was never repaying a debt but *cancelling* it, the clean slate, the jubilee. The dharma that tells the poor to accept their lot and the dharma that tells them to tear up the ledger are written in the same hand.

The fire goes out

The fourth twin turns the danger inward. Not every failure of a dharma involves a victim. Some of the most insidious are the ones where the dharma rots from the inside while everyone keeps going through the motions, and these failures wear a friendly face, which is what makes them so hard to see. They come in two forms: the fire can go out, leaving the form perfectly preserved and empty, or it can burn too hot in the wrong direction, feeding on the group's own certainty of its goodness.

The first is the hollowing. The sociologist Max Weber described how the white-hot insight of a founder, the living fire of a Buddha or a Christ or a prophet, gets slowly cooled and boxed up over the generations into something manageable: the teaching codified into texts, the experience replaced by a ritual, the personal charisma succeeded by a bureaucracy. The form survives intact, long after the thing it was built to carry has died inside it. A worshipper can kneel in a tradition that has become pure habit, recite words that mean nothing to anyone in the room, and mistake the husk for the kernel. At the scale of a single person this rot has a name too: spiritual bypassing, the use of lofty spiritual ideas to dodge one's actual messy human problems, the serene meditator who is really just fleeing his own anger and calling the flight enlightenment. In each case the practice continues while its purpose silently inverts.

A rite can also fail to happen at all. Clifford Geertz watched one fail in a small East Javanese town in 1954, because the dharma underneath it had split. A boy of about ten died suddenly in the house of his uncle, a member of Permai, a political-religious movement of the day that was

hostile to Islam, and the village religious official, the *modin*, who was also the man who prepared bodies and led the burial, declined to officiate for a family of that party, on instruction from above. Nobody else knew how. The neighbours came, as the *slametan* requires, and sat; the body lay in the house for hours while the men argued over whether it could be washed and who might say the words; and the ordinary machinery of Javanese death, which for as long as anyone remembered had turned a corpse into a grave and a stricken household back into a community by nightfall, jammed. Geertz's point was that the rite had acquired a second meaning, a political one beside the religious, and the two could no longer be carried by the same words in the same room. The fire was still burning; the room had been divided, and the ritual that installs a dharma at its deepest, the one Part 5 stood at, is the first thing to fail when that happens.

The second self-corruption is stranger, because the dharma's own *success* causes it. Doing good, it turns out, can license doing bad. The psychologists Benoît Monin and Dale Miller documented what they called moral licensing: having established our virtue in one act, we feel entitled to cut a corner in the next, as though we had banked moral credit and were now free to spend it. A dharma, by this logic, generates moral capital by the ton, and that capital becomes a permit (the laboratory finding is about individuals; scaling it up to whole communities is my own extrapolation). The community certain of its own righteousness is the community best able to excuse its own cruelty, because surely *we*, the good people, could not really be the ones doing wrong. And the very commitment-signalling that binds a group can run away into a purity spiral, an escalating contest to be the most devout and the most orthodox, until the dharma turns inward and begins devouring its own insufficiently faithful. Here the failure is not that anyone abandoned the dharma. It is that they took it too seriously in the wrong direction, and let their goodness become their alibi.

The blueprint becomes the bulldozer

The fifth twin grows from a capacity that no account of a dharma's strengths can leave out, and that this whole book stands on: a dharma can be held up and known as a path. It can be named, questioned, reformed, and even built on purpose. We watched Ambedkar do exactly that two sections ago, editing a tradition, deliberately and with precision, to free his people, and Part 8 will argue that we must learn to do such building well. So it matters that this strength has a dark twin of its own, and that this twin has the highest body count of any failure in this part.

The French revolutionaries tried it first, and most literally. In the spring of 1794 the National Convention, at Robespierre's urging, decreed a new religion into existence: the Cult of the Supreme Being, a rationalist faith of civic festivals and public virtue, designed to replace the Church it had just torn down. The inaugural festival drew hundreds of thousands to the Champ de Mars, with a statue of Atheism burned in effigy and an artificial holy mountain built for the occasion. The revolutionaries had already rebuilt time itself: history restarted at Year One, the months renamed, the seven-day week and its Sunday replaced by a rational week of ten days. It was a dharma by decree, complete with a freshly engineered installation machinery. Seven weeks after the festival, Robespierre went to the guillotine, and his religion went into the ground with him, vanishing so completely that most people now have never heard of it. The lesson is the one that Part 5 should lead us to expect. What takes generations to sink beneath consciousness cannot be legislated in a season, and a dharma that exists only as decree dies with the man who decreed it.

The Bolsheviks understood that, and aimed deeper: not new rituals for old people, but a new kind of person. Their leading theoretician, Nikolai Bukharin, said it with a frankness that still stops the breath, praising 'proletarian compulsion in all its forms, beginning with summary execution', as 'a method of reworking the human material of the capitalistic epoch into Communist humanity'. (These words reach us through a hostile witness: the anarchist Alexander Berkman, who had gone

to Russia as a believer in the revolution, quoted them in the indictment he spent the rest of his life writing.) Human material. The New Soviet Man was to be manufactured, and the factory was the labour camp. Seventy years later the project was abandoned, having reworked nothing and killed millions; Berkman's summary of the party's basic premise was that the people were a mob who 'can be made free only by compulsion'.

And then the limit case. On the seventeenth of April 1975, the Khmer Rouge took Phnom Penh and declared Year Zero: history would begin again from nothing. Within about three days they had emptied a city of two million people at gunpoint, hospitals included. Money, markets, schools, religion and the family were abolished; the banks were dynamited, worthless currency raining on the streets. My old lecturer Paul Stange, whose scholarship on Java runs through this whole book, called it 'a virtually incomprehensible effort to eliminate everything that had come from outside'. Historians still dispute the recipe: imported Maoism, a warped indigenous purification, a countryside already shattered by years of US American bombing; the erasure itself no one disputes. In under four years the regime killed nearly two million of its own people, roughly a quarter of the country. The purest blank slate ever attempted was the fastest catastrophe in this part.

James C Scott, the scholar of peasant resistance from Part 3, spent a career studying these disasters, and his diagnosis is precise. The catastrophe is not planning as such; it requires a combination. A blueprint drawn in perfect confidence. Contempt for the inherited, practical, local knowledge by which people actually live. A state willing to use the full weight of its force to impose the design. And a society too beaten down to resist. Run the three cases through that lens and a gradient appears: the Jacobins tried to replace the liturgy, the Soviets tried to replace the person, the Khmer Rouge tried to replace everything, and the body count rises with the depth of the erasure. The failure is not building. Every dharma we have met to this point was built by someone. The failure is the blank slate: the conviction that the inherited substrate, all that slow evolved and

accumulated material of the first five parts, is rubble to be cleared rather than the only material there is.

I grew up in a working-class Perth where communists were not a spectre but part of the landscape. My father was a metalworker; the shop stewards and union officials of my childhood, Party members among them, were some of the most solidly decent people I have known, and the Left they belonged to was an ecumenical world in which communists, Labor people and even the anarchists all knew one another and worked together more often than not.

As a young man I spent some years as an activist in the Communist Party of Australia myself, working out of the same Trades Hall, and I am not ashamed of a day of it; for its time and place, I still think it was right. I can say that with a straight face here, of all places, because the party I belonged to was not a branch office of the terror described above. It was the counter-case. By the time I found it, it had cut its ties to Moscow and had publicly condemned the Soviet tanks when they rolled into Prague, and it spent its last decades slowly unbuilding its own dogma, arguing itself out of one certainty after another, until in 1991 it did the thing no catastrophic dharma in this section ever managed: it judged that its own form had outlived its purpose and voted to dissolve itself, its people and their politics flowing on, by fits and starts, into the movement that inherited their ground: the Greens.

The two pictures belong side by side: the whole lesson of this twin sits between them. The same word covers the emptied city of Year Zero and the unionists I knew in Trades Hall, and what separates them was never the dream of a fairer world, which both held. It was the boot. A constructed dharma that renounces the boot can keep the power to unbuild, and every horror in this section lacked exactly that power. (None of the gentler builders ever commanded a state, so the comparison is not a controlled one; it is still the only comparison history offers.) Dharmas can be built; they always were. But never with a boot, never at gunpoint, never

against the grain of the animal, and never without leaving the unbuilding power in the hands of the people the dharma is for.

The mirror: dharma in the yoga studio

The sixth twin is the gentlest-looking and closest to home. Part 1 opened with the word 'dharma' on the front of a yoga studio, a soft and pleasant Western thing, vaguely Eastern, vaguely spiritual. It is time to look at that studio squarely, because it is a failure mode too, the failure of how a dharma travels across a line of power.

The problem is not that the West borrowed from the East. Cultures have always borrowed, and dharmas have always lived and grown by crossing borders and mixing; there were Greek kings on the frontier of India two thousand years ago who put the wheel of the dharma on their coins. Borrowing is not theft. The trouble is in the *terms*. When a powerful culture takes from a culture it once colonised, strips away the demanding ethical and communal core, keeps only the soothing technique, and sells it back as a product, something has gone wrong that the innocent word 'sharing' does not cover.

That deep structure has a name, given its critical sense by the scholar Edward Said: Orientalism, the long habit of the West constructing the East as an exotic, mysterious, faintly unreal Other, a screen onto which to project whatever the West was hungry for. The meditation app that promises stress relief with none of the inconvenient teaching about selflessness and the renunciation of craving, the mindfulness reduced to a productivity hack for the very economy it was once meant to question, has been called, sharply, 'McMindfulness', a nickname the critic Ronald Purser made stick. It keeps the calm and discards the challenge.

The appropriation goes deeper than products, all the way down into the categories themselves. The tidy nouns we reach for, 'Buddhism', 'Hinduism', and the very idea of a list of 'world religions', were to a considerable degree consolidated, named and boxed by nineteenth-century European

scholarship. Not invented: a Hindu identity defined against Muslims is visible in Indian texts from the 1200s, and Buddhists knew perfectly well what they were before Europe gave them an -ism. But the boxes carve up other people's lives in ways those people did not always recognise, built on Christian assumptions about what a religion is even supposed to be. The West did not only borrow the practices. It manufactured the containers through which we now perceive 'Eastern religion' in the first place, and then forgot they were manufactured. So when we sort the world's dharmas into their neat boxes, we are often handling tools originally forged as instruments of empire.

And now the sting I cannot avoid, because the non-privileging eye has to turn back on itself. This very project, a secular dharma assembled in a Western language from traditions elsewhere, is a prime suspect in its own investigation. When I lift a 'universal core' out of Buddhism and set its Asian cosmology aside as cultural packaging, I am doing the exact move an appropriator would do, and saying the exact thing an appropriator would say to justify it. Whether that is honest translation or quiet theft is not settled by my good intentions. It hangs on power, on reciprocity, on whether I keep the demanding parts or only the pleasant ones, and on whether I am willing to be changed by what I borrow or only to consume it. I do not get to exempt myself from this. No one does.

The wolf in the flock

Every failure we have walked through so far shares one feature, and it is the feature that makes them so disturbing: they are sincere. The fence-builder loves his people; the priest who crowns the king believes in the crown; the keeper of the cage thinks he is preserving order; the planner who empties a city believes, with all his heart, in the blueprint; and even the appropriator, myself included, mostly means well. The dark twins need no villain. Ordinary devotion, turned a few degrees, does the damage by itself.

But a dharma is not only vulnerable to its sincere believers. The apparatus that makes it work, the deep trust it manufactures and the benefit of the doubt it extends to anyone who performs the right devotions, is a standing invitation to a figure who is not sincere at all. Back in Part 2, costly, hard-to-fake signals sorted the committed from the casual and welded a group together. That filter was built to keep out the free rider, the one who wants the warmth of belonging without paying for it. It works against almost everyone. It does not work against the rare person who can perform every signal flawlessly and feel nothing behind it.

Such people exist. The clinical literature has described the far end of the range since the psychiatrist Hervey Cleckley named the 'mask of sanity' in 1941: a stretch of the human range (as Part 5 said, not a separate kind of human being, nor a headcount any two instruments agree on) in whom the ordinary equipment of conscience, empathy, fear, and remorse is, from early on, muted close to silence. But a dharma does not check diagnoses at the door. What creates the opening is the structure, not the rarity of the people who might walk through it. A dharma produces trust in bulk and hands it to whoever wears the robe convincingly, so the devotions can be worn as a costume, clinical profile or none, by anyone able to perform them without feeling their pull. This is the guru who preys on his disciples, the venerated elder unmasked after thirty years, the holy man whose followers cannot credit the charges precisely because he played the part so well. He does not overextend a strength. He wears it.

Here the deep past speaks straight to the present. The forager bands of Part 2 had a remedy for exactly this figure: the intimidator who could not be shamed was watched, levelled, and in the last resort removed, because in a camp of thirty there is nowhere for a predator to hide. What the small band could do, the mega-society cannot. The very anonymity that broke the old morality, the sea of strangers a dharma was built to cross, is also the condition under which the predator flourishes, because the transparency that once exposed him cannot reach across a congregation of thousands or a corporation of tens of thousands. What protected the

band was never a gift for detecting insincerity; it was accountable authority: everyone visible, everyone levellable, and the settled power to remove. Any community that manufactures trust at scale owes its members the modern forms of that same equipment. And it owes them one memory more: this same equipment has served, in every age, to punish mere difference, so a community that hunts wolves must watch what else gets called a wolf.

We built dharmas so that strangers could trust strangers, and in the same stroke we built the ideal cover for the stranger who should never be trusted. And this undoes the comfort sincerity seemed to offer: the sincere butcher may be more troubling than the fake one, but it does not follow that sincerity is a test we can lean on. Sincerity is the very thing the predator counterfeits, and a dharma's demand for visible devotion rewards the most fluent counterfeiter in the room.

No dharma is safe

Taken together, these twins tell a single and rather severe truth.

The bond that holds a community together is the fence that shuts the stranger out. The authority that lets a prophet shame a tyrant is the authority that lets a priest crown one. A path that promises a good life can trap half of humanity inside an assigned role. The very fire that gives a dharma life is the fire that gutters out into empty form, or flares up into a righteousness that licenses cruelty. The capacity that lets a people know, reform and build its own path is the capacity that, armed with a state and a blueprint, will bulldoze a living world to make room for a paper one. The exchange that lets dharmas grow is the extraction that strip-mines a conquered people's wisdom for a product.

In every case the failure is not a foreign contamination that a purer practice could avoid. It is the strength itself, running past its limit. Even the predator who games a dharma from outside marks the rule's edge: not a strength overextended but a strength counterfeited, possible only

because the strengths are real. That means the comforting dream, the dream of finding the one good dharma that does not fail, is an illusion. There is no such dharma. The tendency to fail is the standing price of a dharma being powerful enough to do anything at all.

This is bleak, but it is also clarifying, because it finally kills a question we should never have been asking. 'Is it a dharma?' was never the same question as 'Is it good?' A thing can be fully, authentically a dharma, comprehensive and binding and deep, and be an instrument of horror. So we cannot rest in the comfortable pluralism that says every path is one more lovely flower in the garden. Some of these flowers are poison. If failure is intrinsic, then the only question left is not 'which dharma is pure', because none is, but 'which dharma fails least, and recovers best, and by what standard could we possibly say?' That is the question of judgement, the one we have been walking toward, and we can no longer walk around it.

But one complication remains. Every dharma we have put on trial here, every caste order and household code and crusading faith, was built long ago, for a world that no longer exists: the world of the village, the empire, the kinship clan, the agrarian field. *That world is gone.* For hundreds of millions of people now, the old gods have fallen silent, and the village has been replaced by the restless, rootless, screen-lit anonymity of the modern city and the internet. So the question is about to become double. Not only how we are to judge dharmas, but also what becomes of dharma itself now, in an age that has misplaced the foundations on which every previous dharma was built.

« 5: How a dharma gets under your skin | 7: Dharmas in a secular age »

Sources & further reading

This part is built from the project's research notes, which carry the full inline citations. Listed here are the notes it draws on and the key works behind them.

Research notes

Research notes used in this book are published on GitHub – https://github.com/Biksu-Okusi/In-Search-of-Dharma.

- 7.1 Failure Modes – the four failure clusters, the No-True-Scotsman refusal, and the thesis that failure-proneness is intrinsic. The spine of this part.
- 7.3 Dharma & Power – the double face: morality as anti-domination captured to sanctify domination; Gramsci, Bourdieu, and Ambedkar.
- 6.4 Gender & Dharma – the subordinating mainstream and the liberating countercurrent; the same scripture as chains and keys.
- 6.3 Economics, Work & Inequality – dharma as justifier, constraint, and critic of economic order; meritocracy and Graeber on debt.
- 7.7 Dharma by Decree: The Engineered-Dharma Failure Mode – the blueprint twin: the Jacobin cults, the New Soviet Man, Year Zero, and Scott's authoritarian high modernism; the conditional licence for Part 8.
- 7.6 Dogma Undone: The CPA Case – the counter-case: the externally fact-checked history of a communist party that cut its ties to Moscow, unmade its own dogma, and dissolved itself.
- 7.2 Cultural Adaptation & Appropriation – Orientalism, 'McMindfulness', and the reflexive indictment of secular translation.
- 5.5 Psychopaths & the Exploiter Limit Case – the insincere predator who games a dharma's trust; the free rider that costly signalling and Boehm's reverse-dominance evolved to catch, and the one type built to beat the filter.

Key works

- On authentic failure: the No-True-Scotsman / internal-diversity argument (Harvard Religious Literacy Project), and Mark Juergensmeyer, *Terror in the Mind of God* – sacred violence across every tradition; with the Wirathu / Rohingya case (TIME's cover story of 1 July 2013, 'The Face of Buddhist Terror'; the UN Human Rights Council's Independent International Fact-Finding Mission on Myanmar, report of September 2018; UNHCR's figures for the 2017 exodus into Bangladesh – more than 700,000 in the first year, atop earlier flights that carry the displaced total past a million).
- Richard Wrangham, *The Goodness Paradox* (2019) – the lethal boundary as cultural rather than bred in the bone, and therefore movable (chimpanzees share our war-death rates but show no battlefield self-sacrifice).
- Clifford Geertz, 'Ritual and Social Change: A Javanese Example', *American Anthropologist* 59(1) (1957): 32–54, repr. in *The Interpretation of Cultures* (1973) – the Modjokuto funeral that could not be held.
- On a dharma's self-corruption: Max Weber on the routinisation of charisma; John Welwood on 'spiritual bypassing'; and Benoît Monin & Dale Miller on moral licensing.
- Michel Foucault, *Discipline and Punish* (1975), on productive power – power that manufactures subjects rather than merely restraining them; the application to a dharma's apparatus of self-formation is this part's extension of that premise.
- James C Scott, *Seeing Like a State* (1998) – why the great schemes to redesign society fail: the blueprint, the coercive state, the prostrate society, and the destruction of practical local knowledge.
- On the engineered catastrophes: François Ponchaud, *Cambodia: Year Zero* (1977); Alexander Berkman, *What Is Communist Anarchism?* (1929) – Bukharin's 'human material' doctrine witnessed from inside; and Paul Stange, *Ancestral Voices in Island Asia* (2009) on the Khmer Rouge.
- Christopher Boehm on morality as anti-domination; Karl Marx ('the opium of the people'); Antonio Gramsci on hegemony; Pierre

Bourdieu on the 'power of legitimate naming'; and BR Ambedkar's Navayāna Buddhism.

- On the predator who games a dharma: Hervey Cleckley, *The Mask of Sanity* (1941), and Robert Hare, *Without Conscience* (1993) – psychopathy as a dimension of the human range, with conscience and empathy constitutionally muted at its far end; with Boehm (above) on the band's levelling of the intimidator the mega-society can no longer watch.
- On gender: the *Manusmṛti*, the *garudhammas*, and the Confucian 'three obediences' (Ban Zhao); the *Therīgāthā*; the Bhakti poets Mīrābāī and Akka Mahādēvi; Galatians 3:28; Amina Wadud, *Qur'an and Woman*; and Rita Gross, *Buddhism After Patriarchy*.
- On economics: Michael Sandel, *The Tyranny of Merit*; David Graeber, *Debt: The First 5,000 Years*; and Karl Polanyi, *The Great Transformation*.
- On appropriation: Edward Said, *Orientalism*; Jeremy Carrette & Richard King, *Selling Spirituality*; and the colonial construction of the very category 'world religions'; with David Lorenzen, 'Who Invented Hinduism?' (1999) and Audrey Truschke (2023) for the correction that the identities were consolidated, not invented, by colonial scholarship.

7: Dharmas in a secular age

Audio: Part 7: in search of dharma



Dharmas in a secular age

Hundreds of millions of people now say they are 'spiritual but not religious'. That is not the absence of a dharma. It is the search for one, carried out by people who have lost the old foundations but kept the old need.

There is a kind of person nearly everyone now knows, and many of us have been.

She left the religion she was raised in, or was never really given one, and she does not believe in much that she cannot see. But she is not empty, and she is not satisfied. So she has assembled something. A little yoga, for the body and for whatever the body seems to know. A meditation app on her phone, ten minutes most mornings, its closing bell followed at once by the notifications waiting behind it. A book of Stoic sayings on the nightstand, a few wise voices in her headphones on the commute, some hard-won vocabulary from therapy, perhaps a quiet practice of gratitude she would feel slightly embarrassed to describe. She has not joined anything. She has built a private patchwork, stitched together from half a dozen traditions she does not formally belong to, and she lives by it as best she can.

There are now a vast number of these people, and the surveys have a name for them: the 'nones', the religiously unaffiliated. Theirs is the category that grew faster than any other in the Western world across the two decades to about 2020 (in the US, from 16% of adults in 2007 to roughly 29% by 2024), before its rise levelled off. The usual way to read them is as a story of decline, the slow draining-away of religion, leaving behind a thin consumer spirituality, a supermarket of the self where lonely people push trolleys past the incense and the self-help. I read them differently. What the seeker is doing is searching for a dharma, in the hardest possible conditions, as someone who has inherited the deep human need to hold a life together but has lost every one of the old foundations on which a dharma used to be built.

The old dharmas, with all their captures and cages, were made for the village and the empire and the believing crowd, and that world is gone. So the question now is whether a dharma can survive the loss at all. Can there be a real one, a binding one, a transforming one, without the foundations on which every previous dharma stood?

Three things a dharma used to get for free

To answer that, we have to be specific about what those lost foundations actually did, because 'faith' is too vague. A traditional religious dharma got three things, more or less for free, that a secular one has to find some other way to earn. Free, that is, to the person born inside it; the tradition itself paid for them continuously, in institutions and labour and discipline, and in no small amount of exclusion and coercion. The inheritance was free. The estate never was.

The first was *grounding*: a reason its commands were binding rather than merely optional, usually a commanding God who made 'thou shalt' into law rather than a preference. The second was *installation*: the whole apparatus of ritual, sacred ordeal, and tight community, anchored to unfalsifiable belief, that drove a dharma down into people until it ran their lives. And the third was a *world that cooperated*, a slow, face-to-face, information-poor world in which the main obstacle to living well was your own untrained heart. A secular dharma in the twenty-first century has lost all three. It has no divine lawgiver, a frayed and improvised apparatus, and a new world that, far from being indifferent to the holding-together a dharma does, is actively engineered against it.

A fourth thing is easy to leave off the list because it was so ordinary: a script for the day someone dies, saying who washes the body, who is told first, what is said, how long the house stays open, when the mourner may work again. Nobody had to invent it in the worst week of their life; it was simply there, and doing it was itself the consolation. That, too, is now something to be earned.

Before testing whether that loss can be survived, the frame itself has to stand trial, because the story I have just told has a name, and the philosopher whose title this part borrows spent nine hundred pages arguing against it. Charles Taylor calls accounts like mine *subtraction stories*: tales in which modernity is simply what remains once human beings have 'lost, or sloughed off, or liberated themselves from' the old

confining illusions. His objection is not a quibble. Western secularity, he argues, is 'the fruit of new inventions, newly constructed self-understandings and related practices'; not an emptiness left by religion's retreat but a new, positive, built condition, whose signature invention is what he calls exclusive humanism, the first widely available way of living oriented entirely within this world. The anthropologist Talal Asad presses the same point from another flank: 'the secular' is not the neutral ground left when the gods withdraw; it is a constructed formation with a history of its own.

If they are right, and I think they are, then my talk of silence and loss is the believer's-eye view of something that looks, from the other side, like a construction site. This does not weaken my argument; I think it completes it. The secular age is a crowded workshop of new dharmas, exclusive humanism first among them, the proliferating 'nova' of options Taylor describes, and the workshop is where the whole of Part 8 takes place.

But Taylor sharpens the problem too, in a way my subtraction telling actually understated. In the old world, the three free gifts went to whoever was born inside the dharma. In the secular age, Taylor argues, every position, belief and unbelief alike, is held as one option among others: contested, fragile, reflectively chosen. Which means the believer has lost the free gifts as well. Nobody now inherits grounding, installation, and a cooperating world; every dharma in the nova, religious or secular, has to earn all three the hard way. The tests that follow are therefore not the secular dharma's special burden. They are the entrance exam every dharma now sits, and the secular candidate merely sits it without notes.

Can it bind?

Grounding is the objection the believer presses hardest, and the question Part 1 raised. Without a God behind it, the challenge runs, a dharma cannot really *bind* anyone. 'Thou shalt not' needs a lawgiver; remove the divine legislator and all our fine moral language collapses into 'I would rather people didn't'. The philosopher Elizabeth Anscombe put it in sharp

terms: the whole vocabulary of moral obligation, of what one *ought* and *must* do, is the wreckage of a system that assumed a divine law, and it becomes literally incoherent once the lawgiver is gone, leaving only preferences dressed up as duties.

It is a serious challenge, and the answer comes in two moves, the first of which Part 1 named and left standing. Plato's old trap, the Euthyphro question: is a thing good because God commands it, or does God command it because it is good? Take the first horn, and morality is arbitrary, a divine whim. Take the second, and the goodness was already there, independent, for God to recognise, so God is not its source after all. Either way, the divine command was never really doing the grounding work it advertised itself as doing. The believer who feels she stands on bedrock, and pities the secularist standing on sand, has mistaken the view. She was never on bedrock either.

The second move is harder, and it cuts against everyone, the believer and the secularist and the scientist alike. There is an old problem, sometimes called the trilemma, about *any* attempt to justify something all the way down: every chain of 'but why?' must end in one of three places: an infinite regress, a circle, or simply a place to stop and plant your feet. There is no exception. No system of ethics, religious, secular or scientific, has ever reached genuine bedrock, because there is no bedrock to reach; the demand for an ultimate, unanswerable foundation is a demand that nothing in human life can meet. And once that is seen, the challenge to secular dharmas loses its force, because it was holding the secularist to a standard the believer never met either. The real question was never 'is it grounded all the way down', since nothing is. It is 'is it grounded *well enough to live by*, and how?'

And to that question a secular dharma has real answers, just not cosmic ones. It can ground its claim on us in the brute fact that we are the kind of creature to whom things already matter, who cannot, except by damage, stop caring about suffering, our own and others'. It can ground it in what the philosopher Philippa Foot called natural goodness, the thought that

for a living thing of a particular kind there is a recognisable shape to flourishing, the way there is for an oak or a wolf; cruelty and cowardice are defects in a human life as real as blight in a tree. It can ground it in the moral sentiments we are built with, the empathy and the sense of fairness that make another's pain register in us whether we consent or not.

None of these is a thunderbolt from heaven. Each is enough to live by. The binding they produce is real, but it is a different shape of binding from the commandment's: it is internal rather than imposed, conditional rather than absolute, a matter of *if we would live well with others, then*, rather than *thou shalt, or else*. That conditional, this-worldly binding may be the only kind there ever was. The commandment-shaped certainty the believer mourns was, perhaps, always a story we told about a binding that actually came from the same place the secularist's does: the fact that we are an animal to whom it matters how we live.

That conditional shape is easy to mistake for weakness. To say a dharma binds you only *if* you would live well is not to say it binds you feebly. Compare the rules of health. They are not handed down from the sky; they hold, conditionally, for any creature that wants to go on living: if you would not sicken, then eat and move and sleep in roughly these ways. Nobody calls the laws of nutrition flimsy for being conditional on wanting to live. The dharmic 'ought' works the same way, and it binds with real force on anyone who has not somehow opted out of caring how their one life goes, which is to say on very nearly everyone alive.

The hardest version of the grounding objection, though, comes not from the believer but from inside the godless camp. Friedrich Nietzsche agreed entirely that the divine ground was an illusion – and drew the opposite conclusion from the one this part has been building. When the belief goes, he argued, the morality raised on it must eventually follow: the secular moralists of his day had rid themselves of the Christian God while clinging all the harder to Christian morality, not seeing that a faith is a system, a whole view of things thought out together, so that breaking out the God breaks the rest.

On his diagnosis the very things a secular ethic keeps – compassion, the priority of suffering, care for the weak – are not self-evident truths but inherited residue, a pity-morality running on borrowed authority; he even jeered that Europe's spreading religion of sympathy was heading toward 'a European Buddhism'. The taunt lands close to home, and it deserves a straight answer rather than a wince. The answer is the one this book has been assembling since Part 2: care is not the residue of any creed. The mattering, the empathy, the fairness-sense are older than every scripture that later claimed them, the evolved endowment of a cooperative animal, which the creeds inherited and codified rather than invented. Nietzsche is owed one concession, and it is a real one: he is right that the content cannot simply be kept on as obvious. It must be defended, positively, on its own this-worldly ground.

And a dharma can add an answer here that is peculiarly its own. It does not finally rest its authority on an argument you could win or lose in a debate. It rests it on an invitation: come and see. The old Buddhist word is *ehipassiko*, and what it asks for is your experiment. Live this way, it says, actually do the practice, and watch what happens to your own suffering and to the suffering of the people around you. The grounding, on this view, is a result discovered inside a life, and that relocates the whole question from the heavens down to lived consequence, which is exactly where a secular age can still test it. It is a humbler foundation than a commandment, but it is also one you can actually check.

Can it install?

Grounding, though, is the easier of the two philosophical problems, and the one secular dharmas worry about too much. The harder one is installation, and it is where most of them fail.

A dharma gets inside a person not by argument but by drilling: by ritual, repeated practice, and tight community, driven below conscious thought until it runs a life. And part of what made that drilling stick, historically, was that it was anchored to claims one could never test and so never

disprove. A secular dharma throws the unfalsifiable anchor overboard on purpose. The question is whether the apparatus still works once that is done, and the answer is that it sometimes does and often does not, and the difference between the two outcomes is the most practical thing a seeker can learn.

Take an ancient practice, lift the one technique out of the demanding ethical and communal whole it grew in, and sell that technique on its own as a tool for feeling better. This is what happened to mindfulness. Pulled out of Buddhism and packaged as an eight-week stress-reduction course, it spread to clinics and corporations and schools, and on its own narrow terms it works: Madhav Goyal's meta-analysis of the careful trials finds real if modest reductions in anxiety and pain. There is nothing wrong with a clinical tool doing clinical work; nobody faults an analgesic for not being a way of life. But as a dharma it was hollowed out in the lifting, which is why the nickname 'McMindfulness' has bitten so hard. Stripped of the ethics that once gave it a direction, mindfulness became a way of helping stressed and exploited people tolerate the conditions that were stressing and exploiting them, a tool for making a more productive worker rather than a freer person. The lesson is brutal and clear: efficacy is not transformation. A practice can be clinically proven to work and have entirely lost the point.

But the other outcome is real, and it is why this is not a counsel of despair. One can strip the metaphysics and *keep the whole bundle*, the practice and the ethics and the community together, and put something this-worldly in the place the old supernatural anchor used to hold. This is what the former monk Stephen Batchelor calls secular Buddhism, or better, secular dharma. He lets the rebirth and the karma fall away as the cultural packaging of ancient India, and keeps the contemplative practice, but he does not keep only the soothing technique. He deliberately puts the ethics back, and widens them, insisting that the practice must turn on racism and injustice in the world as much as on greed and craving in the self, exactly the social dimension that McMindfulness had dropped.

One doctrine in that discarded packaging deserves a second look before it goes, because the rule being applied – reconstruct, don't extract – applies to it too. Karma can be let fall with the rebirth it was wired to, or indicted: wedded to caste, the doctrine that told a man his station was his own past deeds collecting their debt, until Ambedkar led half a million people out from under it. But there is a third option the argument should at least name: karma naturalised, as a this-worldly technology of intention and consequence.

The Buddha himself defined karma as intention, and read that way the doctrine asserts things a secular ethic can keep with a straight face: that intentions shape the actor who holds them, each choice grooving the next, which is Part 5's habituation machinery in ancient dress; that consequences propagate through a community whether or not anyone is watching, which is Part 2's reputation machinery likewise; and that no ledger is kept anywhere else. Rebirth was the packaging; the feedback loop was the point. I flag this reconstruction rather than perform it, since performing it would be a book of its own. But a secular dharma that admires Batchelor's method should notice that the method does not have to stop where Batchelor stopped.

Or look at the success story of modern Stoicism, which translated into the secular world so completely that it became a school of psychotherapy: the founders of cognitive behavioural therapy openly credited Epictetus. His line 'men are disturbed not by things, but by the views which they take of them' is the seed of the whole method. The historian of ancient philosophy Pierre Hadot reframes the entire project. Ancient philosophy, he showed, was never mainly a set of doctrines; it was a way of life, a body of spiritual exercises practised daily, and that practical core withered only later, when philosophy hardened into something merely read and argued about. On Hadot's reading, secular translation at its best is not a theft from religion at all. It is a *recovery*, a restoring of the lived, practised, transforming core that the traditions themselves had often buried under doctrine and institution.

Secular translation is a transferable structure, not one tradition's lucky accident: the very same operation has been performed inside Christianity. The Anglican theologian Don Cupitt, in a book bravely titled *Taking Leave of God*, argued that religious language can carry our deepest human and ethical aspirations without pointing to any supernatural being out there at all, sustaining a this-worldly, practised spirituality with the metaphysics politely set to one side. Strip the supernatural, keep the practice and the ethics, re-ground the whole thing in this life: it is precisely Batchelor's recipe cooked in a different kitchen, and the two men recognised each other as kin.

From the successes and the failures together, a clear rule emerges. A secular translation keeps its transforming power when it does three things: it preserves the whole bundle of practice, ethics, and community rather than lifting out the technique alone; it supplies some this-worldly replacement for whatever the old metaphysics used to do, the binding and the motivating and the enduring; and it stays a way of life one practises rather than a worldview one merely holds. Do all three and a dharma can survive the loss of its gods. Do none of them, keeping the soothing technique and discarding the rest, and the result is simply another McMindfulness.

The bundle has a third strand, though, and it is the one the modern world is least able to supply. A dharma installs through community, through a real and present 'we': the congregation that drills the practice together and holds its members to it, the people whose watching eyes make the commitment cost something. And community is what the secular and the digital age have thinned almost to nothing. The self that modern life produces is what its communitarian critics call the unencumbered individual, cut loose from the dense web of relationships that older dharmas took for granted, and increasingly that self meets other selves only through a screen. Our seeker with her app and her book is trying to install a dharma essentially alone, which is a little like trying to learn a language with no one to speak it to. She can keep the practice on her own,

and even, with effort, the ethics. The 'we' is the hardest part to rebuild from scratch, and a dharma without a 'we' struggles to get beyond the surface of a single private life. This, more than the missing God, may be the secular dharma's deepest practical wound.

The missing 'we' costs most at a death, because the seeker cannot bury alone. When her mother dies she discovers that the practice has nothing to say about a body, that the people who would have known what to do belong to a congregation she left, and that the old words, which she has decided are false, are the only ones anyone in the room knows. The humanist celebrant has appeared to fill that gap, in Britain especially: a professional hired to compose a rite for a family that no longer has one. I do not have reliable figures, but the trade exists and, as far as I can tell, is growing. A dharma that must hire its funerals from outside has not yet installed. Beside grounding and installation, then, a third test: can it bury?

Sumarah, the Javanese fellowship of total surrender we looked at in Part 4, looks like the strongest card in the secular dharma's hand, and, *as a model*, in some ways it is: a living, non-Western tradition, now ninety years old, that practises without scripture, guru or creed; that asks nobody to convert, having nothing to convert them to, so that Muslims, Christians and Buddhists sit together and remain what they are; that tells its members to accept nothing on faith ('We differ from religions, within which people accept God on faith and without knowledge', its first chairman said); and that installs, precisely, through the 'we' the modern seeker lacks, a weekly circle and a guide attuned to the room, transformation by sitting together rather than by doctrine.

Most of what the three-part rule demands was achieved in Java decades before any Western experiment began: the institutional half of the problem, practice without priesthood, and the epistemological half, conviction without creed, are demonstrably solvable, because a small fellowship solved them and has held the solution for three generations. But the rest of the story cuts the other way.

When Sumarah's own practitioners devised a religiously neutral 'relaxed meditation' for officials and foreigners, the leadership ruled from inside that meditation without God 'led to void and not God'; the apparatus was removable, but the theism was the point. Even that ruling, though, has a shadow that could not be named while the Indonesian New Order stood: it was issued under a state that had, after the massacres of 1965, treated atheism as communism's twin – no statute ever named it; none was needed to make it lethal to profess – and made priority to God the price of a movement's legal existence, so how much of the floor was devotion, how much the pious etiquette that opens all Indonesian public speech, and how much survival is a question the record can no longer answer.

The secular-feeling Sumarah that Western practitioners sit in today exists because the translation was performed in transit, by the receivers. A great deal, it turns out, can be stripped from a dharma and the practice survive. What no tradition has yet shown, from the inside, is the removal of its own God; that operation, so far, has always been done by someone else, somewhere downstream, and Sumarah, for three decades, was not even free to try. The proof of concept is real, and it is not ours. The hard part is still ours to do.

So can a secular dharma install? The verdict is: sometimes, if it keeps the whole bundle and works hard to replace what the gods used to supply. The secular experiments are real but young, and we should be suspicious of how readily the people running them, this project among them, declare their own success. But the failure mode and the success mode are now clear enough to steer by, and that is not nothing.

The new terrain

Suppose, though, that both problems were solved, that a secular dharma could be both grounded and installed. It would still have to do its work in a world unlike any a dharma has faced before, and this is the part that is genuinely new under the sun.

Nearly every dharma in history was built on the working assumption that the main obstacle to living well sat inside your own skull: your own craving, your own distraction, your own untrained mind. The contemplative traditions were, accordingly, technologies for disciplining attention against an *inner* enemy. The outer assault is not wholly new; the last century's advertisers, propagandists and broadcasters had already begun it. What is new, and only about twenty years old, is an apparatus that is personalised, ubiquitous, and self-improving: one that learns each mind's particular weaknesses, individually and in real time, and gets better at exploiting them with every use. The enemy is no longer only inside us, and no longer generic. It is outside us, industrialised, very well funded, and it knows you.

We have built, in a single generation, what its own critics call the attention economy, an enormous apparatus whose business is the capture and resale of human attention. Our gaze is the product; the feed is the bait. And the bait is engineered, with enormous skill and oceans of data, to hijack the very reward systems evolution gave us. In the psychologist Mark van Vugt's description, social media is a supernormal stimulus, an exaggerated cue that feeds our ancient hunger for connection far more cheaply and intensely than real life ever could, the way junk food hijacks a palate evolved for scarce sugar and fat. We have, he notes bleakly, no natural defences against it.

James Williams, who left a career inside Google's advertising machine to study what it does to us, puts the stakes plainly: these systems are not neutral tools but engines for 'redirecting people away from their wills', from what they actually, reflectively want their lives to be. A dharma's oldest and deepest job was to hold a human life together, to gather a scattered self around what matters. The attention economy is, almost precisely, a machine built for the opposite purpose: to scatter the self, to shatter attention into sellable fragments, to keep us reactive and outraged and never quite still.

Private attention is only half the damage; the rest falls on the shared world we attend to together. The old gatekeepers of information, for all their faults, are gone, and into the gap pours an undifferentiated flood. The best-known study of how falsehood moves through a social network, by Soroush Vosoughi and his colleagues, found it spreading further and faster than the truth, and the usual explanation is that outrage is the most engaging product of all. I would not lean the whole weight of an argument on that finding, which concerns one platform in one period and which later researchers have worked hard to qualify.

But you do not need the strong version. It is enough that the sorting is done by engagement rather than by truth, and that nobody designed it to care about the difference. Worse, the very act of publicly broadcasting a conviction tends to harden it, so a medium built for endless broadcasting is also a machine for making everyone more certain and less movable. The new age does not tame the failure modes traced earlier; it amplifies and accelerates them. The purity spiral that once took a generation to consume a community can now run its course in a weekend, and the lethal fence between 'us' and 'them' is rebuilt a thousand times a day by systems that have learned that division holds attention better than peace. A dharma for this terrain is not facing the old, slow drift of a wandering mind. It is facing an adversary that gets cleverer every quarter.

This forces something new on any dharma that means to survive here. The old contemplative move, work on the self, train one's own mind, is necessary but no longer sufficient, because no amount of private inner discipline can hold out indefinitely against a billion-dollar industry engineering our weaknesses in real time. A digital-age dharma has to work on the *environment* as well as the self: on the design of the machines, on the rules that govern them, on the shared structures of attention.

The contemplative traditions were never hermetically apolitical; monasteries negotiated with kings, and patronage shaped what could be taught. But no path before this one had to treat the design of the surrounding attention environment as itself a matter of practice, and that

political and collective register is now central rather than marginal. The new register is audible in the people groping toward it: the writer Jenny Odell's call to resist the colonisation of our attention by reattaching it to place and community and the physical world, or the movements pressing for a more humane technology that would be built to serve our intentions rather than to farm them.

And the deepest irony of all: the single most celebrated secular dharma of our time, mindfulness, has itself been swallowed whole by the attention economy, sold back to us as the very coping tool that lets us endure the machine, the same hollowing McMindfulness names. The cure has been digested by the disease. Any real dharma for this age has to be more than a better way of putting up with it.

One thing does *not* change in all this, and it points to the resource a new dharma has to draw on. The deepest contemplative traditions never treated attention as a neutral spotlight to aim wherever one pleased. In Buddhism, the relevant idea is not 'bare attention' but something closer to 'appropriate attention', a noticing already shaped by ethics and intention and woven into the whole question of how to live. The attention economy, by reducing mindfulness to a content-free knack of just-noticing, severed attention from that ethical core, and that severing is exactly what made it so easy to capture and resell.

A real digital-age dharma is therefore partly a recovery, the same move Hadot described: it restores the old truth that what you attend to, and how, is already a moral act, the very fabric of the person you are slowly becoming. And it has begun to grow its own concrete practices. The writer Cal Newport's 'digital minimalism' is recognisably an installation practice in the old sense: a month-long declutter, a deliberate, almost ruthless pruning of the apps and feeds back down to the few that serve a chosen value, a ritual of subtraction meant to retrain a scattered attention until focus becomes, once again, a settled disposition rather than a daily losing fight.

The shape of the question changes

The inherited dharmas are fraying, and most of them were made for a world that is gone. The secular replacements can perhaps be grounded, though only in the quieter, conditional way that may be the only grounding there ever was; and they can perhaps be installed, though the apparatus is improvised and the evidence is young; and they must do their work on terrain engineered, deliberately and for profit, against the gathering of a self. That is a daunting tally. But the seeker we started with, the one with the yoga and the app and the book of Stoic sayings, looks different now. She is not a symptom of decline. She is doing, alone and clumsily and mostly without help, the most ancient human work there is: trying to assemble, out of the materials at hand, a dharma she can live by. The patchwork is construction, under conditions no earlier builder ever faced.

And that recognition changes the very shape of the question we have been asking all along. For all of human history before now, the question a person faced was: *which* of the inherited dharmas is the true one, and how do I submit myself to it? One was born onto a path, and the task was to walk it. But the seeker cannot ask that question any more, and she knows it. So the question is mutating, in her hands and in ours, into something no previous age could quite bring itself to ask out loud. Not *which dharma do I receive*, but: *can we build a better one, knowing exactly what we are doing, on purpose?*

That is a vertiginous question. It is also the most dangerous question there is, because the instant one says out loud that dharmas can be built, the terrible follow-ups arrive: built by whom, for whom, toward what end, and what gets crushed in the building? And we are being made to ask it at the most demanding moment imaginable, on a planet in crisis that may need some shared ethic to survive at all, and on the eve of building machines that may soon think, into which someone, somewhere, is already preparing to pour an ethic of their own. We have come, at last, to the making of dharmas. That is Part 8.

Sources & further reading

This part is built from the project's research notes, which carry the full inline citations. Listed here are the notes it draws on and the key works behind them.

Research notes

Research notes used in this book are published on GitHub – https://github.com/Biksu-Okusi/In-Search-of-Dharma.

- 3.3 The Grounding Problem – whether a godless dharma can bind: the Euthyphro reframing, the trilemma of ultimate justification, Nietzsche's radicalisation, and the this-worldly anchors. The spine of 'Can it bind?'
- 6.1 Secular Translation – extraction versus reconstruction; Batchelor, McMindfulness, Stoicism-to-CBT, and Hadot's 'recovery'. The spine of 'Can it install?'
- 3.5.4 Sumarah & the Secular-Dharma Question – the 'living proof' claim calibrated: the institutional and epistemological halves solved at origin, the theological half translated in transit; 'void and not God', and that ruling's own duress-contamination under a state that treated atheism as communism's twin after 1965. The spine of the Sumarah paragraph.
- 3.5.2 Sumarah: Practice & Transmission – the weekly guided circle as installation through a 'we'; practice without scripture, guru, or creed; the 'relaxed meditation' dispute.
- 3.5.3 Sumarah: Rasa Epistemology – Surono's 'we differ from religions' and conviction-without-creed as a working epistemology.
- 6.2 Digital-Age Dharma – the attention economy as an external, industrial adversary; the supernormal stimulus; and the move from self-cultivation to environment-design.
- 3.1 Tension Resolution – the atomised modern self and the community a dharma needs but the secular age has thinned.

- 7.2 Cultural Adaptation & Appropriation – dharma-as-consumer-product; the extraction critique that 'McMindfulness' sharpens.
- 6.5 Secularisation & the 'Nones' – the Pew demographics behind the opening: the US 'nones' at 29% (and plateaued), SBNR at 22%, the global 1.9 billion; why 'fastest-growing' needs its time-and-place qualifier; and the Taylor–Asad correction to the subtraction frame (secularity as construction, and the fragilisation of every position) that this part's 'on trial' passage states.

Key works

- Charles Taylor, *A Secular Age* (2007) – the source of this part's title, engaged rather than merely borrowed: against 'subtraction stories', secularity as 'the fruit of new inventions'; exclusive humanism; the nova effect; the fragilisation of belief and unbelief alike. With Talal Asad, *Formations of the Secular* (2003) – 'the secular' as a constructed formation with its own history, not religion's residue.
- On grounding: GEM Anscombe, 'Modern Moral Philosophy' (1958), for the no-lawgiver objection; Plato's *Euthyphro*; the Münchhausen trilemma; and Philippa Foot, *Natural Goodness* (2001), on flourishing for a creature of our kind. Friedrich Nietzsche, *The Gay Science* (1882), *The Genealogy of Morals* (1887) and *Twilight of the Idols* (written 1888), for the counter-thesis from the godless side: that the death of God takes the content of the morality with it.
- On karma naturalised: the Buddha's definition of karma as intention (*Aṅguttara Nikāya* 6.63); BR Ambedkar, *The Buddha and His Dhamma* (1957), for the indictment Part 6 carries; the reconstruction sketched here is the author's own application of Batchelor's method, flagged rather than performed.
- The adjacent US American debate this book mostly stays out of: Robert Wright, *Why Buddhism Is True* (2017), the evolutionary-psychology vindication of meditation; Owen Flanagan, *The Bodhisattva's Brain* (2011), Buddhism naturalised as a philosophy of mind; and Evan Thompson, *Why I Am Not a Buddhist* (2020), the

sharpest refusal of both – of Buddhist exceptionalism and of 'neural Buddhism' – and the objection nearest this book's own method.

- B Alan Wallace, 'Distorted Visions of Buddhism' – the traditionalist counter-voice to Batchelor: rebirth and karma as load-bearing structure, not cultural packaging.
- Soroush Vosoughi, Deb Roy & Sinan Aral, 'The Spread of True and False News Online' (*Science*, 2018) – the falsehood-travels-faster finding; read here at second hand, and how far it generalises is debated.
- Stephen Batchelor, *Secular Buddhism / After Buddhism* – reconstruction that keeps the practice, the ethics, and the community; with Ronald Purser, *McMindfulness* (2019), for the extraction failure mode, and the Goyal et al. (2014) meta-analysis on mindfulness's modest efficacy.
- Epictetus, *Enchiridion*, and the Stoicism-to-CBT lineage (Ellis, Beck); with Pierre Hadot, *Philosophy as a Way of Life* (1995), on ancient philosophy as practised exercise rather than doctrine; and Don Cupitt, *Taking Leave of God* (1980), for the same reconstruction performed inside Christianity.
- Paul Stange, *The Evolution of Sumarah* (PhD dissertation, University of Wisconsin–Madison, 1980) and *Relaxed Meditation: Selected Sumarah Teachings* (1977/2001) – the insider record of practice without apparatus and of the 'relaxed meditation' ruling; with Stange, *Politik Perhatian* (LKiS, 1998), on the post-1965 treatment of atheism as communism's twin and the state pressure on mystical movements to put God first, and Robert Cribb (ed.), *The Indonesian Killings of 1965–1966* (Monash, 1990), on the massacres behind it.
- James Williams, *Stand Out of Our Light* (2018); Tristan Harris and the Center for Humane Technology; Mark van Vugt on the social-media 'supernormal stimulus'; Jenny Odell, *How to Do Nothing* (2019); and Cal Newport, *Digital Minimalism* (2019).
- On the 'nones' / 'spiritual but not religious': in the US, 29% of adults are religiously unaffiliated (Pew Research Center, *2023–24 Religious Landscape Study*, released February 2025), up from 16% in 2007, though Pew reports the rise has levelled off since about 2021. Some 22% of US

adults describe themselves as 'spiritual but not religious' (Pew, *Spirituality Among Americans,* December 2023). Globally, the religiously unaffiliated numbered about 1.9 billion in 2020, 24.2% of the world's population, up from 1.63 billion (23.3%) in 2010 (Pew, *How the Global Religious Landscape Changed from 2010 to 2020,* June 2025). Full figures and caveats are captured in research note 6.5.

8: Creating dharmas

Audio: Part 8: in search of dharma



Creating dharmas

We have always created our dharmas and told ourselves we found them. What becomes possible, and what becomes dangerous, once we admit it and start building on purpose?

A woman sits on a cushion in a small flat in a large city. A handbook of Stoic sayings lies on the floor beside her, a meditation app glows on her phone, and she is trying to assemble, from those scraps and a few others, something she can actually live by. We met her in Part 7.

Elsewhere, a team at an AI company sits down to write what it openly calls a constitution. Not a constitution for a country: a list of values for a machine, governing how it answers when a stranger asks it how to live. The company is Anthropic; the method is called 'Constitutional AI'. Anthropic trains the model to critique and revise its own responses against an explicit, plain-language list of principles, so its values sit in a document anyone can read, argue with, and rewrite. In October 2023, with the Collective Intelligence Project, it put that last verb to the test: 1,002 US American adults proposed and voted on principles for a public constitution, and the model trained on what they wrote matched the in-house version on capability and came out less biased. A thousand US American adults are not humanity, and the whose-values question never fully closes. Still, ordinary people, asked directly, set out to write a dharma on purpose, and the thing they wrote held its own.

Between those two pictures sits the whole question. The seeker on the cushion and the team at their screens are doing the same thing at wildly different scales: constructing, by hand and on purpose, an answer to how to live. A reminder from Part 1 is due here, where the word travels farthest from its Indian home: *dharma* remains this book's placeholder, and a company's constitution for a machine enters the way Part 1's rim cases did – environmentalism, the demanding professions – by what it does rather than by where the word was born. It scores where they score, hovering at the threshold: it forms no person and gathers no village. We have been heading here from the start: from the oldest root, *that which holds*, through the teak forests of Java, to the moment the old foundations gave way. For nearly all of history, the question was which inherited dharma is true and how to submit to it. Part 7 ended on her question, which is now ours: *can we build a better one, knowing what we are doing, on purpose?*

The thing we were always doing

Building dharmas on purpose is no unprecedented act of hubris. It is what our species has always done. Every dharma we have met was *made*: assembled by particular people in particular places, from the materials to

hand. The sages of the first millennium BCE made theirs. Samin Surosentiko made his, in plain low Javanese, one conversation at a time. What is new is not the making. What is new is that we can no longer pretend we are doing anything else.

For a glimpse of that making stripped to the bone, consider six teenage boys from a boarding school in Tonga who, in 1965, took a fishing boat, were caught by a storm, and washed up on ʻAta, an uninhabited Pacific rock, where they were marooned for fifteen months. What they built, with a single old knife blade and their hands, was not the savagery of William Golding's *Lord of the Flies* but its opposite. They cleared a food garden, hollowed tree trunks to catch rainwater, and kept a fire alight for more than a year, working the garden and the kitchen in rostered pairs. They opened and closed each day with song and prayer, to a driftwood guitar strung with wire salvaged from the wreck. When two quarrelled, the pair went to opposite ends of the island to cool their tempers, then came back and made up. When one boy fell from a cliff and broke his leg, the others set it with sticks and leaves and carried his share of the work until it healed. They were found in September 1966 in glowing health, the mended leg clean.

Left with nothing, the boys did not descend into a war of all against all. They rebuilt the holding from memory: rosters, ritual, a way to make peace, and care for the injured. It is one case, and they were no blank slate: they came ashore carrying the communal habits of a Tongan village and the daily rhythm of a Catholic school. But that is the point, not an objection. When human beings build a dharma 'from scratch', they build from what they remember, and what they remember is a cooperative inheritance older than any of the traditions it later hardened into. The scaffolding is not imposed on our nature. It is drawn back out of it.

I should hand that story over more carefully than I first told it, because Tongans have objected to the way it travels, and they are right. Start with the names, which the famous version tends to leave out: Tevita Siolaʻa, Sione Fataua, Luke Veikoso, Fatai Latu, Kolo Fekitoa, and Sione Totau, who

now goes by Mano. The writer Meleika Gesa, who grew up hearing this story long before the world did, notes that the celebrated retelling never quite tells it. It centres the sailor who found them, filtered through the author who 'discovered' their story, measured against a novel by yet another outsider, while the six who actually did the surviving stay out of focus. The island has a history the popular version files as scenery, too. 'Ata was emptied by slavers in the 1860s, its people seized and sold, and the boys stayed alive partly on food those stolen families had left growing. And what the six carried ashore has a name. Gesa calls it *anga fakatonga*, the Tongan way: you share from the beginning, you treat everyone as family, you survive together rather than every man for himself.

Which is the finding, stated properly. I said they rebuilt from what they remembered. What they remembered was not generic human decency but a particular dharma, carried by particular people, onto an island their own ancestors had been taken from. The case is stronger told that way, not weaker. And since this part is shortly going to argue that any ethic worth designing must keep its dissenting voices audible, it would be a poor beginning to tell one people's story straight over the top of them.

For almost all of history, the work was hidden from the workers. People built their dharmas and then experienced them as *found*: handed down from a mountaintop, woven into the order of the cosmos. That concealment was not a lie so much as a feature; a rule feels far more binding when it looks like the grain of reality than like last year's committee decision. The secular age has stripped that concealment away. We can see the workshop now. We can see that the values we live by were authored, which means, with a lurch, that they could have been authored differently, and could be again.

So the real question is not *whether* to make dharmas. We will make them whether we admit it or not; the only choice is whether to do it asleep or awake. And the conscious construction falls due just as two things of unprecedented scale bear down on us: a planet in ecological crisis, and machines that now think, into which someone is already pouring an ethic.

The biologist EO Wilson put our predicament in one devastating line: we have 'Paleolithic emotions, medieval institutions, and god-like technology'. Conscious dharma-building is the attempt to grow up the emotions and the institutions before the technology finishes the sentence.

But say out loud that dharmas can be built, and the terrible follow-up questions arrive in a rush: built by whom, for whom, toward what end, and what gets crushed in the building? Part 6 showed what the answers look like when they go wrong at full scale: a decreed cult dead in a season, the emptied city of Year Zero. The licence to build survived that part only with conditions attached: no boot, no blank slate, and the power to unbuild left with the people the dharma is for. The questions name a single recurring danger. Call it the flattening: the temptation, once the power to author an ethic exists, to author just *one* and to crush the glorious plurality of human dharmas into a single official version. And the shape of the answer can be stated now, so the tour that follows has a map: not one dharma for everyone, and not anything-goes, but a thin shared floor beneath a thick and guarded plurality. What remains is four tests of whether we can build to that shape.

A dharma for the whole Earth?

The largest scale first, where the pressure to build a single shared ethic is most intense.

Return to the Samin. At the centre of their handmade dharma sat a flat refusal: the forest, the water, the land are not anyone's to own or sell, but a commons held by everyone and no one. Stretch that conviction over the entire planet and it starts sounding like the only sane description of our situation. The atmosphere is a commons. The oceans are a commons. The stable climate that every economy takes for granted is a commons, and we are burning through it as a village burns through a shared forest when no one's dharma tells them to stop.

For the first time, the pressure comes with an instrument panel. Earth-system scientists have mapped nine 'planetary boundaries', the limits within which humanity can operate safely, and the most recent health check finds seven already crossed, ocean acidification the latest to fall: the very commons the Samin's conviction was just stretched over. That is an *is*, not an *ought*: the science can tell us where the edges are, but cannot, by itself, generate the obligation to stay inside them.

Planetary problems carry a specific cruelty. Human cooperation runs on a tribal engine: we bond fiercely *in here* in part by defining a *them* out there. But the climate crisis is the rare collective problem that excludes nobody. The tribal engine still fires, of course; climate politics manufactures enemies daily, the rich emitters and the rising ones, the deniers and the doom-mongers. The cruelty is that none of them is the enemy whose defeat would solve anything: there is no tribe outside the problem, because the species *is* the unit that has to cooperate. The hard conclusion follows from the evolutionary logic Athena Aktipis draws out: humanity has never had the shared history that would let cooperation evolve at the level of the whole species. A planetary dharma cannot be waited for; there is no competing planet to select it into being. It must be built consciously, or it will not exist at all.

What should we build? Not, I am convinced, a single global ethic. That way lies the flattening in civilisational form. The answer the evidence keeps pointing to is a *thin* shared layer over a *thick* plurality: a few commitments narrow enough to be affirmed from within many traditions. The political philosopher John Rawls called this an 'overlapping consensus': agreement reached from within very different deep worldviews, no one surrendering theirs.

And it has already happened in the open: the Earth Charter of 2000, a thoroughly secular declaration of planetary responsibility whose authority rests on the inclusive process that wrote it, and Pope Francis's *Laudato Si'* fifteen years later, insisting that 'intergenerational solidarity is not optional, but rather a basic question of justice'. Two frameworks that agree

on almost nothing about ultimate reality reach for nearly the same planetary commitments; that convergence, not an imposed creed, is the shape a planetary dharma can actually take. The political scientist Elinor Ostrom, who spent a career showing how real communities govern shared resources without privatisation or a distant boss, prescribed the same shape for the global commons: 'polycentric' governance, many local experiments coordinated toward a shared good. She warned, though, that her design principles do not scale easily to a planet that leaves no room for major error. Polycentricity was her hedge, not her triumph.

And right beside this hopeful picture stands the warning: a thick, singular, state-authored planetary ethic already exists, and it works, on the measures it chooses to count. China's doctrine of 'ecological civilization' was written into the constitution in 2018, and the programme it crowns has real results to show, including one of the largest reforestations in history. It is also, in the judgement of Mette Halskov Hansen and her colleagues, who traced its history, a model of authoritarian environmentalism: an ethic driven from the top by technocratic elites, enforced on people who do not get a say. The singular planetary dharma, in other words, is not science fiction; it can be effective; and it is the flattening itself, at work. Aktipis's own logic supplies the brake: a body does many things to regulate its own cells that no one would call ethical done to a person. A planetary dharma worth having coordinates dharmas. It does not dissolve them into one.

The ethics we hand to machines

From the planet to the machine, where the same drama plays out faster, and the temptation of the single answer wears the friendly mask of a technical solution.

Why does artificial intelligence force a dharmic question at all? In Nick Bostrom's terms, the reason is the 'orthogonality thesis': intelligence and goals are independent axes. A system can become arbitrarily more capable without becoming one inch wiser or kinder. This is the oldest wall in

moral philosophy, the *is/ought* wall that has run beneath everything here, rebuilt in silicon. You cannot compute your way from a fact to a value. Goodness has to be put in by hand, and somebody has to decide *which* goodness.

And here the flattening arrives, disguised. The standard slogan of the field is 'align AIs to human values', and that phrase smuggles in the singular. There is no *the* human values to align to, any more than there is a single *the* Dharma. Iason Gabriel names the real problem: not what values AIs should align with, but whose, chosen by what fair process. That is a political and dharmic question, not an engineering one, and pretending otherwise is how a single company's ethics, or a single state's, could quietly become the encoded conscience of the species.

The serious answers under development run against the single version, and look like the planetary solution scaled down. Stuart Russell's is the most disarming: the safest machine, he argues, is one built to be *uncertain* about what humans value, one that defers, keeps asking, and allows itself to be switched off. Anthropic's public-constitution experiment is another: a way to elicit and reconcile many value systems rather than impose one. A third, the 'moral graph' of Klingefjord, Lowe and Edelman, defines wisdom as knowing 'which values apply in which contexts' rather than as having the right answers. And, fittingly for a stance that refuses to rank traditions, Doctor, Levin and colleagues propose 'care as the driver of intelligence', a design principle drawn from the Bodhisattva vow. That plurality of approaches looks to me like a safeguard, not a defect.

But machines need more than an ethic: they threaten to dismantle one we already live inside. For generations, the West has run on a dharma so pervasive that most people never notice it is a dharma at all: the conviction that your claim to a place in the world is *finding something to do with your time that other people will pay you for*. Work has been our quiet creed of merit, status and belonging. Artificial intelligence threatens it in a new way: where the old machines came first for muscle, this one comes first for the educated professions. Economists have been mapping that reversal for

over a decade, since Carl Benedikt Frey and Michael Osborne first tried to count which occupations were exposed. The grim joke belongs to the philosopher Sam Harris, who put the reversal in one line: it comes for the celebrated technologist before your electrician. If AIs sever work from survival, that dharma loses its ground, and a new ethic, with a new economics under it, will have to be built where it stood.

The most discussed candidate for the economics is a universal basic income (UBI), a regular payment to everyone that breaks the link between earning and surviving. The idea is older than the machines: Thomas Paine argued in 1797 for a citizen's dividend as compensation for the enclosed common inheritance, making basic income less a novelty than the Samin's commons paid out in money. The oldest objection, that free money breeds idleness, has been tested from Finland to Stockton to Kenya, and, in the pilots at least, largely failed. But the pilots expose a deeper problem, dharmic rather than economic. Money can replace a wage. It cannot replace what the wage was secretly carrying: the sense of contributing, of mattering to others, what Michael Sandel calls contributive justice, the human need not merely to consume but to be needed. And David Graeber devoted a whole book to the misery of people trapped in jobs they know to be pointless; the wound, then, was never only about the scarcity of work.

Sam Harris, pressed on exactly this, waves it off: we will find status and meaning in other ways; our need for purposeful effort is just one of the 'stories we tell ourselves'. He is more right than he means to be. *A story we tell ourselves about why our lives matter* is one of the better short definitions of a dharma we have met. AIs do not abolish our need for one. They take aim at the work-shaped scaffolding that carried it, and dare us to build a replacement.

Beside all this stands the sharpest version of the flattening yet: what the philosopher William MacAskill calls 'value lock-in'. Whatever ethic gets encoded into the systems that run everything could *freeze*, foreclosing future moral progress. Pour one dharma into the machines at the wrong

moment, with enough power behind it, and the plural is not merely flattened for now. It may be flattened for keeps.

Building from old stone

Step back from planets and machines to a quieter question beneath both: out of what materials do we build these new dharmas? We build, as humans always have, from what we inherit, and the right name for a dharma built deliberately from inherited materials is *post-traditional*.

'Post-traditional' is easy to misread as 'anti-traditional'. The better gloss is *post-conventional*: a stance reached by absorbing a tradition deeply and then stepping past its unquestioned authority, not by skipping it. Stephen Batchelor gives the move its cleanest statement. He separates two things we lump together as 'religious': *ultimate concern* (Paul Tillich's phrase), the wish to come to terms with our own living and dying; and the institutional apparatus (texts, priesthood, supernatural claims) through which a tradition enacts it. A post-traditional dharma keeps the first and loosens the second. A person can be gripped by ultimate concern, Batchelor notes, without any supernatural belief at all, which is why 'devout atheists' are, in his phrase, 'not entirely joking'.

A deeper irony takes the romance out of the question. The wisdom traditions actually available to us were *already* remade by modernity: the 'Buddhism' that reached the modern West had been reshaped, long ago, to privilege reason and personal experience over ritual and authority and to speak the language of science and Western psychology, as the scholar David McMahan has shown. The fusion we imagine ourselves performing happened before we were born. 'Post-traditional' is just a better name for a process underway for over a century.

What does a well-built post-traditional dharma actually keep? A few features recur. It is *fallibilist*: its claims are revisable rather than fixed revelation, its one straight answer to the grounding problem. It is *naturalist without being scientistic*, finding genuine reverence in the natural

world without pretending science can hand us our values; the Dalai Lama's minimal version is hard to improve on: 'our own brain, our own heart is our temple; the philosophy is kindness'. It prizes *practice over doctrine*, keeping the meditation, the ritual, and the ethics that change a person, while loosening its grip on metaphysics.

It stays fully *reflexive*, aware of its own failure modes, because anything this powerful can curdle. And it counts its losses openly: the secular substitutes, the Sunday Assemblies and humanist associations, have not come close to matching the pull of the communities they set out to replace, while loneliness exacts a health toll ranked alongside smoking and obesity. On its hardest metric, community, the movement is losing, and a well-built dharma has to say so. The commune data behind Part 2 hint that the deficit may be structural: the binding power travelled with the very supernatural warrant the secular versions renounce.

That reflexiveness matters most because building from old stone has two opposite ways of betraying the plural. The shallow betrayal is the one the sociologist Robert Bellah named decades ago in a woman who described her private faith as 'Sheilaism', following her 'own little voice'. That is the spiritual supermarket: maximal personalisation, minimal substance, McMindfulness wearing a different outfit. And before we smile at Sheila: the woman on the cushion from Part 7 is one lonely year away from her; the difference has nothing to do with sincerity, only with whether the scraps ever find a community and someone to answer to.

The deep betrayal is subtler and more seductive because it looks like the height of respect: the claim that all traditions are surface expressions of one underlying truth, best boiled down to their shared essence. This is perennialism, and the philosopher Steven Katz showed why it is both false and flattening: there are no raw, unmediated mystical experiences underneath the traditions; each tradition *constructs* the experiences it produces, all the way down. Honouring traditions means honouring them as genuinely, stubbornly different, not melting them into one ecumenical paste.

And one last warning, aimed straight at those of us who feel safest here, on the secular side: a secular dharma is not automatically more rational or less dangerous than a religious one. David Sloan Wilson calls any belief system that sacrifices truth about trade-offs for the comfort of a tidy story a 'stealth religion', godless ones included, and his prime exhibit is not a church but Ayn Rand's militantly atheist Objectivism. Secular does not mean undogmatic. Building from old stone, we can lay the new bricks just as crooked as the old ones, and congratulate ourselves the whole time on having no religion.

The mirror

One more dharma is under construction that I have not yet named openly: this one. This book is not a neutral survey. It is the second stage of a project whose stated goal is to gather traceably sourced evidence about dharma so that future artificial intelligences can be given, in the project's own words, 'a solid grounding in human ethics and values, and how these are formed'. The project is itself an instance of the thing under discussion: an attempt to deliberately build a dharma and pour it into machines. It would be dishonest to warn about the flattening at this length and exempt the warning's author, so the project goes under its own microscope.

The flattening, it turns out, is not a remote risk for an encoded ethic. It is the *default*, and three mechanisms drive it there. The first was demonstrated by Delphi, a 2021 model distilled from 1.7 million human moral judgements to rule on right and wrong; it managed the easy cases, then broke, and the deepest criticism was that it had served up *descriptions* of what people approve as *prescriptions* about what is good, marching straight off the is/ought cliff. The second is colder: train an AI on data that includes the output of earlier AIs, researchers showed in *Nature* in 2024, and the model can suffer 'collapse', with the *tails* of the distribution vanishing first: the minority dharmas disappear, no ill intent required. The cure was to keep the original human data, plural and messy, in the mix. Provenance turns out to be a survival trait as well as an ethic.

The third mechanism is the most fundamental, the one that makes the danger intrinsic rather than incidental. A machine like this stores no *definitions* of dharma; it learns meaning by statistics, from the company each word keeps, as JR Firth put it: 'you shall know a word by the company it keeps'. It stores that meaning as a position in a vast space, fixed entirely by relations to everything else: Saussure's old insight, that in language 'there are only differences', rebuilt in arithmetic. Meaning built from the statistics of use has a permanent lean: the common sense of a word sits in well-worn territory, reinforced by millions of examples, while a rare or dissenting sense, a minority dharma, sits in thin territory, faintly attested, easy to slide past. The machine does not argue against an unusual dharma. It does something quieter and more total: it *means it away*, not by design but by weight of numbers. The flattening is not a bug to be patched. It is the grain of the medium: a slope everything rolls down unless something holds it.

And I cannot point at that grain as though it belonged only to future machines, because it ran through the instrument this book was written with. The book was researched by retrieval: a question goes to the corpus, and a similarity search returns the nearest few dozen passages. That machinery searches by the same arithmetic of statistical nearness, which biases it toward the most *typical* thing the shelf says. The corrective passage, the minority telling, stands farther from the canonical phrasing of any question, and is what the net is shaped to miss: the instrument I used to find the plural averages the plural away.

This is not hypothetical; it has already cost this book once. An earlier draft of Part 6 retold the famous Robbers Cave experiment in its textbook version, because that is what retrieval surfaced; the archival debunking sat in the same corpus, in a book I had curated myself, and the search sailed past it, because a correction is always rarer than the canon it corrects. A critical review caught it; the retrieval, left to itself, never would have. So the research was not allowed to rest on retrieval alone: questions were re-asked against the corpus's grain, outside sources were hunted where the

shelf was thin or one-sided, and every claim was traced by hand to a named source. Those are patches, not a cure. Weigh every page knowing that the research instrument had the same grain as the medium it has just warned you about.

An older charge, met in Part 6, applies here literally. When a Western, secular, English-language corpus catalogues the world's dharmas and prepares to pour them into machines, it repeats, *at massive scale*, the move Edward Said anatomised: assembling knowledge of other people's ways of living, from one side of an old imbalance of power, in containers the catalogued never chose. Talal Asad drove the critique to the foundations: the universal category itself, the 'religion' or 'dharma' a catalogue is built on, is a Western manufacture with a history; Part 1's defence, a disclosed tool in place of a claimed discovery, buys authorship, not innocence. The research notes behind this book press that critique by name, and good intentions do not answer it. The only answer I have found: keep the provenance, keep the dissent, keep the many voices audibly many, and say plainly whose shelf the collection sits on. The history is not reassuring: Western interpreters have reliably found in 'Dharma' whatever they brought, Kantians finding Kant, positivists finding Russell; so it must be asked whether we found 'holds without crushing' in the traditions, or brought it along.

So can the project's own goal even be coherent? Only, I think, if it gives up the usual sense of 'distil'. The right thing to hand a future machine is not a *resolved* ethic, one clean answer boiled down from the mess, but a *preserved* one: the plurality, the sources, the disagreements, above all the *reasoning* of human dharmas, kept intact. Even that is a target rather than a technique: a system holding preserved disagreement can have the disagreement itself gamed, as critics of shallow AI alignment warn. Preservation is what the method was built for: every claim carries its source, every note flags its own biases, and the gathering of evidence was deliberately separated from the writing, so the tensions survive. The best thing a corpus like this can

teach a future mind is not *what to believe* but *how human beings have come to believe in, fought over, and live their many dharmas*.

One self-criticism cannot be engineered away, and candour requires ending on it. The stance running through all of this, that all dharmas sit on the same shelf and none is privileged in advance, is *not* a view from nowhere. The phrase is Thomas Nagel's: there is no neutral standpoint above the human situation from which to rank everything else. 'Treat all dharmas as equal' is itself a substantive, recognisably modern, secular and liberal commitment, a solid dharma of its own. The project cannot climb out of its own skin: it has a point of view, and cannot encode human ethics from none. What it can do, and what I have tried to do, is name that point of view and refuse to install it as if it were simply the truth. Jorge Luis Borges imagined a map so perfect it was the same size as the territory, and therefore useless. Any compression of human ethics small enough to be useful is a choice about what to leave out, and every such choice encodes a dharma. The only sin is to make that choice while pretending it is not being made.

Plural, but not anything goes

Which brings us, at last, to the question Part 1 raised and every part since has sharpened. If dharmas are genuinely plural and none is privileged in advance, then are some of them better than others, or is it all preference, with nothing to choose between kindness and cruelty but taste? It deserves a straight answer: no, it is not.

Plurality does not mean relativism. That distinction carries the whole answer. Isaiah Berlin insisted that value pluralism is neither relativism nor absolutism. Plural values are *real*, grounded in a shared human nature; there are simply many of them, they conflict, and no single system can maximise them all at once. 'Anything goes' is a different and much lazier claim, and it collapses at the first test: it cannot condemn an atrocity, and it cannot make sense of *reform*, because the reformer who says their own society's practice is wrong (the abolitionist, the suffragist) needs a

standard *above* current custom to appeal to, which is exactly what it denies them.

So what is the standard? Not a single code that dictates how everyone must live. The structure this book keeps arriving at has appeared at every scale: a thin floor, with a teeming plurality flourishing above it. The floor is a small set of near-universal constraints: limits on cruelty and violence, and the protection of basic human capabilities. Nor is it wishful thinking: when Oliver Scott Curry tested seven rules of cooperation against the ethnographic record of sixty societies (the survey Part 1 weighed, critics included), every rule was held as morally good in all but one of nearly a thousand coded observations. A 2024 machine-reading extension to 256 societies found the same seven everywhere, though its own checks showed the software over-detecting badly enough that it widens the coverage without repairing the coding. Morality, on that evidence, is variation on a theme, exactly the shape the floor predicts.

Philosopher Martha Nussbaum gave the floor real force with her list of central human capabilities, goods any defensible way of life must let people actually achieve: life, bodily integrity, practical reason, affiliation, play. Amartya Sen, who originated the approach she built on, refused to fix any such list and kept the standard open; the floor's exact placement is unfinished business. Above the floor, real diversity stops being a problem to solve and becomes a richness to protect. Below it lies not a different valid dharma but a failed one. And that word 'failed' is a standard for criticism, not a licence to rule: crossing the floor tells us where argument, pressure and refusal are justified, not who gets to reach for the boot. The power to judge and the power to impose are different powers, and Part 6's conditions bind the second, not the first.

Before the floor is put to work, the most serious refusal of it should be heard, because it comes from the one thinker who accepted this book's premise most completely. Friedrich Nietzsche saw the plurality before almost anyone: every people, he wrote, hangs its own table of goods over itself, each table the voice of that people's will to power, and the tables are

created, not found. So far, this book's own thesis. But he then did what neither the relativist nor the floor-builder does: he ranked the tables – as symptoms, by the kind of life, ascending or declining, that produces each – while expressly refusing any floor, which he diagnosed as nothing neutral at all, merely the herd's own local morality universalising itself. That is the exact mirror of the warning this book has leaned on since Part 5 about WEIRD values dressed as universals, turned against the floor as such, and I will not pretend to dissolve it in a paragraph.

What can be stated is its price, and the scholarship states it too: his standard smuggles in a substantive aristocratic ideal while claiming to stand outside every morality; it requires rank between persons and, he did not flinch from adding, slavery in some form; and by its own symptomatology it is itself a symptom, one more table hung by one more kind of life. An option with a stated price is not a refutation. It is the standing reminder that the floor is a wager to be argued for, never a discovery to be assumed – which is exactly how this book has tried to hold it.

A floor no one has stood on is only a diagram, so let me run the test through the hardest case I own: the book's own hero. The *wong sikep* of Part 3 hold, and hold magnificently: a complete architecture for living that carried a community through an empire, a dictatorship, and a cement company without breaking. But the not-crushing side of the test has to be applied with the same rigour I asked of everyone else, and it finds two places where the holding pressed hard on the held. The first is the children. For most of a century the community refused to send its children to school, because the only school on offer was the state's, the same state that had fenced the forest and demanded the taxes; and so, in a dharma founded by an illiterate teacher, the children were kept from letters. Practical reason and education sit squarely on Nussbaum's list, and a way of life that denies its children the tools to examine it, or to leave it, presses on the floor, whatever the nobility of the reason.

I celebrated this dharma for a whole part of this book. The floor obliges me to say where the celebration must pause. The second is the women. The initiation formula that Dangir recited in 1928 defines a wife by her duty to her husband; the cosmology assimilates woman to the earth that is worked; and fieldwork in one Blora village reports a domestic order in which Sikep women remain plainly subordinate. And yet it was nine women of the Kendeng farming communities, Sikep among them, who put their feet in cement at the palace gate, on ground the Sikep dharma had prepared. Both facts are true at once, and they must be held together: the tradition made the heroine possible, and prescribed the wife.

So does the keystone case pass the test this book has just built? Not cleanly, and that is what the floor is for. It hands down no verdict of good or evil; it locates the places where the arguing has to happen, and here it found them precisely: the children and the women. After independence, the refusal of schooling softened; the education studies report that from this century most Sikep children have gone to school; and some communities, still declining the state's classroom, have built their own curriculum instead, teaching their ecology on their own terms. The hardest edge was adjusted, from inside, without the dharma losing itself. That is what it looks like when the people a dharma binds keep the power to revise it, and it is why the floor is a tool for living traditions, not a tribunal for dead ones.

The whole standard extends the phrase we began with. A dharma is to be judged by how well it *holds without crushing*. The holding is the floor's positive side: does it actually gather a human life and a community, give them shape, meaning and the strength to endure? The not-crushing is its protective side: does it gather without breaking the people inside it or the strangers outside it? A dharma that holds but crushes is the tyranny-and-purity spiral of Part 6; one that refuses to crush but cannot hold is the thin gruel of Part 7, the patchwork that never quite binds. The good ones do both. They hold firmly enough to give a life its spine, and loosely enough to leave room for other lives, and other dharmas, to do the same.

That is the answer to whether some are better: yes. The better ones hold without crushing, remain revisable by the people they bind, and leave the door open for their neighbours.

Berlin would add a caution: the standard identifies failures but does not rank successes, because above the floor the goods genuinely conflict. Everything up there is still to argue about, and WB Gallie, whom we met in Part 1, explained why it never stops: some concepts (justice, democracy, and surely dharma) are *essentially contested*, disputed from the inside as part of how they work. That endless argument is not the failure of the project. It *is* the project.

That which holds

We have come the whole way round. We started with a word we thought meant incense and inner peace, and we followed it down to a plain and sturdy root: *dharma*, that which holds, the beam that keeps the roof up, the thing that keeps a life, or a world, from chaos. Dharmas are what hold human beings together. There are many of them. They are made, not found. And the making has now become conscious, and urgent, and ours.

For all of history we built the things that hold us and then knelt before them as if we had received them. That age is ending, not because we grew wiser but because the concealment wore through. We can see the workshop now, and we are being handed the tools at a demanding moment: a planet that needs some shared and gentle holding to come through its crisis, and a new kind of mind into which we will pour some ethic or other, on purpose or by neglect. The temptation, now of all moments, will be to reach for the single answer, the one official dharma, the machine-readable verdict that ends the messy argument. That temptation is the one thing the whole argument stands against. The plurality is not the problem to be solved on the way to the answer. The plurality *is* the answer, fenced by a thin floor that forbids only cruelty and demands only that the holding not become a crushing.

None of us gets to opt out of having a dharma; each of us is running one right now, chosen or not, and nowhere along the way have we met a human life that holds together without one. The only real choice is whether we run them asleep or awake. To practise a dharma awake is to know that it is made and not found, to know that it is one good way among other good ways, to hold it firmly enough that it actually holds us, and lightly enough that it never has to crush anyone else to do its work. The woman on the cushion, alone with her scraps, has been doing that work all along; what she lacks is not sincerity but company. We have always been choosing what holds us. Now we get to do it on purpose, with our eyes open. That is not a smaller task than the old religions set themselves. And it is, at last, openly ours.

« 7: Dharmas in a secular age | 9: Coda »

Sources & further reading

This part is built from the project's research notes, which carry the full inline citations. Listed here: the notes it draws on, and the key works behind them.

Research notes

Research notes used in this book are published on GitHub – https://github.com/Biksu-Okusi/In-Search-of-Dharma.

- 8.1 Planetary Dharma – the no-out-group problem; thin-over-thick; authored not evolved; polycentric governance; the totalising temptation.
- 8.2 AI & Dharma – orthogonality; 'whose values'; pluralistic alignment; economic disempowerment, UBI and the meaning it cannot buy; value lock-in.
- 8.3 Post-Traditional Dharmas – post-conventional, not anti-traditional; the constructive features; the two flattening failure modes; 'stealth religion'; the community deficit.
- 8.4 Encoding Dharma into Machines – the project under its own microscope; the flattening as default; the retrieval loop (the book's own research instrument as a majority-seeking device, with the Robbers Cave miss as the documented instance); encode the map and the argument, not the verdict.
- 8.5 Dharma from Scratch: The 'Ata Case – the 1965 'Ata shipwreck as real-world evidence that stripped-down groups rebuild a cooperative order; the Robbers Cave correction; the 'social suite' and Pitcairn as counter-case.
- 7.7 Dharma by Decree: The Engineered-Dharma Failure Mode – the Part 6 stress-test this part's licence rests on: the Jacobin cults, the New Soviet Man, Year Zero, and the conditions that survive them (no boot, no blank slate, the unbuilding power retained).
- 4.1 Samin of Java – the floor's worked hard case: the schooling refusal and its post-independence softening, the gendered cosmology and the

patriarchal domestic order, and the Kartini Kendeng's within-tradition agency.
- 3.4 Relativism vs Universalism – pluralism is not relativism; the thin floor, thick variation; 'holds without crushing'; Nietzsche's ranking-without-a-floor as the standing challenge.
- 7.4 Measurement & Falsifiability – the is/ought wall; provenance is not truth; the project's own evidentiary bar.
- 7.5 Orientalism – Said's knowledge-power critique and its limits, turned on this project's own corpus-and-machine ambition; the projection-screen history behind the Mirror.

Key works

- Y Bai et al., 'Constitutional AI: Harmlessness from AI Feedback' (2022, arXiv:2212.08073) – the machine's values as an explicit, readable, rewritable document.
- Saffron Huang, Divya Siddarth et al., 'Collective Constitutional AI: Aligning a Language Model with Public Input' (ACM FAccT 2024, DOI 10.1145/3630106.3658979) – the public-constitution experiment of the opening: ~1,000 US Americans, Polis, 1,127 statements, 38,252 votes; the publicly trained model matched on capability with lower bias.
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- Elinor Ostrom, *Governing the Commons* (1990), and DS Wilson, E Ostrom & ME Cox, 'Generalizing the core design principles' (*JEBO*, 2013) – polycentric self-governance against Garrett Hardin's 'Tragedy of the Commons' (1968); her own warning that the principles do not easily scale to a single fragile planet.
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Coda

Audio: Part 9: in search of dharma



What is dharma?

Eight parts of searching have earned one plain definition and two tests. So here they are, stated rather than argued: what a dharma is, and how to tell the better ones.

A **dharma** is a way of living that tells a person or group how to act, what to value, what to avoid, and what kind of person is worth trying to become.

A dharma is not necessarily a religion. It is a **living ethical orientation**: a pattern of values, habits, stories, duties, practices and social expectations that helps humans navigate the world. Most dharmas are inherited half-consciously and never feel chosen at all; a few are examined, reformed, or built on purpose. The word describes what a thing *does*, not how well: gentle and cruel, living and hollowed, all are dharmas. Whether one is any good is a separate question, answered below.

At its deepest level, a dharma is **that which holds a life, a community, or a world together**.

There is no single 'the Dharma'

It is better to say **a dharma** than **the Dharma**, because human beings create many dharmas.

And the word itself is a placeholder. Every culture builds the thing and names it in its own tongue: *Ubuntu*, *ma'at*, and *Tao* are not translations of *dharma* but sibling names for sibling instances. The Sanskrit is kept because, of all the candidates, its root says most plainly what the thing does: hold.

A Buddhist dharma, a Hindu dharma, a scientific-rationalist dharma, a warrior dharma, an environmental dharma, a professional dharma, a family dharma, a personal dharma: all of these are candidates. But coherence alone does not make a dharma. What marks one off from mere custom, law, or etiquette is a combination of four features:

- **Comprehensive** – it governs a whole life, or a whole domain of one, not a single slice of behaviour.
- **Identity-constituting** – it binds from the inside, by conviction, and works to remake its carrier.
- **Oriented toward the good** – an answer to how one *ought* to live, as its carriers conceive it, not a strategy for getting ahead.

- **Reflectively self-aware** – it can be held up and known *as* a path: named, questioned, reformed.

The features come in degrees; a profession, a subculture, an environmentalism may carry two or three, and sit near the rim.

Religious dharmas do not have automatic privilege over secular ones. All dharmas can be studied as human cultural systems for answering the same practical question:

How should we live?

The question is shared. The answers are not: they differ all the way down, about what a person is, what time is, and what the world rests on.

What a dharma contains

A dharma usually includes:

- **Values** – what matters.
- **Ethics** – what is appropriate or inappropriate.
- **Practices** – what one repeatedly does.
- **Stories** – why life is this way.
- **Duties** – what one owes to self, others, community, or world.
- **Community** – whom one belongs to, and who holds one to the path.
- **Identity** – who 'we' are, or who 'I' am trying to become.
- **Discipline** – how one trains conduct, attention, speech, desire, and response.
- **Transmission** – how the way is handed on: by story, example, drill, and correction.

A dharma is more than an idea: it becomes real through behaviour. It is embodied in how one speaks, works, eats, raises children, handles conflict, treats strangers, responds to suffering, and uses power.

Why humans need dharmas

Humans are cooperative primates with dangerous capacities: love and cruelty, loyalty and tribal hatred, care and domination, imagination and self-deception.

A dharma helps regulate these forces. It gives structure to conduct, makes people more predictable to one another, and helps groups coordinate, reduce conflict, transmit wisdom, and preserve meaning across generations.

In this sense, a dharma is a kind of **ethical software** running on human biological hardware.

It does not erase our animal nature. It trains it.

And none of this survives on its own. Every carrier of a dharma dies, so a dharma persists only by reproducing itself in new people: taught by story and example, grooved in by practice and repetition, held in place by a community that notices when it slips. The funeral is where that shows most plainly: the rite that sends one carrier off is the one that reseats the rest. Call it education, in the broadest sense, so long as the word is allowed to include all of that; explicit instruction is the smallest part of it, and most of the teaching happens below argument, which is why a dharma feels inherited rather than chosen. A dharma that cannot reproduce itself dies with the people who hold it, however wise it was.

And no dharma is built from nothing. New dharmas emerge from within the cultures and communities that carry their makers, and they inherit the materials of those cultures, the worse along with the better. The craft lies in choosing what deserves to go on holding.

How a dharma survives translation

A dharma can be carried out of its old cosmology, and the record holds both successes and husks. The translations that keep their transforming power do three things. They keep the **whole bundle**: practice, ethics and community together, never the soothing technique alone. They put some **this-worldly replacement** in the place the old metaphysics held: something that still binds, still motivates, still endures. And they remain a **way of life one practises**, rather than a worldview one merely holds. Do all three and a dharma can survive the loss of its gods. Keep only the soothing technique, and the result is a product.

The two tests

Holding is not by itself goodness, and *plural* is not the same as *equal*. A dharma is judged by two tests.

The first is substantive: **the better dharmas hold without crushing**. They gather a life or a community into shape and meaning without breaking the people inside them or the strangers outside them. A dharma that holds but crushes is a tyranny; one that refuses to crush but cannot hold is a mood.

The second is procedural, and it is the keystone: **dharmas are better to the extent they remain revisable by the people bound by them**. Not revisable by guardians alone, and not reformed from outside, however enlightened the outsiders: revisable by the bound. Dharmas are made things, and an unrevisable dharma is a made thing pretending to be found. The first test asks what a dharma does. The second asks who holds the pen.

Not everything that holds deserves to keep holding. These two tests are how to tell.

A personal dharma

A personal dharma is the way an individual consciously chooses to live. But it is never made alone: even the most personal dharma is built from inherited language, examples, communities, obligations and refusals, and it needs company, and someone to answer to, if it is to be more than a private mood.

It is not necessarily a mystical destiny or a fixed 'life purpose'. It is more like a cultivated path: a way of accepting reality, responding to difficulty, reducing unnecessary harm, and leaving the place a little better held than one found it.

A mature personal dharma asks:

> What do I care about above all else?
>
> What kind of person do I become through my repeated actions?
>
> What do my habits actually serve?
>
> Does my way of living reduce suffering or increase it?
>
> Does it help only me, or does it help us?

The question that dissolves

For readers who came from the secular-dharma world carrying its standing worry (is what we practise still Buddhism? is it really a dharma?): the eight parts behind this page dissolve the question rather than answer it. Dharmas are made, plural, and revisable. The living questions are the ones above: what are we building, does it hold without crushing, and who holds the pen?

> **A dharma is a way of living that holds a person or a people together. The better ones hold without crushing, and leave the pen in the hands of those held.**

Sources & further reading

This coda states in miniature what Parts 1–8 argue and source in full; it introduces no new claims. The four features and the placeholder rule are Part 1's; the disagreement among the answers is Part 4's; the point about reproduction condenses Part 2's storytelling and Part 5's installation machinery; the translation rule is Part 7's; the two tests are stated at the end of Part 8 and defended at full length in the appendix that follows, Dharmas: the better ones, *which is also published with the research notes on* GitHub ***– https://github.com/Biksu-Okusi/In-Search-of-Dharma****.*

Appendix: Dharmas, the better ones

Throughout *in search of dharma* I have insisted that dharmas are *made*, plural, and unprivileged: no single *The* Dharma, no view from nowhere, no tradition seated above the others in advance. And then, having said all that, I have gone on using the word 'better'. Better dharmas, worse ones, failed ones. A reader is entitled to stop me here and ask the obvious question: 'better? *by what standard*?' If you refuse to privilege any dharma, what exactly are you measuring them against?

Part 8 answers this, but it answers it six hundred words from the end of a longish book, after eight parts of preparation. A standard that matters should also be stated where it can be examined on its own, attacked on its own, and cited on its own. So here it is, whole.

A dharma is to be judged by two tests.

The first is substantive: **a dharma is better the more fully it holds without crushing**. The better ones gather human lives into shape and meaning without breaking the people inside them or the strangers outside them.

The second is procedural, and it is the keystone: **dharmas are better to the extent they remain revisable by the people bound by them.**

The first test asks what a dharma does. The second asks who holds the pen. The rest of this essay defends each, explains why the second is more than one more item on the first's list, and then meets the strongest objections I know of, including the ones I cannot fully answer.

Plural is not equal

Begin with the accusation this whole book exists to answer: that a project which privileges no dharma has thereby forfeited the right to judge any, and that 'unprivileged' is just relativism under another name.

It is not, and the distinction is not a technicality. Isaiah Berlin spent a career on it: value pluralism is an alternative to *both* relativism and absolutism. The many values that human communities build their lives around are real, grounded in a shared human nature; there are simply more of them than any single way of life can hold at once, and they genuinely conflict. That is a different claim, and a far stronger one, than 'anything goes'. Relativism collapses at the first two tests you put to it. It cannot condemn an atrocity, since the atrocity is somebody's custom. And it cannot make sense of *reform*: the abolitionist and the suffragist both said that their own society's settled practice was wrong, which requires a standard standing above settled practice, which is precisely what relativism denies them. Any account of dharmas that makes reformers impossible has disqualified itself. Every tradition in this book has had its reformers.

Disagreement proves less than it seems to. That cultures disagree about a norm is a fact about acceptance, not about bindingness; 'many people permit recreational cruelty' and 'recreational cruelty is permissible' are claims of different kinds, and the first has never entailed the second. Descriptive plurality leaves the question of standards exactly where it found it.

So: plural, yes; equal, no. The question is what the standard is.

The first test: holds without crushing

The shape the evidence keeps converging on, at every scale this project has examined, is a thin floor with thick plurality above it.

The floor is a small set of near-universal constraints: limits on cruelty and violence, and the protection of basic human capabilities. This is not wishful cosmopolitanism. When Oliver Scott Curry's team tested seven rules of cooperation against the ethnographic record of sixty societies, every rule was held as morally good in all but one of nearly a thousand observations (a 2024 machine-reading extension to 256 societies found the same seven, with validation weak enough that it widens coverage without repairing the coding); human morality, on that evidence, is variation on a theme, which is the architecture the floor predicts. Martha Nussbaum gave the floor teeth with her list of central human capabilities, the goods any defensible way of life must let the people inside it actually achieve: life, bodily integrity, practical reason, affiliation, play, and the rest. Amartya Sen, who originated the approach she built on, refused to fix any such list.

Above the floor, diversity stops being a problem and becomes a richness. Below it lies not a different-but-valid dharma but a failed one. And a dharma can fail the first test in two opposite directions. It can hold *and* crush: the tyranny-and-purity spiral of Part 6, the order that gathers its people magnificently and grinds them. Or it can refuse to crush and fail to hold: the thin gruel of Part 7, the curated patchwork that never binds a community or carries a life through grief. The good ones do both jobs at once. They hold firmly enough to give a life its spine, and loosely enough that other lives, and other dharmas, have room to do the same.

Two cautions come with this test, the first of them Berlin's. The floor identifies failures; it does not rank successes. Above the line the goods conflict, and where values are incommensurable there will be ties and tragic trade-offs, not a league table. And the judging power is not the imposing power: knowing that a dharma has fallen through the floor tells us where argument, pressure and refusal are justified. It tells us nothing about who may enforce that judgement, or how. Those are different powers, and Part 6's conditions on intervention bind the second, not the first.

The problem the first test cannot solve

Now the real difficulty: the floor needs placing, and every placement is made by someone, from somewhere.

Sen's refusal to fix the list is usually read as a technical dispute with Nussbaum inside one school. I think it is much more than that. It is the recognition that a fixed floor, specified once and for all, is somebody's thick dharma at the moment of fixing, and the fixer is never a view from nowhere. One tradition's obvious floor (gender equality, say, or individual rights of exit) is another's imposition; the hard cases sit exactly on the line, and this project's own research notes flag, repeatedly, the trap of mistaking one's local dharma for the universal threshold. The charge lands on this book too. Western interpreters have reliably found in other people's dharmas whatever they carried in: Kantians finding Kant, positivists finding Russell. Did we find 'holds without crushing' in the traditions, or bring it along?

The usual escape routes fail. Hand the placement to experts, and you have built a priesthood; the floor is then whatever the credentialed say it is, which is capture with footnotes. Hand it to an overlapping consensus of the traditions, the common ground they already share, and you do better, but you freeze the floor at the moment of overlap; consensus is a snapshot, and snapshots yellow over time.

The way out is not a cleverer placement. It is to change what kind of thing the standard demands: not the *correct* position of the floor, but a floor whose position remains permanently contestable by the people standing on it. Which is to say, the first test cannot stand on its own. It needs the second.

The second test: who holds the pen

This sentence needs repeating: dharmas are *better* to the extent they remain revisable by the people bound by them.

Revisable: the capacity must actually exist, not as a myth of origin ('our founder once changed things') but as a living organ. *By the people*: not by guardians alone. A dharma whose revision is monopolised by its priesthood, its politburo or its board is not revisable in the relevant sense; it is revisable the way a locked room is ventilated, from the outside, at the discretion of whoever holds the key. *Bound by them*: the test is indexed to the held, not the onlookers. Reform imposed wholesale from outside fails it too, however enlightened; that is the coloniser's shortcut.

The clearest statement of the underlying principle in this project's corpus is a century and a half old. Bakunin, asked whether rejecting imposed authority meant rejecting all authority, answered: far from it. 'In the matter of boots, I refer to the authority of the bootmaker'. He consults the architect and the *savant*, listens freely and with respect, 'reserving always my incontestable right of criticism and censure'. What he refuses is not authority; it is authority he cannot revoke. There is, he concludes, 'no fixed and constant authority, but a continual exchange of mutual, temporary, and, above all, voluntary authority and subordination'. That is the second test in one sentence, written in 1871. Transmission always requires authority. The bootmaker's principle does not abolish teachers. It denies them tenure over the taught.

Why should *this* be the keystone, rather than one virtue among several? Because it is the only part of the standard that follows from the project's own central finding. Dharmas are made, not found: that claim has been the spine of this book since Part 1. And if made, then made by people who err, in circumstances that pass. An unrevisable dharma is therefore a made thing pretending to be found. To forbid revision by the bound, a dharma must claim that its shape was fixed elsewhere: by heaven, by blood, by history's verdict, by the founder's unrepeatable genius. It must, in short, lie about its own origins, and institutionalise the lie. The concealment this book exists to dismantle (building the things that hold us and then kneeling before them as if we had received them) is not merely error.

Enforced, it is the mechanism of every catastrophe in Part 6. Revisability is honesty about origins, given a constitutional form.

I did not reason my way to this in one step. The criterion converged from three directions before it was ever stated as one sentence. Part 8's verdict already carries it as a clause ('remain revisable by the people they bind'). The research note on relativism (3.4) had, independently, listed 'self-correcting and non-oppressive' among its criteria. And the note on engineered dharmas (7.7), after walking through the Jacobin cults, the New Soviet Man and Year Zero, ended its licence to build with the condition that matters: *the power to unbuild kept in the hands of the built-for*. Three separate investigations, three routes to the same clause.

The tests at work

Run the tests across the cases this project has already put in evidence, and the second test repeatedly sees what the first one squints at.

The *wong sikep* of Part 3, the book's own hero and its hardest case. On the first test they pass with two pauses, set down here plainly: the children long kept from letters, the wife defined by her duty. It is the second test they pass outright. The schooling refusal softened after independence; some communities built their own curriculum rather than accept the state's or abandon the principle; the hardest edge was adjusted from inside, without the dharma losing itself. The pen stayed in the village. That is what revisability looks like when it is lived rather than proclaimed, and it is why this tradition could come as close to the floor as it did and still stand.

The engineered dharmas fail the second test before the first can even be scored. The Cult of the Supreme Being, the New Soviet Man, Year Zero: in each, an ethic was authored at the centre and enforced downward, and the one power never distributed was the power to write back. The atrocities differ; the pen-monopoly is constant.

China's 'ecological civilization' doctrine is the instructive modern case precisely because it embarrasses the first test. Written into the constitution in 2018, it holds, it coordinates, and it delivers real results, including one of history's largest reforestations, on the measures it chooses to count. Mette Halskov Hansen and her colleagues, who traced its history, call it authoritarian environmentalism: an ethic driven by technocratic elites, enforced on people who do not get a say. The first test hesitates, because the thing plainly functions. The second does not hesitate at all.

The corporate culture-by-decree, the same failure in a minor key: values authored in a workshop, laminated, and cascaded to people who must live them but may not amend them. Revisable, certainly: by the board, at the next rebrand. Revisable by the bound, no. That the regime is a comfortable one does not change who may amend it.

And the machines, since they are where this project is ultimately headed. Delphi, the 2021 model distilled from 1.7 million moral judgements, was in effect a dharma with no revision organ at all: a frozen verdict machine, wrong the way an oracle is wrong, with no path by which the judged could talk back. Whereas a constitution for a machine, an explicit, readable, rewritable document stating the values it is trained toward, is at least the right *shape*: the pen exists, the text is public, revision is procedurally possible. The second test then asks its question anyway: revisable by *whom*? By the lab that wrote it, or by the people increasingly bound by it? The plain answer today is the former, with experiments (1,002 US American adults drafting a public constitution, in one trial) probing toward the latter.

The objections

'You brought it along.' The sharpest objection says revisability is just liberalism smuggled in as a meta-standard: one more Western thick dharma flattering itself that it is a neutral referee.

Half of this must simply be conceded. The criterion is a commitment, not a discovery; there is no view from nowhere, this project has one point of view like everything else, and an avowed commitment is the only defensible kind. But the other half should be resisted, because the criterion is thinner than the liberalism it is accused of being. It demands no elections, no individualism, no rights-talk, no separation of powers. It demands only that the capacity to revise exist and sit with the bound, and traditions have built that organ in forms liberalism would not recognise as its own. *Musyawarah*, deliberation toward consensus, is a revision organ. *Ijtihad*, the labour of fresh interpretation in Islamic law, is a revision organ, and the centuries-long argument over whether its 'gate' ever closed is itself an argument about this very criterion, conducted entirely inside the tradition. The *wong sikep* revised a refusal most of a century old without a ballot in sight.

What the criterion does refuse is narrower and starker: any dharma whose self-understanding *requires* that the bound never touch it. A genuinely closed orthodoxy will experience this standard as an attack. It is.

Nietzsche's challenge. The fiercest counter-voice in this book's sources deserves his turn, because he is the most serious attempt in the tradition to do what I have said cannot be done: rank dharmas with *no floor at all*. Every people hangs its table of goods over itself, he says, and the tables are created, not found. So far, this book's own thesis. But he then ranks the tables as symptoms, by the kind of life, ascending or declining, that produces each, and expressly refuses the floor, which he diagnoses as the herd's own local morality universalising itself.

The challenge is real and I will not pretend to dissolve it in a paragraph. I will state its price, which the scholarship states too: the standard 'what kind of life it produces' smuggles in a substantive aristocratic ideal while claiming to stand outside all moralities, and by its own method it is itself a symptom.

An option with a stated price does not refute the floor. It stands as a reminder that the floor must be argued for, never assumed. That is, again, why the pen matters more than the placement.

'Revisability just measures churn.' No. The criterion names a capacity, not a rate. A dharma may stand substantially unchanged for a century and pass, because the bound held the pen throughout and chose, year after year, not to use it; consent renewed is not stagnation. Another may change every quarter and fail, because every change was the centre's. What is measured is where the capacity lives, not how often it is exercised. A grip you cannot open is not a hold; it is a trap – and the test for a trap is not whether it is currently moving.

'Can a dharma revise itself shut?' Yes, and the paradox is more apparent than real. A community may use its living revision organ to weld the hatch: entrench a canon, close a gate, criminalise the question. The criterion does not forbid this in advance, and it does not need to. It is a test applied to the dharma as it now stands, not a licence granted in perpetuity to whatever the dharma once was. The community that froze itself by a free act is now a frozen community; the freedom of the welding does not unweld the hatch. Popper saw the same structure in tolerance, and the resolution is the same: the standard judges states, not pedigrees.

'Who are the bound, when the bound cannot speak?' The criterion indexes revision to the people a dharma binds, and my worked cases quietly assume those people are adults with voices. Most of the bound are not. Every dharma binds children first and hardest, in the years before examining it is possible; that is what the installation machinery of Part 5 is *for*. Many bind the dead, whose vows and bequests persist. Some bind the unborn explicitly, as the Seven Generations teaching does, and the ecological dharmas bind rivers and forests that will never hold any pen.

For each of these, the test must convert or confess. For the children it converts into a demand about equipment and exit: a dharma passes only insofar as it gives the child the tools to examine it and the realistic

possibility of leaving it, which is what the *wong sikep* schooling case was about, and why its revision mattered so much. For the dead it converts into a denial of tenure: their pen passed to the living at the grave, and a bequest is honoured as an inheritance, not obeyed as a command.

For the unborn and the more-than-human the test can only be held in trust, and there the criterion must confess its limit: every trustee is a proxy with interests of its own, 'speaking for the river' is a role that capture loves, and the most the second test can demand is that the trusteeship itself remain revisable by the living who share the binding. That is thinner than I would like, and I will not dress it up. It is the outer edge of the standard: the second test is strongest exactly where the bound can answer back, and weakest where they never can – which is a reason to keep widening who can answer back, not a licence to hand the pen to whoever claims to speak for the silent.

The is/ought wall. Finally, the objection this project's own note 7.4 built into the foundations. Nothing above is *derived* from the ethnography. Curry's sixty societies show that the floor's shape recurs; recurrence is not obligation, and no count of cultures ever crossed the gap from is to ought. The *wong sikep*'s revision shows that the criterion can be lived; that it can be does not prove that it must be. Both tests are wagers: disclosed, argued, and revisable, but wagers. Provenance is not truth. The most this essay claims is that these are the best-argued wagers the evidence allows, staked in the open, by an author who can be wrong.

Held, not trapped

The word this whole project grew from means *that which holds*. The standard, in the end, only spells out what the root already said. The first test asks whether the holding is real and whether it has become a crushing. The second asks the question that tells traps apart from holds: whether the held could loosen the grip, and stayed.

So, in one breath: the better dharmas hold firmly, crush no one – and keep the pen in the hands of those held. That the argument never ends is not a flaw; it is the standard, applied to itself.

Sources & further reading

A companion essay, not a research note: it argues from cases already presented in In search of dharma *and its research notes, and carries no inline citations. The notes closest to it: 3.4 Relativism vs Universalism (Berlin, Curry, Nussbaum and Sen, the relativism taxonomy, the Nietzsche challenge); 7.7 Dharma by Decree (the engineered cases and the 'power to unbuild' condition); 7.4 Measurement & Falsifiability (the is/ought wall and the project's evidentiary bar). The substantive test is argued in full, with the* wong sikep *worked case, at the end of Part 8 of* In search of dharma*. The criterion sentence itself (dharmas are better to the extent they remain revisable by the people bound by them) is the author's, and is offered under the same terms as everything else here: revisable.*

Key works

- Isaiah Berlin, 'Two Concepts of Liberty' (1958) and *The Crooked Timber of Humanity* (1990) – value pluralism as the alternative to both relativism and absolutism; incommensurable goods above the floor.
- Oliver Scott Curry, Daniel Austin Mullins & Harvey Whitehouse, 'Is It Good to Cooperate? Testing the Theory of Morality-as-Cooperation in 60 Societies' (*Current Anthropology*, 2019) – the sixty-society test behind the floor's shape; with Mark Alfano, Marc Cheong & Oliver Scott Curry, 'Moral universals: A machine-reading analysis of 256 societies' (*Heliyon*, 2024), the extension and its own weak validation.
- Martha Nussbaum, *Women and Human Development* (2000) – the ten central human capabilities; and Amartya Sen, 'Capabilities, Lists, and Public Reason' (*Feminist Economics*, 2004) – the refusal to fix the list.
- Mikhail Bakunin, *God and the State* (written 1871, published posthumously 1882) – the bootmaker passage; authority without tenure over the taught.
- Martine & Stephen Batchelor, Q+A session with the Tuwhiri *What is this?* reading group (26 July 2026) – the criterion reached independently from inside the secular-dharma world: communities needing 'some sort of safeguard against becoming orthodoxies and

institutions' while letting their members 'flourish as autonomous persons'; and the stream-enterer as *aparapaccaya*, independent of others – a Pali anchor for the bootmaker's principle.

- Friedrich Nietzsche, *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, 'The Thousand and One Goals' (1883), and *Beyond Good and Evil* (1886) – ranking without a floor; the challenge met here at its stated price.
- Karl Popper, *The Open Society and Its Enemies*, vol. 1 (1945) – the paradox of tolerance; standards that judge states, not pedigrees.
- Wael B Hallaq, 'Was the Gate of Ijtihad Closed?' (*International Journal of Middle East Studies*, 1984) – the centuries-long tradition-internal argument over a revision organ.
- Mette Halskov Hansen, Hongtao Li & Rune Svarverud, 'Ecological civilization: Interpreting the Chinese past, projecting the global future' (*Global Environmental Change*, 2018) – authoritarian environmentalism and the 2018 constitutional amendment.
- L Jiang et al., 'Can Machines Learn Morality? The Delphi Experiment' (arXiv:2110.07574, 2021) – the frozen verdict machine.
- Anthropic & the Collective Intelligence Project, 'Collective Constitutional AI: Aligning a Language Model with Public Input' (2023) – the thousand-participant constitution trial.

Colophon

in search of dharma

What holds a life, a people, a world together

A natural history of ethics

by **Biksu Okusi**

This ebook was typeset from Markdown with pandoc, in the Bona Nova and Work Sans typefaces. The cover and chapter illustrations are watercolour-style images generated with AI:grok-imagine-image-quality, from prompts written, iterated, and selected by the author.

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IN SEARCH OF DHARMA

You use the word. Almost everyone does — on yoga studios, paperback spines, meditation apps. Now try to define it.

Strip away three thousand years of religion and philosophy and *dharma* means something startlingly plain: *that which holds*. Not incense — a load-bearing beam. The thing that keeps a life, a people, a world from falling apart. And once you see that, a harder truth follows: there was never a single Dharma handed down from the sky. There are only dharmas, plural — built by human beings, over and over, wherever we appear. Which means they can be built again. Someone, right now, is deciding which one to pour into the machines.

In Search of Dharma follows the word from its Sanskrit root to the first crowded cities, from an illiterate Javanese farmer who assembled an entire ethical world in a teak forest to nine women who set their feet in wet cement at a presidential palace to defend it. Along the way it asks the uncomfortable questions: why every dharma's failures are its strengths turned inside out, whether an ethic can still bind without a god behind it, and whether we can now build one deliberately, with our eyes open, without crushing anyone inside it.



Biksu Okusi comes from neither the monastery nor the university: raised on the remote western rim of Australia, he is a naturalised Indonesian citizen writing from Bali. He built this book on forty years of reading, three decades inside Indonesian society, and a knowledgebase of fifteen thousand curated documents, every claim traceable to its source. You are not asked to trust him. You are asked to follow the links.